

NEW DELHI,
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(₹8 RAIPUR,
₹15 SRINAGAR)

The Sunday EXPRESS



EYE Wind in her Hair

Women in India are riding further, faster and in greater numbers. What holds them together is the sense of community, not choosing just a destination but a direction

SCREEN

At his centenary celebrations, unpacking Uttam Kumar's appeal



DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

AMID ROW OVER OBJECTIONS BY ELECTION COMMISSIONERS TO SIR-RELATED DECISIONS AND GAPS IN PROCESSES

Disquiet within, all three Election Commissioners meet, take first steps

Unmapped voters need not attend hearings, ECINet to get a review

Damini Nath
New Delhi, September 26

IN ITS first meeting since *The Indian Express* reported on the deep divide within the Election Commission over the past 10 months, the poll panel on Saturday sought to address several concerns raised by its two commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi.

Electors who were issued notices for "logical discrepancies" and for being "unmapped" in the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls will not be required to attend hearings to establish their eligibility, a statement issued by the ECI said.

This exemption from in-person hearings will be a relief to lakhs of electors who were issued notices in the ongoing SIR. The decision comes as

hearings are being held across states on the basis of system-generated notices.

"Unmapped" voters are those whose names did not figure in the rolls of the previous intensive revision, and who were unable to provide the names of their parents or grandparents too during that revision. "Logical discrepancies" refers to certain discrepancies flagged by the ECI's centralised software based on which voters are issued notices following which they need to submit additional documentary proof to stay in the rolls.

"In case of any person to whom notice has been issued during the ongoing SIR, for being unmapped and logical discrepancies, BLOs will visit the homes of such persons for collection of documents and thereafter upload them on the



CEC Gyanesh Kumar with ECs Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi in New Delhi, Saturday. X/@ECISVEEP

• KEY DECISIONS BY COMMISSION

CONCERNS ON ECINET: 'Centralisation of electoral rolls'; Officers backed by law not getting proper access to ERONet

ECI: A committee headed by Sr Deputy Election Commissioner and including an independent expert will review the ECINET

CONCERN ON 'LOGICAL DISCREPANCIES': ECI filing appeals against voters who were first flagged for 'logical discrepancies'

by it, but then included by judicial officers in the SIR.

ECI: BLOs will visit homes to collect documents from those issued notices during ongoing SIR for being unmapped and for logical discrepancies, and upload them on ECINET for decision by ERO

CONCERN ON 'ADDITION TO FORM 6': Additions to Form 6 linking new voter registration to SIR is 'illegal, unauthorised'. Cannot be

made unless govt amends rules.

ECI: For non-SIR period, the forms applicable as per Rules (the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960) will be used

CONCERNS ON issues such as conduct of meetings, permissions, directions by Commission

ECI: Agenda will be circulated in advance and minutes will be issued for all Commission meetings; all directions issued by the Commissioners to officers shall be complied with

INSIDE

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'WISHY-WASHY' NOTE IS DAMAGE CONTROL, SAYS CONGRESS

BJP RALLIES BEHIND EC: 'RAHUL SHOULD EXPLAIN WHY HE LIED'

ECINET, for decision by the ERO. Such persons need not be called for hearing to ERO/AERO office. Only in exceptional circumstances, as decided by the ERO, the hearing will be held preferably online. Any adult member of the family can be authorised by the elector to attend the hearing on their behalf, if required," the EC announced.

The Commission, comprising Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, and ECs Sandhu and Joshi, held a meeting at 3pm on Saturday, the EC statement said. It underlined that the press note had the "approval of the full Commission" and released a photo of the three-member EC at the meeting.

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NEW NORMAL?

In 48 hours, a sharp turn: Steps map two ECs' concerns but key silences remain

No word on appeals in West Bengal that the ECs had flagged or on Form 6 and chain of command in ECINET

Ritika Chopra
Mumbai, September 26

THREE DAYS ago, the Election Commission of India had a straightforward answer to *The Indian Express* investigation into how the three-member body was functioning. Two of its members had recorded objections at least 14 times to decisions touching the core of the Commission's man-

date: who gets registered as a voter, who gets deleted and restored, who appeals against those restorations, and who controls the systems through which the electoral roll is maintained.

The Commission called those notes "suggestions" and "inputs", part of normal deliberation. The important decisions of the past year, it insisted, »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



The Indian Express report published on September 23

Maharashtra declares drought in 75% of state amid rainfall deficit

Alok Deshpande
& Shubhangi Khapre
Mumbai, September 26

WITH MAHARASHTRA recording a rainfall deficit of 18% this year, the state government on Saturday declared drought in 265 of the state's 358 tehsils — about three-fourths of Maharashtra.

The declaration, under the Drought Management Code, 2016, will trigger crop-loss surveys and a package of immediate concessions, including waiver of land revenue, restructuring of crop loans, a stay on recovery of agriculture-related loans and relaxation of Viksit



A farmer in Mukhed, Nanded district. HAFIZ KHAN PATHAN

Bharat—Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB—G RAM G) norms. Financial assistance for crop losses

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Marathwada worst-hit, cloud over Rabi season

Amitabh Sinha
& Harish Damodaran
New Delhi, September 26

THE RAINFALL over Maharashtra this monsoon season has not been drastically different from other states so far. It has a rainfall deficit of 18%, while the country as a whole has a 13% deficit. Many other states — including Assam and Bihar, which have also experienced floods

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• RAINFALL DEFICIT (up to September 25)

SOLAPUR	-57%
BEED	-49%
HINGOLI	-48%
JALNA	-46%
DHARASHIV	-45%
AHMEDNAGAR	-44%
AMRAVATI	-42%
AKOLA	-41%
PARBHANI	-38%
NANDURBAR	-37%

SOURCE: IMD



Sawan Barwal (second from left) clocked 2:11:37 to win silver in Nagoya, Japan, Saturday. REUTERS

Havildar from Himachal ends India's 44-year wait for a medal in marathon



Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 26

SAWAN BARWAL woke up at 3.30 am, ate a banana and, a few hours later, made Indian athletics history.

On the damp streets of Nagoya, Barwal won silver in the

Asian Games marathon, ending India's 44-year wait for a medal in the event — and becoming the first to win one outside home soil. The country's last marathon medal in the Asiad was a bronze, won by Hosur Kukkappa Seetharan in New Delhi in 1982.

The 28-year-old clocked 2:11:37, lowering his own national record, but there was no catching Japan's Ichitaka Yamashita, who pulled away to win gold in 2:10:49. "This feels special," said Barwal. "To win a medal, and set a national rec-

ord doing it and ending a long wait for a marathon medal... this was my target."

For Barwal, competing in only his second marathon, the silver was the culmination of an extraordinary transformation — and not bad for someone who had taken up marathon running just a year ago. Moreover, there were 11 athletes in the 20-man field who had run a marathon faster than him but the timings of his competitors didn't overwhelm him.

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AT UN GENERAL ASSEMBLY SESSION

Jaishankar hits back at Pak PM: Serial terror practitioner's bid for immunity won't stand

Flags 'weaponisation of everything', from chokepoints to market access hurdles

Divya A
New Delhi, September 26

A DAY after Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif raked up the issue of Kashmir and described India's suspension of the Indus Waters Treaty as an "act of war", External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, referring to Pakistan as "a serial practitioner of terrorism", told the United Nations General Assembly Saturday that attempts to "normalise terrorism and claim immunity from its consequences" will not stand and India will exercise its right to defend itself.

He also called out "weaponisation of everything" in a world roiled by conflicts — from chokepoints to constricting market access — and flagged the "mindset of extreme competition" that is "undermining institutions".

In a strong rebuttal to Sharif's remarks from the UNGA podium, Jaishankar, without naming him, said, "Yesterday, a serial practitioner of terrorism misrepresented facts before this assem-



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar with Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi in New York. PTI

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INDIA WARNS PAK AFTER SHARIF'S 'ACT OF WAR' THREAT

TRUMP REJECTS IRAN PROPOSAL TO END WAR, OPEN HORMUZ

Arguments were invoked to normalise terrorism and claim immunity from its consequences. That will not stand."

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Happening today

• **PUBLIC SECTOR** banks and regional rural banks will remain open today, ahead of a strike by bank unions.

Naga leaders agree to open key Manipur highway after talks with Centre in Assam

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, September 26

THE UNITED Naga Council (UNC) on Saturday agreed to temporarily lift its more than three-month economic blockade of Manipur's highways after a high-level tripartite meeting with the Centre and the Manipur government in Assam, marking a significant breakthrough in efforts to ease the state's prolonged supply crisis.

"We had a lengthy deliberation in connection with the economic blockade. We have come to an agreement that the government will address the demands of the UNC, and we will temporarily end the blockade. Our demands are the revocation of the SoO (Suspension of Operations agreement with Kuki armed groups), the removal of Deputy Chief Minister Nemcha Kipgen and justice for the six Naga men," UNC president Ng. Lorho told *The Indian Express*.

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• HE WAS 15 WHEN HE GOT ON HIS FAVOURITE RIDE — THE TRAIN — THAT TOOK HIM FAR AWAY FROM HOME

Train to nowhere, Facebook reel and road home: 21-yr search for a Bihar man ends

Santosh Singh
Maheshpura (Madhubani),
September 26

FOR MOST, there's nothing unusual about the Mahrail Railway Station in Bihar's Madhubani district. A blink-and-you-miss station on the Sakri-Jhanjharpur-Laukaha Bazar line under the Eastern Central Railway Zone, it's exactly how you would expect one in rural India to be — quiet, nondescript and, save for two stationary tempo trucks, a cow and a few stragglers, nearly empty.

But for Ram Shanker Kushwaha from Madhubani's Ma-

heshpura village, this is a place close to his heart. Only 400 metres from his village, the station is where he spent hours daydreaming about trains and waiting for a chance to ride one, even if only to the next station. It is also where he, as a 15-year-old, boarded a random train that took him 1,000-odd km away to Madhya Pradesh's Gwalior — an act that separated him from his family for 21 years.

Now 36, Shanker reunited with his family on September 7, after a Facebook video posted by Gwalior Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) Santosh Patel. The video, made after

Patel visited the state-run Ashram Swarg Sadan, where Shanker had been living for eight years, featured a man in a *muretha* — a traditional headgear worn by many North Indian farmers — introducing himself as "Shanker Kushwaha from Anand Nagar, Bihar".

"I was drawn to his smile and mentioned it in the post that ultimately helped find him. I'm thrilled that my post eventually reunited a man with his family," DSP Santosh Patel tells *The Indian Express*.

It was on September 4, 2026 — Janmashtami — that Shanker's oldest brother Lalit Shastri spotted the Facebook post. "With trembling hands, I



Shanker Kushwaha (centre) with his parents at his home in Maheshpura in Bihar's Madhubani district. RAHUL SHARMA

dialled the number listed on DSP Santosh Patel's post," says Lalit, a priest who also runs a

bike spare-parts business. Shanker's fascination with trains began early. According to

his father Rajendra, he would frequently hop on a local train and return an hour or two later.

On December 6, 2005, Shanker undertook a train journey that would divide him from his family for over two decades. It was Vivah Panchami, and Maheshpura was abuzz with festivities marking the celestial wedding of Ram and Sita — an event that drew sadhus and ascetics from across the country.

"A sadhu from Ayodhya asked if I wanted to go with him. I asked how he was travelling, and he said, 'by train'," Shanker says.

Without bothering to pack a spare set of clothes, Shanker set off to Ayodhya. What happened

next is still hazy, blurred between train journeys. But both the police and the family believe he drifted from place to place, unable to tell where he was or where he was meant to go.

"He kept confusing 'Jhanjharpur' and 'Jharkhand', unaware that while the former was a block in Madhubani, the latter was an entire state to the south of Bihar," says Lalit.

In 2018, Gwalior's state-run Ashram Swarg Sadan found Shanker at the city railway station. "I have no clear memory of how or when I reached Gwalior," says Shanker. "I remember living around the Gwalior railway station for years, sleeping on platforms or outdoors. I did-

n't like begging, so I survived on food given by passersby or shopkeepers, and did odd jobs at roadside dhabas."

Adds Pawan Suryavanshi, the shelter in-charge: "We kept him under medical care until he recovered. He also spoke of a brother living in Delhi. Authorities later found out this was his brother Lallan Kushwaha."

The return

Back in Maheshpura, at the Kushwahas' modest single-roofed mud house, Lalit was hopeful after watching the video: Could this be their lost brother who left home all those years ago?

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Demolitions follow spate of harassment cases in Samastipur

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, September 26

THE SAMASTIPUR district administration Friday used bulldozers to remove “encroachments” from properties belonging to three of the four accused in a case involving the alleged harassment of a minor girl earlier this week. The administration said the action was against encroachments on government land. Police cancelled the public distribution system (PDS) licence of one of them.

The action followed the arrest of the four accused — Vikas Kumar Sharma, Rahul Kumar, Rambabu Sahni and Awadhesh Paswan — on Thursday, within six hours of police receiving information about a video of the incident. The video allegedly showed a minor girl being subjected to abuse and indecent behaviour by a group of youths.

A day later, bulldozers demolished what authorities claimed were illegal constructions — including a tea shop — belonging to Rahul Kumar, Rambabu Sahni and Awadhesh Paswan.

The administration also took action against an encroachment outside Vikas Kumar Sharma's house in Jagatsingpur.

Samastipur Sadar Sub-Divisional Magistrate Rakesh Kumar said Saturday that the administration had taken action against three of the four accused for encroachment on government land. “One of them, Vikas Sharma, has a permanent construction. While it was not demolished yesterday, a 24-hour notice had been served to his family to vacate the encroached portion. Another notice is to be served today, following which further action will be taken after three days,” he said. He also confirmed the cancellation of Awadhesh Paswan's PDS licence.

The latest developments came amid a series of videos involving alleged harassment of girls surfacing against Bihar over the past week, keeping police in

several districts on their toes. Earlier this week, a video showed youth surrounding and allegedly harassing two teenage students in a hilly area on the outskirts of Jamui. Police subsequently apprehended three juveniles and arrested two people, identified as Nandan Yadav and Hareram Yadav. Police said Nandan was shot in the leg while resisting arrest.

The incident and its aftermath became a political flashpoint in the state, with Indian Youth Congress National Secretary Murari Kumar alleging that a bulldozer was sent to the house of a local Congress leader for his protest over the Jamui incident.

Another unrelated video showed a girl allegedly harassed, pulled by her hair and subjected to abusive remarks by a group of youths on a bypass road in Samastipur in broad daylight. The four accused were subsequently sent to judicial custody after their arrest, following registration of an FIR under relevant provisions of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act and the Information Technology Act.

Police said Vikas had previously faced FIRs under the Excise Act in connection with alleged liquor smuggling and had been in jail in those cases. The criminal backgrounds of the other accused were also being verified, officials said.

A third video of an unrelated incident from Samastipur shows some people allegedly harassing a girl on a road under Musrihari police station. The purported video, reportedly from August 14, led to four people being identified and one person, Dharmendra Sahni, being arrested.

Another video from Banka showed some people harassing and assaulting a girl at the historic Mandar Hill tourist site. Police later said the incident had actually taken place on June 3, and that they had identified three suspects working as migrant labourers outside Bihar.

around Rs 5,600-5,700 per quintal, which is close to the government's MSP of Rs 5,705.

In terms of availability of soyabean, an expected good yield in Madhya Pradesh is likely to offset the production losses from Maharashtra.

The problem is likely to be greater for crops like arhar/tur (pigeon pea), which is a longer-duration crop (160-180 days, versus 80-90 days for soyabean). Arhar will enter the flowering stage around the third week of October and pod-filling would begin around the first week of November. Harvesting generally starts in November-end and continues till the first week of December. Since rainfall is expected to remain sparse under the growing influence of the El Nino phenomenon, which is gaining in strength, this crop could experience terminal moisture stress.

Arhar prices are already at Rs 9,000-9,200 per quintal in Latur, well above the MSP of Rs 8,450. The market is clearly sensing a production shortfall. Even chana (chickpea) prices are at Rs 7,200/quintal or so, as against the MSP of Rs 5,875.

The real crisis, however, is likely to be experienced during the coming rabi season. The rainfall deficit has left very little moisture in the soil and reservoirs and borewells would also be depleted. Therefore, farmers may not go in for sowing of rabi crops like chana and jowar.

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All three Commissioners meet

In its statement, the Commission also said that a declaration that was added without amendment to the voter enrolment form or Form 6, would go back to the original after the SIR. *The Indian Express* had reported that the two ECs had said this addition was “illegal, unauthorised” and called for its removal so that young, first-time voters are not harassed.

Responding to some specific concerns, the EC said agendas would be circulated in advance for all commission meetings and minutes issued. The Annual Performance Appraisal Reports of officers would be completed within the stipulated time frame, which is by December 31 each year, and that the commission's approval will be taken for foreign trips of the officers.

Further, in its statement, the EC said, “All directions issued by the Commissioners to the officers of the Commission shall be meticulously complied with.”

The EC also clarified that the Form 6, which is the statutory form for new voter enrolment, would revert to the original one

as per the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. Earlier this year, the EC had added a declaration to the online Form 6 that requires applicants to answer if they or their parents/grandparents were on the rolls of the previous intensive revision of electoral rolls. While a separate declaration form was created by the EC for the SIR, the declaration was inserted within the online version of the Form 6, which can only be amended by the Law Ministry. The two Election Commissioners had raised concerns with the same.

“The declaration attached to Form 6 for SIR has been upheld by the Hon'ble Supreme Court. For non-SIR period, the Forms applicable as per Rules (the Registration of Electors Rules 1960) will be used,” the EC said in its statement.

The two ECs, Sandhu and Joshi, had also flagged concerns with the centralisation of the ECINet portal. The EC on Saturday announced the setting up of a committee to review ECINet and double-check if it complies with the law. “Field officers have

role-based access to the ECINet system as per their statutory powers. A Committee headed by Sr. Deputy Election Commissioner (DEC) and including an independent expert from IT/IIIT will review the ECINet to double-check that it complies with the provisions of the Acts and Rules and submit report to the Commission,” it said.

According to the statement, various upgrades of the portal have already been made based on the inputs from State CEOs in the past few months. “In case, any further flexibility is required by the field officers, that will be made operational. Henceforth, all the new initiatives about IT modules and portals will be discussed in the Committee of Officers (COO) before approval by the Commission,” it said.

The EC said that the letters written by the two ECs to Cabinet Secretary T V Somanathan were in relation to the conduct of an officer. “The letter to Cabinet Secretary was not related to any policy matter of the Commission or IT division but related to the working of an officer on

deputation to ECI. The work redistribution orders issued by the concerned officers were not actually implemented after the orders of the two Commissioners and the oversight over the IT division by the DEC was never actually withdrawn,” the EC statement read.

With regard to the ongoing SIR, which has been completed in 20 states/UTs so far, the EC said: “Any person whose name has got left out during SIR or thereafter, and any person including young/first-time voter, may apply to the concerned ERO, for inclusion of their names in the electoral rolls under the process of continuous updation. CEOs have been directed to facilitate the same. The CEOs, DEOs, EROs will immediately launch a special drive for enrolment of these electors.”

Regarding the issue of 97 Goa electors who had been deleted from the final roll despite the statutory officials recommending their inclusion during the SIR earlier this year, the EC said the Chief Electoral Officer of Goa had directed the Booth Level Officers concerned to collect enrolment forms from them, and 81 of those electors had already filled the Form 6.

In 48 hrs, a sharp turn

had the “unanimous” approval of the full Commission.

On Saturday, the Commission met again. What followed was striking. In a four-page note issued after the meeting, it announced nine decisions that addressed, point by point, several of the concerns recorded by the two Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi.

Agendas will now be circulated before every Commission meeting and minutes issued afterwards. Officers' foreign trips will need Commission approval. New IT modules and portals will go through a committee of officers before being placed before the Commission. The ECINet will be reviewed by a committee headed by a senior Deputy Election Commissioner and will include an independent expert from an IIT or IIIT. If field officers need more flexibility in the system, it will be provided. And directions issued by Commis-

sioners to officers will be “meticulously complied with”.

These decisions map, almost item for item, onto the concerns the two Commissioners had put on file over 10 months: That agendas were not circulated and minutes not issued, that officers went abroad without the Commission's approval, that new IT modules were built without its knowledge, that the electoral roll database needed an audit by an independent expert, that field officers lacked “proper and complete access” to ERONet, and that an administrative order had altered the allocation of work around the IT division without them.

In Goa, where *The Indian Express* found 97 voters cleared by local officers still missing from the final roll, the Commission says 81 have now filled Form 6 and the CEO has been directed to facilitate their inclusion.

This sharp turn signals how

deep the disquiet inside the Commission had become, and how far it had travelled outside, with Opposition parties by Friday demanding that polls on SIR rolls be cancelled.

But the concessions have limits, and Form 6 is where they show. The note reads like a concession there and isn't one. It says the form prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules will apply outside the SIR period, which was the substance of Joshi's May objection. But the objection was about the online form on ECINet, where a question on the applicant's parents was inserted between sections J and K, and which would not let an applicant proceed without answering it. The note does not mention the online form, or the question, or say whether it has been removed. It says the Supreme Court “upheld” the declaration, which the court's May 27 order on the SIR does not appear to do in terms. And it does not say who put the question there in July, or why it stayed after

Sandhu called it “unauthorised/illegal” on August 13.

Other questions go unanswered too. The note says nothing about the central one from West Bengal: who authorised the appeals filed against voters whose inclusion had been ordered by judicial officers, and were they filed on behalf of ECI and if yes, who was it authorised by? It does not explain why Goa's requested software facility to restore voter names was never enabled. And it does not say whether DG (IT) Seema Khanna, whose functioning was a point of contention and Senior Deputy Election Commissioner Maneesh Garg, against whom both Commissioners sought action, stay.

And it leaves the biggest question open: what the new normal inside the Commission looks like. Whether Gyanesh Kumar now takes Sandhu and Joshi along before decisions are made, and whether the two, having put their objections on record, will have more say at the table, remains to be seen.

Jaishankar at UN

“A persistent threat to peace has been the scourge of terrorism. That this could be state-sponsored with cross-border purpose makes it a direct affront to the global order. Governments indulging in such practices must be held accountable,” he said.

The international community, he said, must hold such states accountable. “There must be no dilution in our zero-tolerance approach towards terrorism. Its financial aspects, in particular, should be exposed and should be countered,” he said.

“Our right to defend ourselves against terrorism will be exercised... Friendship and goodwill cannot coexist with terrorism. And understandings premised on that will naturally be called into question,” he said, underlining “it is for the perpetrator of terrorism to mend its ways”.

Jaishankar, who began his address with a ‘Namaskar from 1.4 billion people of Bharat’, said “conflicts and confrontations remain the primary preoccupation” of the world at this time.

“The inability to maintain peace is not just undermining security but threatening progress and retarding development,” he said, adding that the effects of war are felt worldwide in a globalised world.

“Countries far from conflicts are being penalised for no fault of theirs. Those most impacted often have the least say,” he said, referring to the West Asia war, the Russia-Ukraine conflict, and also the Israel-Gaza conflict, emphasising on a two-state solution.

“Let us recognise that peace is not just the absence of war; if

the world is subjected to continuous threats and pressures, then we are really living on the edge of an abyss,” he said. “All it takes is one more step to push us over.”

Calling for strengthening stability, security and predictability, he said “if any of them are undermined, peace will inevitably be weakened.”

“What we are actually seeing is a weaponization of everything. A mindset of extreme competition has set in, undermining institutions and establishing chokepoints. It extends from the world of finance to restricting market access, disrupting supply chains and withholding technology. Resources and connectivity have become particularly subject to leverage,” he said.

Just two days ago, Jaishankar had flagged India's concerns over the new US law to punish Russia's energy buyers. The Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act, which has been signed into law by President Donald Trump, authorises the US to impose up to 100 per cent tariffs on Russian energy purchases including India and China.

He said that as a result of such measures, “nations are now more focused on de-risking and diversifying”. The predicament of the Global South is particularly acute, he said, adding that the countries in the region face a 4F crisis — the security of food, fuel, fertiliser and finance.

He also called the targeting of commercial shipping as “unacceptable” — India has lost over 10 of its seafarers owing to attacks in the Strait of Hormuz and the Black Sea.

help make a video call. When we did, Shanker cried.”

From Gwalior, Shanker embarked on a train journey — this time homeward. In Patna, while his brother was buying him a pair of trousers and a shirt, Shanker had a request — he wanted a cap to cover his receding hairline.

At Kanhauli Chowk along the national highway in Madhubani, a group of 500 people was waiting to greet him and accompany him as he walked

back home, where his joyful parents — and his favourite dish ‘bachka and bari’ — waited.

With Shanker home, the focus now is to keep Shanker meaningfully engaged. “Shanker is strong and capable of physical labour. He could do well in rearing cattle. We have plans, but we want him to settle down first. Our priority now is making sure he doesn't take another train to nowhere,” Lalit says.

Maharashtra drought

will be decided separately after the assessment is completed, government officials said.

The declaration comes as the state enters the final days of the monsoon with a significant rainfall deficit. From June 1 to September 26, Maharashtra has received 798.2 mm of rainfall against a normal 970.9 mm, a deficit of 18%. Except for five districts, the state has recorded deficient rainfall during the period.

The situation is particularly acute in Marathwada, where the eight districts together have recorded a 38% deficit. It ranges from 16% in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar to 48% in Hingoli.

In Vidarbha, the average deficit across 11 districts is 27%, with the shortfall ranging from 26% in Yavatmal to 42% in Amravati.

The state government's decision follows a report by the Agriculture Commissioner, which found drought-like conditions from June onwards in 265 tehsils based on rainfall deficiency and other factors. The first trigger under the drought assessment process, which includes a continuous dry spell of at least 21 days without significant rainfall during the monsoon, has been found applicable in these areas.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis, who recently toured parts of the state to assess the drought situation and met farmers, said the government's focus would be on providing relief to those affected.

“In this drought-like situation, farmers, agricultural labourers and working people in the state are at the centre of our relief efforts. All possible measures will be taken to provide them relief. We stand firmly with our farmer brothers and sisters. Let us make united efforts to overcome this challenge,” Fadnis said.

He also directed the Revenue and Agriculture departments and other agencies to begin field-level assessments immediately and coordinate to ensure that relief reaches farmers.

The 265 affected tehsils are spread across all six revenue divisions. They include 49 tehsils in Nashik division, 35 in Pune division, 74 in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar division, 56 in Amravati division and 39 in Nag-

pur division. In the Thane division, 12 tehsils have been included.

The government's declaration does not immediately determine the crop compensation individual farmers will receive. District administrations will first conduct panchnamas and document the condition of crops with the help of photographs and GPS coordinates. The reports will be submitted through the Agriculture Commissioner, following which the government will issue a separate order on assistance.

Relief measures

For farmers and rural households, the immediate relief measures announced with the drought declaration include a waiver of land revenue, restructuring of crop loans and a stay on recovery of agriculture-related loans. The government has also provided for concessions on electricity bills for agricultural pumps, with bills for pumps up to 7.5 HP already waived and concessions to apply to pumps above that capacity.

Other measures include a waiver of examination fees for school and college students, relaxation of VB-G-RAM G norms to maximise employment, deployment of tankers for drinking water wherever required, no disconnection of electricity supply to agricultural pumps in villages declared to be facing shortages, and arrangements for food-grains and fodder.

The measures are intended to provide immediate relief while the crop-loss assessment is carried out. The extent of compensation to individual farmers will depend on the findings of the surveys and the separate government order to be issued on crop damage assistance.

Maharashtra Congress chief Harshvardhan Sapkal said the government had announced concessions but no substantial financial assistance for farmers. “The important question is when will farmers get compensation. First deposit cash into their bank accounts and then complete the formalities of panchnama and surveys,” he said, demanding Rs 1 lakh per hectare for crop losses, free seeds and fertilisers for the rabi season, and immediate arrangements for fodder and drinking water.

remained up and down,” Barwal, who drank just 120ml of fluids from all eight water stations, said. “Our target was to stay with the group till the end. If we could maintain that position, the chances of winning the medal would increase.”

The strategy was less about making a move than refusing to make the wrong one. He wanted to remain in the middle of the pack, never pushing beyond his limit. That patience became crucial after 30km, when the race suddenly changed. The pace rose as the runners reached an uphill stretch and the group of six began to splinter. Soon, only three or four remained.

Barwal briefly lost contact as Yamashita accelerated up the hill. But he did not panic. Once the road tilted downwards again, he clawed back the lost ground. “After 30 km, when you see the hill and the pace increases, you feel a little different. I got left behind, but when we crossed it, I covered it on the downward slope,” he said.

By the final 10 kilometres, there were only three runners left in contention. Barwal knew the danger of going beyond what his body could sustain. His experience at the Rotterdam Marathon earlier this year, where he had set the national record, had taught him how brutal the closing kilometres could be. “We didn't try to go too fast. We kept the limit at 2:58 per kilometre. Our target was not to go beyond our limit,” he said.

Yamashita eventually found another gear. By 39 kilometres, he had begun to pull away, and at 40 kilometres, the gap was 26 seconds. The gold was slipping away, but Barwal's silver was not. The Japanese runner entered the stadium to a roar from the home crowd and crossed the line in 2:10:51. Barwal followed, holding on for second and lowering the national record he had set in Rotterdam in April. Back then he experienced two mini blackouts towards the end of the race, caused because of the cold winds that numbed his head. But he got back on his feet to finish the race.

That race had already been a breakthrough. Barwal had become the first Indian to break 2:12 in the marathon, bettering Shivnath Singh's 48-year-old national record in Holland. In Nagoya, he went faster still — and added an Asian Games medal to it, ending India's 44-year wait.



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Train to nowhere

“I said: ‘Arre, ye to Shankerba hai, mera bachcha (Oh, this is Shanker, my child),’ his mother Lakshmi Devi recalls having said then.

But bureaucratic hurdles delayed the return: Shanker had no identity proof, had never attended school, and it took hours of persuasion for officials at the local Jhanyharpur police station

to sign off on the official identity certificate.

In the days that followed, Shanker's older brother Lallan and his cousin Sanjeev Kumar boarded a train for Gwalior, where Shanker recognised them instantly. Says Lakshmi Devi: “When I learnt where he was, I asked my oldest, Lalit, to give me every tiny update and

Delhi SIR deadline revised for fourth time, final electoral roll now on Dec 4

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, September 26

THE DEADLINE for the on-going Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Delhi was revised for the fourth time on Saturday, with the Election Commission of India (ECI) pushing the publication of the final electoral roll from November 4 to December 4 and giving residents one more month to file claims and objections.

Residents can now file claims and objections until October 30, while the deadline for disposal of notices, claims and objections has been extended to November 30.

Also, the ECI eased the process for voters who have received notices over discrepancies in their records. From

now on, they will not have to appear at an election office for a hearing but booth level officers (BLOs) will visit their homes to collect documents and upload them on the ECINet platform for a decision by the Electoral Registration Officer (ERO).

The revised schedule was issued "in view of the request received from CEO Delhi", the ECI said. It followed a request from the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) in a letter dated September 23, it added.

The latest change is the fourth revision of the SIR schedule since the exercise was ordered on May 14. The deadline to issue the final roll was earlier October 7, which was then revised to October 19, October 27 and November 4.

The extension comes as the

• HOW THE DEADLINE HAS MOVED



REVISION	DATE	DEADLINE
First	July 15	Oct 19
Second	August 4	Oct 27
Third	August 19	Nov 4
Fourth	Sept 26	Dec 4

claims and objections phase has seen a relatively low number of applications from people seeking fresh enrolment. Since the draft rolls were published on August 31, only 1.21 lakh Form 6 applications – used to seek registration as new electors – have been filed, according to Delhi CEO office data.

The figure assumes significance in the context of the number of deletions in the draft

electoral roll.

Delhi had around 1.45 crore electors before the exercise. Among them, 97.5 lakh were included in the draft electoral roll, while around 47.5 lakh electors were classified as "uncollectible" – after BLOs found them absent, shifted, dead or having duplicate entries, among other reasons – and were struck off the roll.

Among the 97.5 lakh who

did make it to the draft roll, one-third or around 33.1 lakh electors were issued notices to prove that they are eligible to be on the final roll. While 13.79 lakh electors got notices because they could not link themselves to the electoral roll of the last SIR, 19.33 lakh were flagged for "logical discrepancies" in their enumeration forms.

Several prominent voters, including former Deputy Prime Minister L. K. Advani, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Election Commissioner S. S. Sandhu, former Vice-President Jagdeep Dhankhar and former Delhi CM Arvind Kejriwal, have received such notices. Officials said the details of most had been validated through field verification and their names had

been reserved for inclusion in the final roll.

Sources in the Delhi CEO's office said the decision to seek more time was taken after a meeting with representatives of parties earlier this week. "All parties requested that more time be given for filing claims and objections," an official said.

Further, the ECI directed district election officers to create adequate helpdesks and hold special camps for people living in night shelters, labourers, poor people and the homeless, as required. The Delhi CEO's office has been trying to increase enrolment among vulnerable communities, including the homeless, sex workers, and transgender persons, through special camps at night shelters and other locations.

Rain lashes Delhi, temperature drops

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 26

• Skywatch

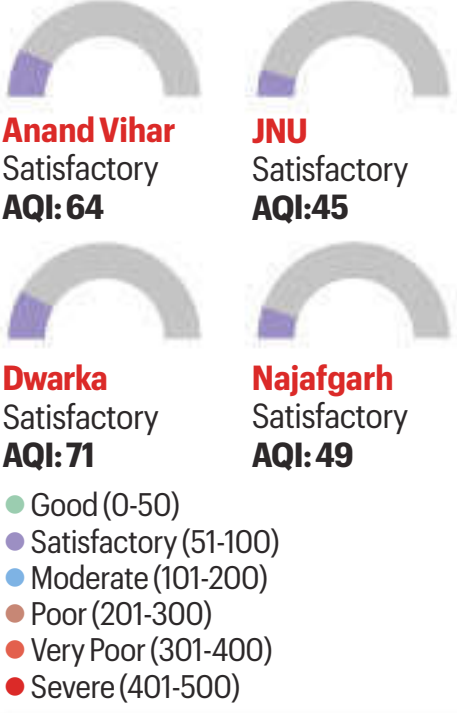


Forecast:
September 27, 2026
Generally cloudy sky; no rain expected

MAX: 30-32
2.3°C below normal

MIN: 21-23
2.9°C below normal

• AQI Tracker



Air quality index (AQI) in the Capital also remained in the satisfactory category. The 24-hour average air quality index was 72 at 4 pm, compared to 78 on Friday, as per CPCB data.

Dry conditions are set to return with the IMD forecasting a generally cloudy sky on Sunday. Come next week, the city is set to see "mainly clear sky," and prevailing northwesterly winds by October that bring cooler air.

YUVRAJ SINGH MANCHANDA MURDER

How can a body be cremated along with belongings: Court raps Gurugram Police

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, September 26

A DELHI court on Saturday pulled up the Gurugram Police, asking how it cremated the body of real estate professional Yuvraj Singh Manchanda along with his belongings without following legal procedures.



Yuvraj Singh Manchanda

"How can a body be cremated along with belongings? How can the law not be followed," Judicial Magistrate Rahul Jain of Saket court asked the Gurugram Police in response to a submission by senior advocate Amit Prasad, who appeared for Yuvraj's sister, that a burnt watch and kada were recovered from the cremation site.

The remarks came after the court on Thursday said the Gurugram Police had "botched up" the case and described its handling of the body as a "complete hotch potch".

Yuvraj was allegedly killed by his former colleague and her partner in Gurgaon on September 6 and thrown into a drain.

Describing the sequence of events as a "shocking state of affairs", the court asked, "Do you not upload details of an unidentified body on ZIPNET in cases of murder or otherwise? Isn't that the procedure followed by Gurugram Police?"

Yuvraj's details, including a photograph, were uploaded by the Delhi Police on ZIPNET — an interstate police database — on September 12, two days after Gurugram Police recovered an unidentified body from a drain in Badshahpur. However, the body, which later turned out to be Yuvraj's, was cremated on September 14 without being identified.

The court was hearing an application moved earlier by Yuvraj's sister, in which she had raised concerns over the handling of the body by Gurugram Police and alleged that vital

forensic evidence and personal belongings were mishandled or destroyed during the cremation. It reserved its order on the application.

According to PTI, questioning an officer from Gurugram's Badshahpur police station, the judge asked why the nearest executive magistrate or sub-divisional magistrate was not informed on the second day after recovery of the unidentified body for the inquest proceedings. "Isn't it the norm to inform the nearest executive magistrate... regarding inquest proceedings for the unidentified body? Why wasn't it carried out," the court said.

The judge further raised serious questions over the post-mortem process, noting that two reports appeared to contain materially different findings. While one report mentioned bullet injuries, the other attributed the cause of death to asphyxia due to antemortem drowning.

"The postmortem reports are different... How can such basic procedures be skipped," the court asked, while also taking note that the viscera had not been preserved.

The court observed that the lapses had resulted in Manchanda's family being deprived of the right to perform his last rites. "The complainant not only lost her brother by cremating his body, you snatched away her family's right to dutifully carry out his last rites," it said.

Drishti Jain
New Delhi, September 26

KALEEM'S DAY as a caretaker at the Delhi Race Club would begin at 4 am.

He first cleaned the stables, and gave the horses a bath and a massage. "Then, I'd put the saddles on them and take them out for a walk. The jockey would then wait while I prepared Ashwa Bravo for a race. I would bring it back at 3 pm. At night, I'd make rounds to refill their water and check if they needed anything," said Kaleem.

On a Tuesday, the 48-year-old stood amid the rubble of the horse-wash rack, staring at the row of partially demolished stables where he had spent 20 years caring for racehorses.

Following the Centre's takeover of the Delhi Race Club and Jaipur Polo Ground, near the Prime Minister's residence in Lutyens' Delhi, Kaleem and others who live in three nearby settlements — Bhai Ram Camp, DID and Masjid Camp — have lost the only jobs they knew.

Kaleem, a resident of Bhai Ram Camp, said 1,500-2,000 residents of the three camps were employed here as caretakers, grass cutters and caddies. From having a fixed income, they are now left struggling, depending on daily-wage jobs.

"I used to earn around Rs 19,000 a month, but now I am trying to find work at construction sites. A few times, I get work at the Air Force station, but it does not even pay Rs 500 a day," Kaleem said.

Earlier in the day, Kaleem and another ex-employee Tara Chand, 40, had gone looking for work together. Chand had worked at the club maintaining the betting register and earned around Rs 18,000 a month.

Picking up a small square book with a photograph of a horse on its cover, titled 'BOL Race Card,' he said, "We've



(Top) Kaleem (in blue) and Tara Chand used to work as caretakers at the Delhi Race Club; the iron benches where spectators once sat were rusted and, in places, uprooted, with tall grass growing around them. ABHINAV SAHA

grown up selling these race cards at traffic signals for Rs 50. We used to get Rs 5 as our cut."

Kaleem's own connection to the Race Club went back even further. His father had worked as a *sais*, a local term for people who cared for horses. "He was their union leader, so I grew up watching him care for them."

"I was very sad when the horses — 200-250 of them — were sold," he added.

On August 11, the Estate Officer of the Land and Development Office (L&DO), which comes under the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, issued an eviction order to the Club under the Public

Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act. It directed the club to vacate the premises within 15 days, terming them to be "unauthorised occupant" of the land.

Last month, the Supreme Court dismissed the Club's appeal against a High Court order, which had vacated a stay on the eviction proceedings initiated by the Centre. A district court also refused to grant any interim stay on the eviction proceedings.

For several former staff, the uncertainty surrounding their homes has dealt a double blow.

Nearly 700 families across three camps have got eviction notices. In court, the Centre

said clearing these unauthorised structures was necessary to strengthen defence infrastructure and protect high-security installations.

Their new homes are 45 km away in Savda Ghevra, a resettlement colony in Northwest Delhi. That distance has become a problem for those still looking for work around Lutyens' Delhi. "How will we travel for work here from there?" asked Chand. "My children are in school... Everything has ended for us."

As of May 2026, while the litigations were pending at Delhi High Court, 192 dwellers had accepted the allotment letters and 136 had taken possession of the flats at Savda Ghevra.

For one family in Masjid Camp, the move proved difficult.

A woman in her late 40s was waiting anxiously for her husband. He had lost his job at the club and was now working as a caddie at the nearby Delhi Golf Club. But he was paid only when he assisted someone.

"I sit here hoping that his turn will come, but it hasn't for the past three days. He must be waiting," she said.

The family had shifted to Savda Ghevra three months ago, but her husband was unable to find work there. "He is a BA graduate from Dyal Singh College but hasn't been able to find a skilled job," she said.

Then, there was the question of her son's school. "My son is in Class 12. We would leave at 6 am for school but couldn't reach even by 8 am. So we shifted back last month," she said.

Meanwhile, a bouncer who had been hired on contract still had a job. But his duties had changed: he now guarded the security staff and iron rods at the site. "There used to be 10 of us, but now we're just three left," he said, speaking on condition of anonymity.



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at the launch on Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Now open, 3rd automated testing station for vehicles

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 26

MAINTAINING THAT temporary measures taken only during winter would not be enough to address Delhi's pollution problem, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Saturday that the government will launch an enforcement drive against vehicles with invalid Pollution Under Control Certificates (PUCC) from October 1.

Gupta, who inaugurated a five-lane Automated Testing Station (ATS) in Burari — with a capacity to test one lakh vehicles a year — said modernising vehicle testing is part of a "year-round" approach to tackling pollution issues in the Capital.

"Temporary measures taken only during winter would not be enough to address Delhi's pollution problem. The government has taken pollution control up as a continuous,

year-round process and is working simultaneously across areas, including transport, expansion of green cover, electric mobility, waste management and technology-based monitoring," she said in a statement.

"Pollution does not remain confined to any one boundary and Delhi-NCR's air quality is affected by several areas, but it is the government's responsibility to take the necessary concrete steps to reduce pollution in Delhi," she added.

"We want to ensure that every person in Delhi gets clean air to breathe. This enforcement will be done to check whether the PUCCs are valid."

This is the third such ATS to begin operations in Delhi. Similar stations were inaugurated in Nand Nagri and Tekhand earlier this year. The Burari facility will be able to test 40,000 heavy motor vehicles and 60,000 light motor vehicles annually.

• THE GAME IS NOW BEING TAUGHT COMMERCIALLY, PLAYED AT RESTAURANTS AND TOURNAMENTS

Once a family pastime, Mahjong finds a new table in Delhi's social scene

Reva Thakkar
New Delhi, September 26

ON A Tuesday morning in Jor Bagh, Ferida Chopra's drawing room is full. Four women — in their 20s to 70s — sit around a square table, their fingers moving across rows of Mahjong tiles. The players draw and discard from 144 tiles, trying to complete a winning combination.

Mahjong means "sparrow", said to come either from the bird carved on some traditional tiles or from the sound the pieces make when shuffled.

A lawyer who began practising at 50, Ferida learnt Mahjong only recently, taking lessons from two teachers in Greater Kailash. Her 10-year-old grandson had started learning it, and she wanted something to keep her brain active; her 97-year-old

mother suffers from dementia.

Her WhatsApp group where one can book Mahjong sessions, named 'Lutyens' Delhi', has members from across Jor Bagh, Nizamuddin, Vasant Vihar and Khan Market. Slots for games played at her home fill up in under half an hour, twice a week, every week. "The game has helped me reconnect with distant relatives, family friends and acquaintances," she says.

Ferida is part of a Mahjong boom that has gathered pace in Delhi over the last five years. A game once largely played between families, particularly in Army and Parsi circles, is now being taught commercially, played at restaurants and organised through WhatsApp groups and tournaments.

The reasons are varied: a post-pandemic appetite for

meeting people offline, the game's visibility on social media, and teachers turning a family pastime into businesses.

Mahjong originated in 19th century China. How it came to India has more than one version.

Ferida, a Parsi, traces its presence in Bombay to the community's links with China. "My grandfather used to play bridge, while my grandmother dressed in chiffons and pearls to play Mahjong with a beautiful ivory set in a carved cabinet," she says. "The Parsi traders who went to China brought back silks and Mahjong sets."

The game has been played for generations in Mumbai. At the Willingdon Sports Club, more than 200 people can play across 10 to 15 tables. She mentions how officers of the East India Company during British



(Left) At an event conducted by The Mahjong Network; the stage is set at Latitude 28 in Khan Market. EXPRESS



rule played Mahjong and, because of that, clubs in Kolkata like the Tollygunge Club had Parsis playing the game.

Another lineage runs through Army families. Vijaylakshmi (73) was 10

when she learnt to play. In the 1960s, when her father and other officers were posted to non-family stations, her mother gathered the officers' wives and children around Mahjong tables to keep them busy.

"When she had to go to the kitchen, she would hand her game over to me, and that's how I learned," says Vijaylakshmi.

In 2015, Vijaylakshmi started offering professional sessions in Defence Colony. "I was quite astounded at the diversity of my students — geographically, in age, and in their careers and backgrounds," she says. Her students have included an investment banker, a senior IAS officer's wife, and a jeweller.

In Greater Kailash, Vasundhara Sinha (39) and her sister-in-law Diya Kaul (41) launched Mahjong Studio last December.

Vasundhara has a master's in economics from the London School of Economics; Diya prac-

tised law for a decade and recently qualified for the Advocates-on-Records examination. Both have put careers on hold.

"We love teaching Mahjong, it has become our full-time job," says Vasundhara. They teach the Indian formats, Taiwanese, American, and other advanced variations. Their students range from Diya's 10-year-old son to a 91-year-old man and his wife.

"Initially, mostly women in their 50s came to play. But over the last five to seven months, there's been a sudden surge of people in their 20s... even college students

are coming," she says. According to the studio, around 80% of its players are women.

The Mahjong Network,



HC flags 'grim situation', seeks aggressive measures to tackle Gurugram water crisis

Express News Service
Gurugram, September 26

WARNING THAT Gurugram faces a progressively "grim" future unless corrective steps are pursued aggressively, the Punjab and Haryana High Court recently took serious note of its persistent water crisis, flagging the rapid depletion of ground-water alongside the city facing recurring waterlogging during monsoon.

In an order passed on September 22, a bench comprising Chief Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra and Justice Rohit Kapoor observed that the city's proximity to the national capital has made rapid urbanisation and population influx inevitable, yet basic water resource governance has lagged dangerously behind.

"Unless appropriate and effective measures are pursued

aggressively, the situation is likely to remain grim, particularly as continued urbanisation and population growth appear inevitable, given Gurugram's proximity to the National Capital," the bench observed.

Examining the material on record, it pointed to a stark urban paradox: while Gurugram reels from acute potable water shortages and shrinking subsoil reserves, intense monsoon showers consistently lead to paralyzing deluge in urban areas that authorities fail to harness. The HC noted that indiscriminate extraction through private borewells over several decades has triggered a steep drop in the groundwater table across municipal limits. Concurrently, natural catchment systems have collapsed.

"Further, the existing natural water bodies have substantially diminished, while the

channels that sustained these water bodies remain largely blocked," the bench said.

It observed that while Gurugram witnesses severe water-logging every monsoon, the accumulated runoff is not being channelled into replenishing the underground aquifers. The judges raised concerns regarding the inadequate treatment and reuse of wastewater, pointing out that sewage treatment plants are not being operated to their optimum capacity to offset freshwater demand.

The HC directed that the Chief Engineer of Municipal Corporation of Gurugram (MCG), Gurugram Deputy Commissioner, officers in-charge of Haryana Shehri Vikas Pradhikaran as well as officials of Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority to appear before it via videoconferencing on October 1, the next date of

hearing.

The proceedings stem from a long-pending bunch of writ petitions, filed by Sunil Singh, alongside the Qutab Enclave Residents' Welfare Association and others.

The litigation, spanning nearly two decades, originally challenged unchecked construction and commercial expansion across sectors developed by private colonisers, including DLF City, without commensurate environmental clearances, sewage networks, or sustainable water supply mechanisms. The petitioners had argued that rapid real estate development was being carried out in violation of environmental norms, driving massive illegal extraction of subsoil groundwater through unmetred tubewells. Over the years, the HC had declined multiple pleas to transfer the

litigation to the National Green Tribunal, retaining continuous supervisory jurisdiction to monitor compliance.

The bench had in August called upon the Central Ground Water Authority, under the Union Ministry of Water Resources, to submit a comprehensive affidavit assessing the current depletion rates and water tables within Gurugram's municipal boundaries.

Earlier this month, the Haryana Human Rights Commission (HHRC) had initiated suo motu proceedings following heavy rain on August 24 that submerged arterial stretches, stranded school buses, and caused a major road cave-in near IFFCO Chowk. In an order passed on September 8, the HHRC said the seasonal chaos is an institutional lapse attributable to neglect and lack of preventive measures.



A view of the charred sleeper bus after it caught fire on the Yamuna Expressway in Greater Noida on Thursday. ANI

Greater Noida bus fire: HC seeks details on safety checks from UP Transport dept

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, September 26

TAKING SUO motu cognizance of the death of nine people in a bus fire in Noida earlier this week, the Allahabad High Court asked the UP Transport department to submit a detailed affidavit answering a set of questions raised by the bench after it heard the state Chief Secretary, state DGP, and the Transport Secretary through video-conferencing on Friday. The High Court asked the senior officers to appear before it again on October 13.

Citing incidents of buses catching fire in UP in the last three years, the single bench of Justice Saurabh Shyam Shamsheery on Friday observed, "It appears that AC sleeper buses are operating without proper checks and without proper safeguards, such as fire extinguishers, etc. It also appears that drivers and conductors of buses are not trained to act responsibly in such mishaps."

The bench also cited a reply given by the Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways to the Rajya Sabha last year, in which it was stated that about 45 bus fire incidents have taken

place since 2023, killing 64 passengers. The bench asked the State Transport Department to reply on the following issues:

■ Number of permits issued to sleeper buses by UP in the last three years

■ Whether, before issuing such permits, the standards required to be maintained by such sleeper buses were checked or not

■ Specification of checking points or steps taken for such surprise checking

■ Details of inspection of a bus in the state and whether statements of passengers were recorded or not; also whether there were fire extinguishers inside the bus, and whether the passengers were told about the emergency gate

■ Details of criminal action taken in the last three years and its outcome in such accidents.

The Indian Express on Saturday reported that a non-functional emergency exit, luggage packed into the aisle and under the seats, and passengers in a rush to disembark may have left them with few options to escape after the AC sleeper bus caught fire on the Yamuna Expressway in Greater Noida late Wednesday.

'Artificial skeleton' found during cleanliness drive prompts probe

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 26

A SKELETON-LIKE structure found inside a wooden box during a cleanliness drive near the Kali Mandir on Deendayal Upadhyay Marg in New Delhi on Saturday triggered panic and prompted a police inquiry. A preliminary examination by a forensic team, however, indicated that it was an artificial skeleton, said officers.

The recovery was made during a cleanliness drive organised by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), according to police, around the temple complex ahead of the upcoming Durga Puja celebrations. Delhi BJP vice-president Rajesh Bhatia, along with co-officer secretary Amit Gupta and former Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) mayor Raja Iqbal Singh, also took part in the drive.

During the drive, a wooden



A police officer looks at the box with the 'artificial skeleton' on Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

box containing what some described as a "human skeleton" was found inside the jhuggi of a scrap dealer identified by the BJP as Mohammad Shakeel. The matter was then reported to Delhi Police.

Bhatia claimed that Shakeel told the team that he had purchased the box as part of scrap from a local school. The BJP called for an investigation into

the matter.

According to DCP Central Rohit Rajbir Singh, police staff reached the spot after receiving information and found an old, assembled skeletal structure inside the wooden box. There were no bloodstains or any other suspicious material in or around the box, officers said.

During the preliminary inquiry, police learnt that the material had been purchased as scrap from Government Boys Senior Secondary School on Mata Sundari Road, along with other old and broken articles. The school principal told police that the institution had shifted to a new building in 2023 and that old articles were disposed of in July.

According to the preliminary assessment of the forensic expert, the structure appeared to be an artificial skeleton, possibly used for educational purposes.

Speeding car rams auto, cycle rickshaw, 1 killed

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 26

A 45-YEAR-OLD auto-rickshaw driver was killed and another person was injured after a speeding car allegedly crashed into his vehicle and then hit a cycle rickshaw in Southeast Delhi's Sukhdev Vihar on Saturday morning. The car driver was arrested later in the day, said officers.

The accident took place around 7 am. According to an eyewitness, two cars were allegedly racing before the crash. The account was shared with police too. The man who was killed in the accident was identified as Mohammad Kalam, a resident of New Friends Colony. The injured man, identified as Mohammad Bablu, lives near Sukhdev Vihar Metro station, police said. The accused has been identified as Mohammad Talib. He was allegedly returning from a friend's birthday



The auto suffered huge damage and its driver was killed in the collision. PRAVEEN KHANNA

party. "Initial probe suggests that he was not drunk at the time of the accident," an officer said.

Jeet, an eyewitness who was on his way to work, said that he had stopped for tea break when he heard a loud thud. "Two cars were racing each other and one car rammed into the auto. The other car fled at a high speed," he said. Police are examining CCTV footage to establish the sequence of events.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSONS

SEE SECTION 82 Cr.P.C./84 BHARATIYA NAGARIK SURAKSHA SANHITA

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused persons **1. Gopal Sharma, 2. Mahendra Sharma, 3. Aaryan Sharma** all S/o Sh. Deepchand Sharma & **4. Sangeeta** W/o Sh. Gopal Sharma all R/o H. No. U115, Prem Nagar-2, KSN, Delhi have committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence case FIR No. 1162/2018 u/s 498A/406/34 IPC, at P.S. Aman Vihar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the above said accused cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the above said accused have absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr.P.C./84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **1. Gopal Sharma, 2. Mahendra Sharma, 3. Aaryan Sharma & 4. Sangeeta** accused of FIR No. 1162/2018 u/s 498A/406/34 IPC, at P.S. Aman Vihar, Delhi are required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.11.2026**.

By Order: **Ms. Neha Goel,**
Metropolitan Magistrate Mahila Court-02,
Room No. 18, Ground Floor,
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/13548/RD/2026

Office of the Executive Engineer
Drinking Water & Sanitation Division, Sahibganj

e-Procurement Notice
Very-Very Short Term Tender
Tender Reference No.- DWSD/SAHIBGANJ-05/2026-27
(3rd Call) (e-Tender) Date- 26.09.2026

1	Name of Work:	Operation & Maintenance of 27.0 MLD WTP at Hathri Park, Intake Floating Jetty at River Ganga, Chanan, Raw Water & Clear Water Rising Main D.I K-9 from Intake Floating Jetty at River Ganga, Chanan to WTP to ESR at Sahibganj and Distribution Pipe line under Urban Water Supply Scheme for 2 (Two) Years under D.W.& S. Division, Sahibganj "on Turn Key basis." (Excluding the cost of energy charges).
2	Department Name:	Drinking Water & Sanitation Department, Jharkhand, Ranchi.
3	Name & Address of the Office Inviting Tender	Executive Engineer, D.W.&S. Division, Sahibganj
4	Estimated Cost	Rs. 1,35,26,169.00
5	Earnest Money	Rs. 2,71,000.00
6	Cost of BOQ (In Rs.)	Rs. 10,000.00
7	Time of Completion	24 Months
8	Date of Publication of Tender/Time on Website:	29.09.2026 / 05 : 00 PM
9	Last date/Time for receipt of Online Bid	06.10.2026 / 05 : 00 PM
10	Last date/time of Online submission of Earnest Money and Cost of BOQ (As per Letter No.-120, dated-03.10.2023 of Secretary to Govt., Information Technology & e-Governance Department, Govt. of Jharkhand)	06.10.2026 / 05 : 00 PM
11	Date of Opening of Tender /Time:	07.10.2026 / 05: 00 PM
12	Name & Address of Tender Opening Officer:	Executive Engineer, D.W.&S. Division, Sahibganj
13	Contact no. of Procurement Office:	9431749737
14	Help line No. of e-procurement cell:	0651-2480345

Note:-
No claim shall be entertained because of disputation of internet service being used by the bidders. Bidders are advice to upload their bids well in advance to avoid last minute technical snags. Further details can be seen on website <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in>
Estimated Cost may be increase or decrease.
This tender is done in anticipation of Administration Sanction. Work order will be given only after Administrative approval.
Executive Engineer
D.W. & S. Division, Sahibganj.
PR 390544 (Drinking Water and Sanitation)26-27"D

NORTHERN POWER DISTRIBUTION COMPANY OF TELANGANA LIMITED
Corporate Identity Number: U40109TG20005GC034119

TENDER NOTICE

TGNPDCL intends to purchase the Materials through e-Procurement platform from the Manufacturers.

Specification No: **CE/P&MM/(STN-51 to STN-150/2026-27 and OT-26 to OT-75/2026-27)**

Name of the Material: Various Materials
Bid Security @ 2% on Ex-Works.
Downloading of Tenders through On-Line e-Procurement starts from **28.09.2026 at 11:00 AM**
For further details visit www.tender.telangana.gov.in and www.tgnpdcl.com
For obtaining Digital Key visit www.tsts.telangana.gov.in
Contact:- 8712483302 Email: cgmpmm@tgnpdcl.com

DIPR R.O.No. 581-PPCL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:26-09-2026 Sd/- Chief Engineer (P&MM)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Md. Sadiq @ Mohd. Sadiq, S/o: Abdul Jalil, R/o: A-218, Sahid Nagar @ Shahid Nagar, Ghaziabad, UP** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **SC No. 363/2022, FIR No: 264/2022 U/s: 20/29 NDPS ACT, PS: Shahdara, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Md. Sadiq @ Mohd. Sadiq**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Md. Sadiq @ Mohd. Sadiq**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Md. Sadiq @ Mohd. Sadiq, of SC No. 363/2022, FIR No: 264/2022 U/s: 20/29 NDPS ACT, PS: Shahdara, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **28.10.2026**.

By Order
Vineet Kumar
Special Judge (NDPS) Shahdara
Room No. 11, Second Floor
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/13712/SHD/2026 (Court Matter)

"IMPORTANT"

Whilst care is taken prior to acceptance of advertising copy, it is not possible to verify its contents. The Indian Express (P) Limited cannot be held responsible for such contents, nor for any loss or damage incurred as a result of transactions with companies, associations or individuals advertising in its newspapers or Publications. We therefore recommend that readers make necessary inquiries before sending any monies or entering into any agreements with advertisers or otherwise acting on an advertisement in any manner whatsoever.

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H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone: 0135 - 2763808, Fax 0135-2763508
CIN No. : U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website : www.ujvnl.com

Tender Notice Dated 26.09.2026
Letter No 873
Office of the Executive Engineer (Civil-Maintenance), Yamuna Bhawan, Yamuna Colony, Dehradun invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below :
Tender No. 13/EE/(C-M)/DDN/2026-27.
Name of work: Provision of various instruction Boards as per ISO norms 9001, 14001 & 45001 and other miscellaneous work at New Corporate office Building at Ujjwal Dehradun, Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road Dehradun."
Estimated cost :- Rs. 9,90,510.00 (Exclusive of GST)
Date of availability of bid document on website: From 14:00 hrs of 28.09.2026
Last date for submission of tender: Up to 14:00 hrs of 19-10-2026
For full & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website <https://ujvnl.uk.gov.in>
Executive Engineer (Civil-Maintenance)
"Avoid Wasteful use of Electricity"

उत्तराखण्ड पावर कारपोरेशन लि०
(उत्तराखण्ड सरकार का उपक्रम)
कार्यालय अधिशासी अभियन्ता, विद्युत वितरण खण्ड, विकासनगर-248198 रुड़की पिन : 9412075946

पत्रांक:-6976 / विरिचिख / दिनांक-26.09.2026

निविदा सूचना

अधोहस्ताक्षरी द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्यों हेतु आयकर तथा वस्तु एवं सेवाकर में पंजीकृत अनुमयी फर्मों / ठेकेदारों से मोहरबन्द निविदायें दो भागों में (प्रथम भाग में धरोहर राशि, जो अधिशासी अभियन्ता, विद्युत वितरण खण्ड, विकासनगर के नाम बनाई जायेगी, 180 दिनों के लिए बैच हो एवं नियम व शर्तें, प्रपत्र इत्यादि तथा द्वितीय भाग में वरें हो) दिनांक 13-10-2026 को 15:00 बजे तक आमन्त्रित की जाती है जो उसी दिन अधोहस्ताक्षरी के कार्यालय में 15:30 बजे सार्वजनिक रूप से खोली जाएगी। निविदा प्रपत्र एवं सम्बन्धित विवरण अधोहस्ताक्षरी के कार्यालय से दिनांक 12-10-2026 को सांय 17:00 बजे तक नकद धनराशि जमा कर प्राप्त की जा सकती है। निविदा विक्रय करने की तिथि/ खुलने की तिथि को किसी कारण अवकाश होने पर उक्त कार्य अगले कार्य दिवस पर होगा। किसी भी निविदा को बिना कारण बताये अस्वीकृत/ निरस्त करने का अधिकार अधोहस्ताक्षरी के पास सुरक्षित होगा। विस्तृत नियम व शर्तें निविदा प्रपत्र में वर्णित है।

निविदा संख्या 26/EDDV/2026-27:- विद्युत वितरण खण्ड विकासनगर के अन्तर्गत विभिन्न रजिस्टर/ प्रपत्रों/ लेखन सामग्री की छपाई एवं आपूर्ति का कार्य इत्यादि। धरोहर राशि रु० 10,00,000, निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य रु० 295,000/- जी०एस०टी० अतिरिक्त।

अधिशासी अभियन्ता
सद्विहित में बिजली बचाए / Save Electricity in the interest of Nation (Toll Free No. 1800-419-0405)

UJVNL LIMITED
H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvnl.com

Tender Notice Date: 26/09/2026
Letter No: 877
Office of the Executive Engineer, Maintenance Chilla (Pauri- Garhwal), invites sealed tenders from experienced firms for following works/supply for Chilla Power House:-
1- T-15/EE/M/2026-27:- Annual General Cleaning of different places, Officers Club, Guest House, Substations, Central Store and Tube well premises etc. at Chilla Power House, Chilla.
2-T-16/EE/M/2026-27:- Providing services of divers to carry out the various underwater works at chilla power house
3 - Estimated Cost - Rs 8,57,312.00 (Taxes Extra) & Rs 6,75,000.00 (Taxes Extra)
4 - Date of availability of Tender document on website - 24-09-2026 (17:00 Hrs)
5 -Date of Receipt of the tender - 15-10-2026 up to (11:00 Hrs)
For all details, bidders are advised to visit our website www.ujvnl.com
Executive Engineer (M), Chilla Power House
"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC/84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Vinod Kumar S/o Ved Prakash R/o House No. S-83, Bansi Nizamuddin, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 380/2017 U/S 20(b)(ii) NDPS ACT, PS Badapur, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Vinod Kumar** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Vinod Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Vinod Kumar of FIR No. 380/2017 U/S 20(b)(ii) NDPS ACT, PS Badapur, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **29.10.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Kumar Rajat
ASJ-04/Special Judge(NDPS)
Court No. 312, South East District
Saket Courts, New Delhi

DP/13737/SE/2026(Court Matter)

Registered and Corporate Office:
YES BANK Limited: YES BANK House, Off Western Express Highway, Santacruz East, Mumbai – 400055 India.
Website: www.yesbank.in Email: communications@yesbank.in CIN: L65190MH2003PLC143249
Regional Office At: 4th Floor, Max Tower, Sector 16B, Noida, U.P.- 201301

Sale notice for sale of immovable properties
E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immoveable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower (s) and Guarantor (s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Yes Bank Ltd. i.e. Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is", and "Whatever there is" on **October 30, 2026**, for recovery of **Rs. 20,32,36,243.79/- (Rupees Twenty Crore Thirty Two Lakh Thirty Six Thousand Two Hundred Forty Three and Seventy Nine Paise Only)** due as on Feb 14, 2026 subject to further interest and charges at contracted rate, due to the Secured Creditor by (1) **M/s Sarangi Metal Works International Private Limited ("Borrower")** through its Director(s) ("Borrower"); (2) **Mr. Sumit Kumar Sarangi S/o Mr. Shashank Sekhar Sarangi ("Director & Guarantor")**; (3) **Mrs. Tejashwini Rath W/o Mr. Sumit Kumar Sarangi ("Director, Guarantor & Mortgagor")**; (4) **Mr. Shasanka Sekhar Sarangi S/o Mr. Shyamunder Sarangi ("Guarantor")**; (5) **Mrs. Seba Sarangi W/o Mr. Shasanka Sekhar Sarangi ("Mortgagor & Guarantor")** & (6) **M/s New Modern Techno Mech Pvt Ltd., through its Directors, Mr. Sumit Kumar Sarangi, Mrs. Seba Sarangi & Shasanka Sekhar Sarangi ("Guarantor")**.

The reserve price will be **Rs. 22,06,26,000/- (Rupees Twenty Two Crore Six Lakh and Twenty Six Thousand Only)** and the Earnest Money Deposit will be **Rs. 2,20,62,600/- (Rupees Two Crore Twenty Lakh Sixty Two Thousand and Six Hundred only)**.

Description of property
All that piece and parcel of freehold immovable property/Apartment bearing no. B-001, on Ground Floor, Tower-B, having super area measuring 7004 Sq. Ft., (Carpet area 4664 Sq. Ft.) in Residential Complex known as "ARAYA" situated in Sector-62 in the revenue estate of Village-Ghata, Tehsil-Wazirabad, District-Gurugram-122001. Boundaries: North: Staircase, South: Lobby, East: Open, West: Entry

Date and time of e-auction: October 30, 2026, 11 am to 2 pm with extension of 5 minutes each.
Last date for submission of bid: October 27, 2026 till 6:30 pm
Date and time of inspection of property: October 22, 2026 between 11:00 AM to 02:00 PM.

For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in www.yesbank.in/about-us/media/auction-property – Secured Creditor's website i.e. www.yesbank.in.

In case of any difficulty in obtaining Tender Documents/ e-bidding catalogue or inspection of the Immoveable Properties/ Secured Assets and for Queries, Please Contact Concerned Officials of YES BANK LTD., Mr. Pradeep Kumar on +919810711126 or Email: pradeep.kumar36@yesbank.in and Officials of M/s. e-Procurement Technologies Limited (Auction Tiger) Ahmedabad, Bidder Support Numbers: 9265562821, 079-61200594/598/568/587/538. Email id ramprasad@auctiontiger.net, chintan.bhatt@auctiontiger.net at the web portal <https://sarfaesi.auctiontiger.net> / also on Auction tiger Mobile App.

As contemplated U/s.13(8) of the Act, in case if the total dues together with all costs, charges and expenses incurred by us are tendered at any time before the publication of the auction/ sale notice, then secured asset shall not be sold or transferred by us, and no further step shall be taken by us for transfer or sale of that secured asset.

SALE NOTICE TO BORROWER/GUARANTORS/MORTGAGORS
The above shall be treated as Notice U/r. 9(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, to the Obligants to pay the same within 30 days from the date of publication.
Place: Delhi NCR
Date: 27.09.2026
Sd/- (Authorised Officer)
YES BANK



NAFED's journey towards a stronger cooperative India

From empowering farmers and strengthening procurement systems to expanding global markets and embracing digital innovation, NAFED continues to redefine its role as a cooperative institution in building a resilient, inclusive, and future - ready agricultural ecosystem.

INDIA'S cooperative movement has long remained as one of the strongest foundations of the rural economy, allowing millions of farmers to access markets, strengthen their inclusive growth and improve their livelihoods through collective action. To reinforce this vision, the Government of India has established the Ministry of Cooperation on 6th July, 2021 under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, with the vision of "Sahkar Se Samridhhi." Led by Union Minister of Home Affairs and Cooperation Amit Shah, the Ministry has since focused on revitalising the cooperative sector by promoting transparency, institutional re-

forms, technology-driven governance, and greater opportunities for cooperative organisations across the country. As the ministry marks five years of its journey, the milestone was commemorated at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, bringing together cooperative institutions, PACS, farmers and other stakeholders. For NAFED, the occasion also highlighted its nearly seven-decade contribution to agricultural marketing, procurement and food security. Established in 1958, it has evolved by embracing technology and market-led interventions to strengthen market access and improve price realisation for farmers.

To mark the anniversary, NAFED organised a week-long nationwide campaign from June 29 to July 6, 2026, across its offices. The campaign featured tree plantation drives, Cooperative Pledge ceremonies and farmer awareness camps, while encouraging farmers to register on the NAFED e-Samridhi Portal for transparent procurement and timely digital payments. As it approaches seven decades of service, NAFED continues to combine the principles of cooperation with innovation, strengthening market linkages and creating greater opportunities for India's agricultural producers.



By embracing innovation & technology, cooperatives can become a powerful force in advancing the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047 & strengthening Atmanirbhar Bharat. NAFED remains committed to empowering farmers and building a more resilient and self-reliant agricultural economy."

— SHRI JETHABHAI AHIR
CHAIRMAN, NAFED

Building a trusted retail presence across India

ONE of NAFED's most remarkable success stories has been the growth of NAFED Bazar, a retail platform dedicated to providing quality agricultural products at affordable prices. With a humble beginning of two retail outlets in 2014, it has today grown into a nationwide network of 39 outlets by 2026. This expansion shows the growing trust consumers have placed in NAFED over the years. The retail business has also recorded a strong growth, with a Y-O-Y turnover witnessing a 200% increase from 2024-2025.

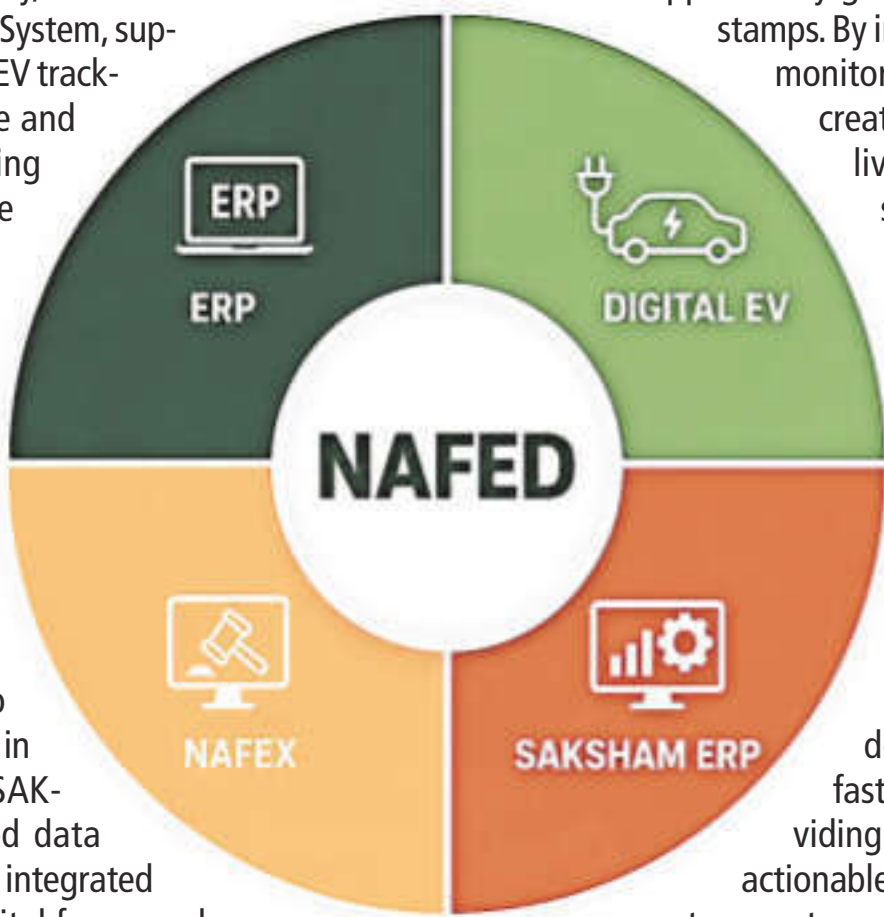
Moreover, it has significantly diversified its product range. While the early offerings included pulses, dry fruits, and spices, today's portfolio includes staple food products, edible oils, peanuts, millet-based foods, ready-to-cook and ready-to-eat products, natural sweeteners, products sourced from Farmer Producer

Organisations, and GI - tagged specialty products. By connecting quality products with wider markets, NAFED Bazar is creating new opportunities for farmers while promoting nutritious, value-added and locally sourced food products. NAFED Bazar continues to strengthen its retail presence by embracing modern retail practices and expanding its reach across diverse consumer segments.



Strengthening nutrition delivery through digital tracking

TO further strengthen nutrition delivery, NAFED has implemented an advanced Track & Trace System, supported by ERP integration and Digital EV tracking, to create a transparent, effective and target-oriented supply chain. Covering over 1.89 lakh Anganwadi Centres, the system enables real-time monitoring of consignments, from manufacturing facilities to warehouses and final delivery, while OTP authentication, QR scanning and geo-tagged proof of delivery enhance accountability and transparency. This end-to-end digital visibility is part of NAFED's wider digital transformation, which includes initiatives such as NAFEX.in, a digital auction platform designed to strengthen transparency and efficiency in agricultural produce auctions, and SAKSHAM ERP, which brings centralised data management, real-time reporting and integrated business processes onto a single digital framework. The system further enhances accountability through OTP - based receipt authentication, QR code scanning and digital proof of delivery,



supported by geo-tagged, GPS coordinates and time-stamps. By integrating vehicle tracking, ERP - based monitoring and digital verification, NAFED has created a more transparent and efficient delivery ecosystem. Complementing these systems, DRISHTI provides real-time monitoring of inventory across more than 1,500 warehouses, enabling accurate stock tracking and stronger coordination with platforms such as e-Samridhi and NAFEX. Together, these digital initiatives are helping NAFED build a more transparent, effective and target-oriented operating ecosystem, while using technology and data to strengthen accountability and improve service delivery. These initiatives also enable faster and smarter decision-making by providing stakeholders with timely, accurate and actionable information. By leveraging technology at every stage, NAFED is strengthening overall operational efficiency while ensuring better outcomes for farmers, beneficiaries and consumers.

NAFED expands its footprint in railway catering services

- Supplies essential food ingredients to IRCTC vendors for passenger meals served through train pantries and base kitchens.
- Key supplies include atta, maida, besan, pulses, rice, spices and edible oils.
- Provides a range of ready-to-serve and packaged products, including fruit juice, premix tea and coffee, muffins and diet mixture.
- NAFED biscuits, chikki, patisa and roasted dry fruits are among products in the pipeline.
- Leverages its pan-India network of state branches to support seamless supply and distribution.
- Helps IRCTC catering services access quality-assured ingredients and convenient packaged food products for railway passengers.



From Indian farms to international shelves



WITH the times, NAFED's ambitions extend beyond domestic markets. In recent years, the organisation has steadily strengthened its international presence through strategic collaborations with leading global retailers and distributors. Partnerships with Lulu Hypermarket, Gelda Foods, and AU Global have enabled NAFED-branded products to reach consumers across the UAE, GCC countries, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand.

Participation in prestigious international trade exhibitions such as Gulfood, Indus Food, and World Food India has further expanded the organisation's global footprint, helping showcase India's agricultural excellence while creating new business opportunities for Indian producers. This growing international presence of NAFED reflects India's rising stature in global agricultural trade and demonstrates how co-operative institutions can successfully compete in international markets.

Cooperation driving the future of Indian agriculture development

AS India's premier cooperative organisations, NAFED continues to show how innovation, technology, and cooperation can work together to strengthen

NAFED continues to evolve while remaining firmly rooted in its cooperative values.

Inspired by the vision of the Ministry of Cooperation and committed to the guiding principle of "Sahkar Se Samridhhi," NAFED is building a future where technology, transparency, and cooperation work hand in hand to create a stronger agricultural ecosystem, empower farmers, and contribute meaningfully to India's journey towards inclusive and sustainable growth.

As the Ministry of Cooperation marks five years of its transformative journey, NAFED shows how seven decades of cooperative leadership, technological innovation and farmer-centric initiatives are contributing to India's vision of 'Sahkar Se Samridhhi'

Expanding storage capacity for farmers

UNDER the Government of India's World's Largest Grain Storage Plan in the Cooperative Sector, NAFED is helping build a decentralised network of modern storage facilities through Primary Agricultural Credit Societies. The initiative brings storage infrastructure closer to farms, enabling farmers to store produce locally and reducing transportation to distant godowns. NAFED identifies suitable PACS and locations, facilitates project proposals and supports cooperatives

during implementation. Hiring assurance for the godowns also helps ensure their sustained utilisation for procurement and storage operations. By linking these facilities with NAFED's procurement network, the programme can streamline post-harvest management, reduce logistical challenges and strengthen PACS. Improved access to storage, procurement and market linkages can help farmers reduce post-harvest pressures and realise better value from their produce.



Modernising procurement for a more connected farm economy

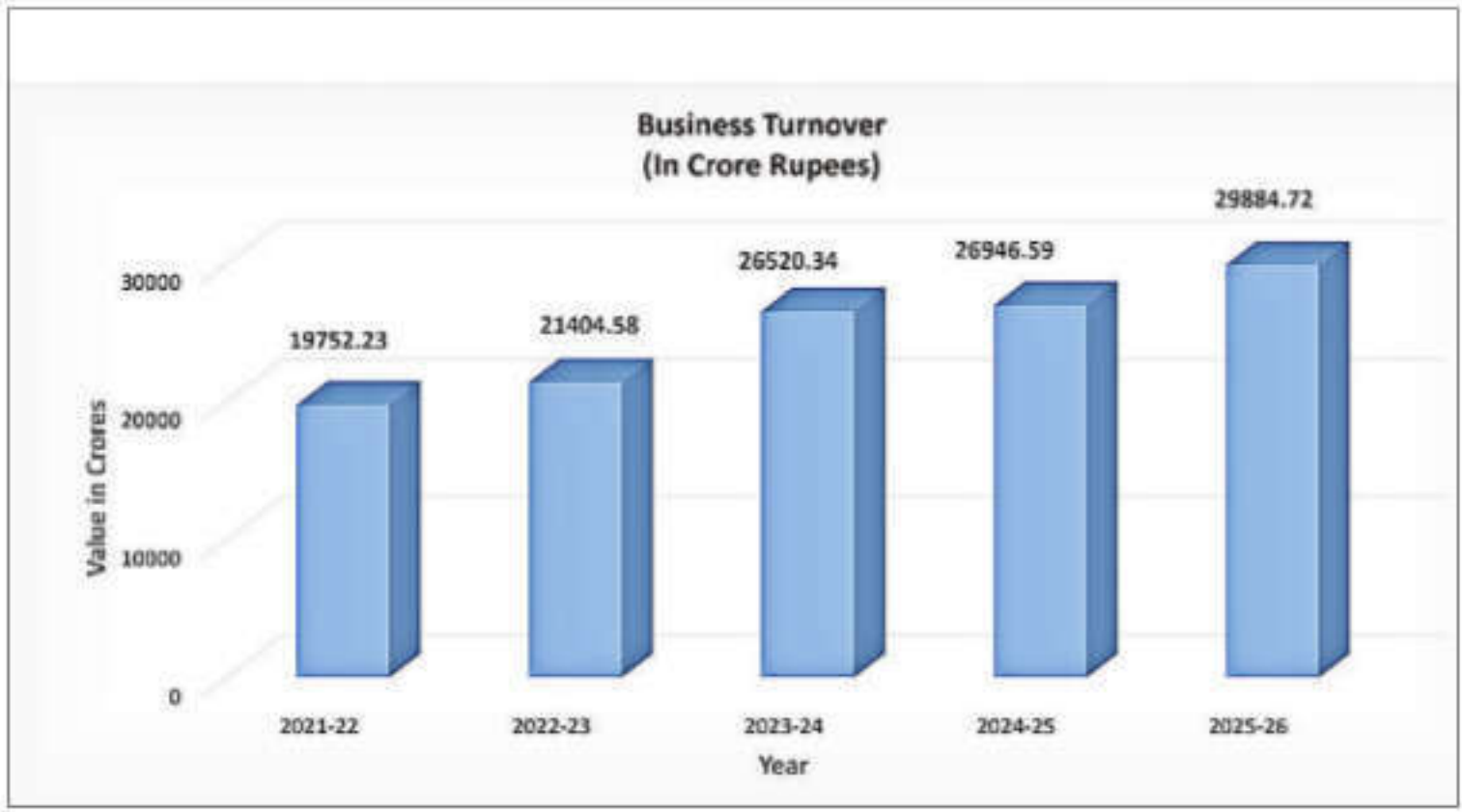
NAFED operates an integrated, tech-driven ecosystem for farmer welfare. Its Direct Procurement Centers, under the Atmanirbhar Bharat Mission, connect farmers directly with government procurement, ensuring easy registration, SMS- based scheduling, and payments within 72 hours along with basic facilities at centers. This in turn is powered by the e-Samridhi portal, enabling farmers to register, sell produce at MSP through PACS/FPOs, and receive direct bank transfers via PFMS.

Stock movement is monitored through DRISHTI, a real-time inventory surveillance platform offering geo-spatial visibility across 1,500+ warehouses, integrated with e-Samridhi and NAFEX for accurate reconciliation. A robust ERP sys-

tem unifies finance, procurement, and inventory functions, automating processes and enhancing transparency. Complementing this, the KALYAN scholarship programme supports the education of meritorious children from farming families registered on e-Samridhi, linking digital participation with long-term rural development. Together, these initiatives reflect NAFED's commitment to transparent procurement, efficient inventory governance, and farmer welfare. NAFED is also leveraging digital technologies to simplify access to agricultural services and strengthen engagement with farmers. By reducing paperwork and enabling seamless information exchange, these initiatives are making procurement processes more convenient while im-

proving communication between farmers, PACS, FPOs and other stakeholders. The growing use of digital platforms is helping create a more responsive and farmer-centric system. At the same time, real-time data and technology-driven monitoring are improving the efficiency of NAFED's supply chain operations. Digital visibility across procurement, storage, inventory and distribution enables better coordination, faster decision-making and more effective resource utilisation. These systems also strengthen accountability by ensuring that critical transactions and stock movements can be tracked throughout the operational cycle. Through the continued adoption of technology, NAFED is building a more connected and transparent cooperative

ecosystem that supports both farmers and rural communities. By integrating digital solutions with welfare and development initiatives, the organisation is strengthening service delivery, improving operational efficiency and creating a more inclusive framework for sustainable agricultural growth. NAFED's digital transformation is also enabling stronger coordination and informed decision-making across its diverse operations. This transformation is further enabling NAFED to strengthen coordination across procurement, storage, distribution and farmer support systems. Integrated digital platforms are helping streamline workflows, improve data accuracy and provide timely insights for better planning and execution.



Range of More Than 1000 NAFED Products Available at NAFED BAZAR



NAFED products are available at NAFED BAZAR, ASHRAM CHOWK, RING ROAD | LAWRENCE ROAD, INDUSTRIAL AREA | KRISHI BHAWAN | DWARKA | ROHINI | NARELA | GTB HOSPITAL RESIDENTIAL COMPLEX

Wishy-washy statement, EC is in damage-control mode, says Cong

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 26

THE CONGRESS on Saturday termed the Election Commission's statement on its SIR-related decisions as "wishy-washy" and said the poll panel was in a "damage-control mode after causing massive damage to democracy".

Congress MP and general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said on X: "It (EC) has just issued a wishy-washy Press Note that raises further questions on its intent, integrity, impartiality and credibility." The senior Congress leader was reacting to the EC's statement which came following *The Indian Express* investigation on notes of dissent by the two Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, on steps taken by the poll panel.

Ramesh said the EC does not "directly deny the (*Indian Express*) story or its findings". "It makes a defensive attempt to downplay the same in paragraph 3(i) and 3(ii) but does not say that the allegations are baseless," said Ramesh in a statement on behalf of the Congress.

"Second, in the case of Goa [where 97 voters' names had

been deleted despite them being eligible for inclusion], after having been caught out, the EC has sheepishly stated that Form 6 has already been filled out for inclusion by 81 of the 97 deleted voters. To put this another way, you disenfranchise voters through a broken and corrupt system, and when caught, you say that they are being added back," said the Congress MP.

In his third point, Ramesh said the EC statement "seeks to justify the Commission's actions by appealing to the Order of the Supreme Court dated May 27, 2026". Citing the EC's decision to extend deadlines for voter registration in Delhi and Maharashtra, he asked what about the voters of Karnataka, Telangana, Bihar and West Bengal.

Ramesh also said the EC avoided "questions regarding the deliberate targeting of Gen Z voters". "The ECI has no answer for its targeted disenfranchisement, beginning mid-July 2026 through wholly illegal changes made to Form 6 (unseen and unapproved by Parliament) which placed an unfair burden on them to find and disclose their parents and/or grandparents' details," read the statement.

The Congress said the CEC thinks he can hide behind



Police use water cannons to disperse Congress workers protesting against EC, in Patna. ANI

"bureaucratise" and protocol. "He (Gyanesh Kumar) stands exposed and is now petrified as an entire country seeks to hold him accountable."

Congress's head of media & publicity department Pawan Khara said: "The EC's press note is too lame, too little, too late."

Khara said the EC statement still leaves several questions unanswered, even as it does not address the objections raised by

two ECs on alterations in Form 6 for new voters.

"That objection was not resolved then... And this 'mother of all objections' has still not been addressed — even after today's so-called unanimous meeting. So until ECI answers this specific legal objection, no length of press notes, no claim of unanimity or any other clownery can save Gyanesh Kumar Gupta's face," Khara said on X.

"It is still not too late for him. He should resign and turn approver, or prepare for jail," he said. Amid calls for the removal of CEC, LoP Rahul Gandhi Saturday alleged that the poll panel chief was made in-charge of "match-fixing" elections by PM Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah.

Gandhi levelled this allegation after sharing a post from Kerala Congress, which cited

• INDIA bloc meet likely on Sept 30

INDIA bloc parties are planning to meet on September 30 in Delhi to discuss and strategise their next course of action as they ramp up pressure on CEC Gyanesh Kumar. Sources in INDIA bloc parties said they have got invitations for the meeting on September 30 in Delhi. In a statement on Saturday, TMC MP Derek O'Brien said: "First, GK (Gyanesh Kumar) has to go. There are certain other demands which have been raised. Those demands are very much in place, including how a CEC is selected and how SIR was a fraud. We will work unitedly, purposefully and swiftly." ENS

media reports claiming that Kumar had told a former Kerala chief secretary to contest on a BJP ticket after his retirement. "First, Gyanesh Kumar — then a serving IAS officer — was used to recruit for the BJP... Then Modi and Shah made him the umpire and put him in charge of match-fixing India's elections," Gandhi alleged on X.

There was no immediate response from CEC Kumar on the claims made by Gandhi or Kerala Congress.

BJP: Rahul lied, claims baseless, Opp must work hard to win polls

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 26

WITH THE Election Commission issuing a statement Saturday seeking to address several concerns raised by the two poll panel commissioners — Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi — the BJP lashed out at Congress for what it termed as "baseless allegations" against the EC and said that LoP Rahul Gandhi "should explain why he told this lie".

The EC held its first meeting Saturday since *The Indian Express* reported that Sandhu and Joshi had objected on record at least 14 times in 10 months to SIR-related decisions taken without their knowledge and to glaring gaps in processes.

Welcoming the statement, former Union Minister and BJP MP Ravi Shankar Prasad questioned the Opposition's narrative despite the fact that the SIR has been held valid by the Supreme Court. "Who had gone to the Supreme Court regarding the SIR process? Congress, CPM and TMC had filed dozens of cases. After hearing all of them, the Supreme Court called the SIR ok," he said.

"We condemn the baseless and unfortunate allegations that Opposition parties, especially Congress, and especially Rahul Gandhi are levelling against the Election Commission. They even went to the extent of saying they should be arrested, there should be an FIR."

"Today, the Election Commission has duly issued a press note... It says that all the decisions regarding the SIR were taken with the concurrence of the CEC (Gyanesh Kumar) and the two Election Commissioners. Secondly, on 24.06.25, it (the SIR) began in all states and UTs — first Bihar, then West Bengal, the process has taken place in 30 other states. The Election Commission has specially mentioned... that on May 27 2026, Supreme Court held all matters related to the SIR valid and deeply permissible," he said.

"Rahul Gandhi should explain why he told this lie. The Election Commission has today made the facts absolutely clear. The CEC and both Election Commissioners were present, and this decision was taken in



Senior BJP leader Ravi Shankar Prasad. @RSPRASAD/X

their presence," he said.

"BJP would once again like to tell the Opposition to go among the people, work hard and win elections. BJP is not present in Kerala, where Congress won. Elections were also held in Himachal Pradesh and Telangana, and Congress won there as well. When Congress wins, everything is fine, whether it is the EC officials, the voter list or EVMs. But when the Opposition loses, it creates a ruckus," he said.

"... Today's statement makes it clear that even Form 6 has been approved by Supreme Court, despite which there has been so much controversy over it," he said. "However, this issue is being raised without any reason. This is provided for under the Representation of People Acts, 1950 and 1951. These provisions provide that Election Commission can conduct an SIR. Such revisions have been carried out in the past as well. Under Article 324 of the Constitution, the Election Commission has the sole authority to conduct and complete the entire electoral process from beginning to end."

Targeting Gandhi as "a non-serious politician", Prasad said, "The kind of abusive language used by Rahul Gandhi is highly condemnable. The people don't take him seriously. Perhaps, for the first time in the history of the country, the EC has had to issue a detailed clarification because of his false propaganda, and the CEC and both Election Commissioners sat together today to take this decision."

"Rahul Gandhi repeatedly gets exposed because whatever issues he raises, he is publicly defeated on all of them. Whether it is the Rafale issue or other matters... people do not take him seriously," he said, underlining "no one will be deprived of the right to vote".

SIR conducted to help BJP capture Bengal: Mamata

Kolkata: Former West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee on Saturday alleged that the EC conducted the SIR to help BJP win the Assembly polls by deleting valid voters' names.

Addressing a rally in Serampore in Hooghly district, the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress chief mounted attack on CEC Gyanesh Kumar, alleging that the "truth" about the manner in which the poll panel was used by BJP had now emerged, in an apparent reference to a report by *The Indian Express*. "SIR was conducted in Bengal to capture the state. 93 lakh names were either deleted or put under adjudication," Banerjee said. Renewing her call for opposition unity, she said, "I sent a message to Rahul Gandhi, and told him we must sit together. A meeting of the INDIA bloc will most likely be held in Delhi's Constitution Club on September 30." ENS

NDA partners rally behind poll panel: 'Clarification reaffirms integrity, SIR issue presented clearly'

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 26

A DAY after members of the ruling BJP-led NDA on Friday said CEC Gyanesh Kumar must "dispel misgivings in the minds of the people" and the EC must issue a clarification on internal differences over SIR, the poll panel issued a statement on Saturday announcing a slew of decisions ranging from BLOs home visit for "unmapped" voters, Form 6, and a review of the ECINet portal. Following this, the NDA constituents rallied behind the poll panel, saying the statement has addressed the concerns they had raised.

Andhra Pradesh CM and TDP chief N Chandrababu Naidu sought to underline that the "unanimous clarification issued by the Election Commission" reaffirms the "integrity and credibility of our constitu-

tional institutions and puts to rest all the misconceptions surrounding it." "The decisions concerning the SIR are taken collectively and in strict adherence to established institutional protocols. Attempts to undermine global confidence in India's democratic framework or electoral processes for short-term political gains are deeply unfortunate," he said on X.

"It is collective responsibility of leaders across party lines to uphold public confidence in India's democratic process," he said. On Friday, TDP's LS floor leader, Lavu Srikrishna Deva-rayalu, said SIR was "conducted in a transparent manner" in Andhra Pradesh, but added, "At the same time, the Election Commission is a constitutional institution entrusted with a crucial responsibility on our democracy. Therefore, whenever questions are raised by anyone, providing

appropriate clarification and maintaining transparency will only help strengthen public confidence in the institution."

Union Minister and LJP (RV) chief Chirag Paswan, who said Friday that "it is problematic if people begin to doubt the electoral process itself. EC needs to present its stance, not to Rahul Gandhi, but to the public... it must dispel misgivings in the minds of people", on Saturday said that the Election Commission has "clarified its position on all key issues, point by point. Facts regarding the SIR process, the unanimity among the three Commissioners, and the meeting with the Cabinet Secretary have also been clearly presented. This clarity further strengthens public trust in democracy."

Accusing the Opposition of spreading "false notion" that there was no consensus within the poll panel over SIR, JD(U)

working president Sanjay Jha said the EC's statement had proved that "misconceptions being spread regarding constitutional bodies are baseless". "Dissemination of misinformation against a key constitutional body like the Election Commission is unfortunate, and the Opposition ought to apologise to the nation for it," he said.

On Friday, JD(U) spokesperson Rajiv Ranjan Prasad asked why the Opposition had not filed any official complaint "if the allegations are true". "EC has explained its position. We are not going into what and wherefore of it," he had said, adding, "RJD was aware it was going to be defeated. They kept trying to blame the EC repeatedly. But the EC sought a clarification when allegations of irregularities in the SIR were raised, and submitted that if there are so many accusations, why is there no official

complaint."

In a post on X Saturday, RLM chief Upendra Kushwaha said, "Yesterday, there was an expectation of clarification from the EC to dispel the confusion arising in the public's mind regarding the SIR controversy. Now, matters have come forward from the EC's side with utmost clarity. For this, I express heartfelt thanks to the Commission. At the same time, I appeal to general public to remain cautious of those spreading falsehoods."

On Friday, he told *The Indian Express* that "the EC must clarify its position... it must clarify the questions being raised and concerns being flagged."

JD(S) leader and Union Minister H D Kumaraswamy, however, said, "What's going on inside EC — the difference... what we are watching in media and what is real fact — need to be spelled out by these members."

Stones, eggs thrown at Mamata faction MLA's vehicle; TMC's internal fight: BJP

Atri Mitra

Kolkata, September 26

STONES AND eggs were allegedly hurled at TMC MLA Kunal Ghosh's car in Hooghly district while he was on his way to attend Mamata Banerjee's rally in Serampore. Ghosh, who sustained injuries, claimed that miscreants attacked his vehicle at Shokher Bazar area in Uttarpara, damaging its front and rear windscreens and hurling eggs at the car.

"This is jungle raj. This cannot be tolerated. I did not get help from the police. They attacked with sharp weapons and



Kunal Ghosh claimed the attackers tried to kill him. ANI

tried to kill me," Ghosh said. Around 3.30 pm, he reached the police headquarters, Bhabani Bhavan, where his car was alleg-

edly stopped at the main gate. He said he had emailed the DGP regarding the incident.

Banerjee said, "They (BJP) are trying to stop us at any cost. We got permission from the HC 15 days back. Such atrocities are not even happening in UP and Bihar, which are also BJP-ruled. Then why has BJP unleashed so much terror on the streets?" BJP leader Rahul Sinha denied the allegations, saying it was "nothing but their (TMC's) internal fighting". MLA Dipanjan Chakraborty said people of the state had rejected Banerjee. "Peace and development is prevailing in Bengal now."

PM to kick off Puja festivities at Eden Gardens on Oct 10

Cultural programmes will feature 6,000 artistes and 3,000 dhakis, laser shows

Tanusree Bose

Kolkata, September 26

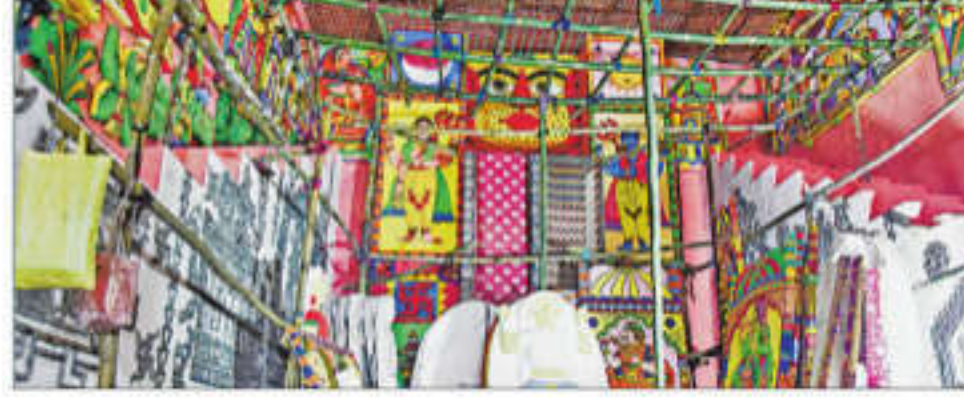
PREPARATIONS ARE in full swing at Kolkata's Eden Gardens to welcome PM Narendra Modi, who will open the grand celebration of Durga Puja on October 10 on Mahalaya.

According to sources, the PM will inaugurate five big pujas virtually from Eden Gardens — Sribhumi Sporting, Suruchi Sangha, Santosh Mitra Square, Chetla Agrani, and Tridhara Sammilani.

The PM will be greeted with the blowing of thousands of conch shells, after which Modi, along with CM Suvedu Adhikari, will tour the field in a golf cart, sources said.

Ahead of the inauguration, cultural programmes, featuring 6,000 artistes and 3,000 dhakis, will be held at Eden Gardens, sources said. There will also be a light and sound laser show and a drone show, followed by fireworks.

Sanjay Das, treasurer of the Cricket Association of Bengal



A Durga Puja pandal in Kolkata on Saturday. ANI

(CAB), said, "We will make the arrangements as the administration wants. This is the first time the PM is coming to Eden."

On Friday, the CAB held a

meeting with the state administration where a presentation of the entire programme was shown to participants. According to sources, CAB president

Sourav Ganguly, Sanjay Das, the state's Additional Chief Secretary, Kolkata Police Commissioner, KMC officials and Tourism Department officials were present.

According to CAB sources, around 35,000 spectators, including 2,500 VVIPs, are expected to attend the event for which preparations have already begun, though sources stated there will be no restrictions on entry and exit at Eden Gardens for now.

Another highlight of the event will be a musical concert, featuring composer Shantanu Maitra, Shaan, Lagnajita, Antara Mitra, and Kaushiki Chakraborty.

1994 ban to revival bid in 2016: Why Maharashtra is bringing back student polls

Pallavi Smart

Mumbai, September 26

THE LAST time the college and university students in Maharashtra voted for their representatives was in 1993. Thirty-three years later, earlier this week, the Devendra Fadnavis-led Mahayuti government took a significant step aimed at reviving the student union elections on campus.

On Thursday, the Higher and Technical Education Department constituted a 12-member committee headed by former Mumbai University Vice-Chancellor Prof Suhas Pednekar to work out a framework for the student union polls, giving the panel a month to submit its report.

The Pednekar committee will examine safeguards

against external political interference and commercialisation, management and audit of the Student Council funds, orientation and training of elected representatives, and the use of digital systems for nominations, scrutiny and grievance redressal.

It will also consider representation for women, students from reserved categories and those involved in the NSS, NCC, sports and cultural activities. Among other things, the committee will explore the digital process for the elections and keeping it free of political interference. Most student organisations have demanded that the polling should be a traditional ballot process to ensure transparency.

Pradeep Sawant from Yuva Sena, Sena (UBT) youth wing,

asked, "Is this (new) committee going to be another eyewash to calm the storm, or the government is really serious about bringing back student elections?" Santosh Gangurde, state general secretary of MNS student wing, said, "The entire decision of examining how to bring back students' election is itself a political one. How can the process be kept free of political influence?"

He also said: "Even in the ongoing protest over an IIT Bombay student's death by suicide, while there are students protesting inside, there are various political outfits who are protesting outside campus. And youth wings of various parties have also been raising voices for students' issues. The upcoming process should be inclusive of political participation although



Protest over IIT-Bombay student's suicide. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

in a restricted manner."

Over the past few months, a large section of students have hit the streets protesting over alleged irregularities in the education and exam system and demand accountability.

In July, thousands of students and youth protested across Maharashtra over NEET

paper leak. In September, the death by suicide of 20-year-old IIT Bombay student Sahil Wadke led protests on campus.

In October 1989, NSUI student leader Owen D'Souza was killed outside a Mumbai college during campaigning. The state government passed the Maharashtra Universities Act, 1994, to

ban direct, competitive student elections over concerns about money and muscle power and entry of external political organisations into campuses.

Advocate Amol Matele from NCP (SP), who has written several letters to government demanding the student elections' revival, has welcomed the move. "I wrote to Higher and Technical Education Minister, Chandrakant Patil, in August to review state's decision on putting student elections on hold. Ideally, they should have just declared to start student elections since its rules and regulations in accordance with the Lyngdoh Committee recommendations have already been prepared by the government in 2018, based on which Student Council elections were declared in 2019," said Matele.

He noted it is already too late for student elections to begin this academic year. "But the process should now be ready before next academic year begins in June, so that in July (2027) elections can be held," he added.

The first serious attempt to reverse the ban came in the 2010s. All-party discussions were held in 2013-14 on reviving it along the lines recommended by Lyngdoh Committee.

In 2016, then BJP-Shiv Sena government led by Fadnavis passed the Maharashtra Public Universities Act to revoke the ban and provide for elected Student Councils in universities, colleges and departments. It also ensured safeguards in light of the Lyngdoh framework.

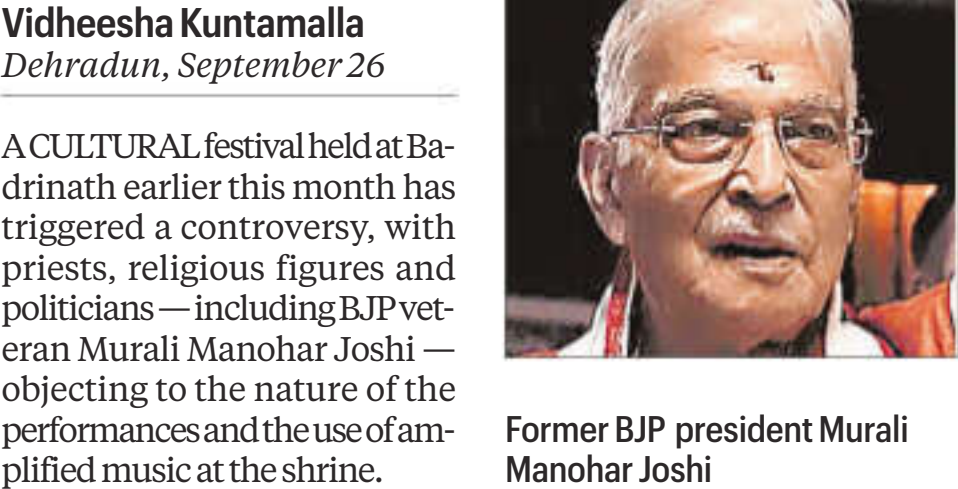
The state government framed detailed rules for the 2016 Act in 2018, following which univer-

sities prepared election schedules for 2019. Then the government stepped back again.

Weeks before the scheduled polls, the Cabinet, in August 2019, decided to put student polls on hold, citing law and order concerns and their proximity to October Assembly elections. It approved Section 99B of the Maharashtra Public Universities (Second Amendment) Ordinance, which gave the government power to defer the campus polls. Then the pandemic hit, and the state's political instability pushed the issue further down on government's agenda. Since then, universities continued with nominated Student Councils.

The Indian Express reported in August about the students' renewed demand for the campus elections.

Murali Manohar Joshi criticises music festival at Badrinath shrine



Vidheesha Kuntamalla
Dehradun, September 26

A CULTURAL festival held at Badrinath earlier this month has triggered a controversy, with priests, religious figures and politicians — including BJP veteran Murali Manohar Joshi — objecting to the nature of the performances and the use of amplified music at the shrine.

The two-day Devbhoomi Cultural Festival-2026 was held on September 19 and 20 at the Tourist Arrival Plaza in Badrinath under the Army's Operation Sadbhavana, in collaboration with the Chamoli district administration and the Uttarakhand Tourism Department. The festival was billed as an effort to showcase Uttarakhand's folk culture, local products, handicrafts, traditional food and the traditions of villages along the border.

The controversy followed videos of performances, including one by Uttarakhand singer Priyanka Meher, circulating on social media, showing amplified

programmes.

The Char Dham Teerth Purohit Mahapanchayat has objected to the use of loud music and the nature of the performances at the venue, saying activities around the shrine should conform to its religious traditions.

In a clarification issued amid the controversy, the Chamoli district administration said its role in the event was limited largely to facilitating stalls and other arrangements, while the cultural programme itself was organised by the Army.

According to the administration, the Army selected the cultural performances and decided their format. It also said that performances representing the folk culture, traditional practices and local customs of border villages, including Bamni and Mana, were part of the programme.

The administration said it had advised the local Army authorities to conduct the programme keeping in mind Badrinath's religious faith, mythological and spiritual significance, and local religious traditions.

Champat, Anil Mishra among 133 witnesses named in chargesheet

Express News Service
Lucknow, September 26

THE SPECIAL Investigation Team (SIT), probing the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, has listed 133 witnesses — including former office-bearers of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, Champat Rai and Anil Mishra — in its chargesheet against the 8 accused.

Rai served as the Trust's general secretary and Anil Mishra as a member. They resigned after the allegations of the donation theft surfaced. Other witnesses named by the SIT include Krishna Mohan, a Trust member who filed the original complaint; Gopal M Nagarkatte, also known as Gopal Rao, who was frequently invited as a special invitee to Trust meetings; and several local residents and police personnel.

The chargesheet, running to

approximately 74,000 pages, was filed before a local court in Ayodhya on Wednesday.

It is learnt that the SIT, in its chargesheet, stated allegations of donation theft first came to light when a video and a written message were sent to Champat Rai while he was travelling by train from Delhi to Ayodhya on June 4. He was informed about the cash found in a bathroom. After reaching Ayodhya, Rai was shown videos, learnt to be mentioned in the chargesheet, in which counting staff could allegedly be seen removing money while it was being counted.

The eight accused — Avinash Shukla, Lavkush Mishra, Anukul Mishra, Manish Yadav, Karunesh Pandey, Ramshankar Mishra, Ram Shankar Yadav and Subhash Srivastav — face charges of criminal breach of trust, criminal conspiracy, and offences under the Prevention of Corruption Act.

AT UN GENERAL ASSEMBLY SESSION ‘Consequences’: India warns Pak on terror after Sharif’s ‘act of war’ threat on Indus

Delhi draws world's attention to killings in PoK, Pak's treatment of minorities

Diviya A
New Delhi, September 26

HOURS AFTER Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif took over the Kashmir issue and told the United Nations General Assembly that any attempt to alter the status of the Indus Waters Treaty would be considered an "act of war", India reacted sharply Saturday, warning Pakistan of "consequences" over its export of terror, and drawing the world body's attention to the killings and violence in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir and Islamabad's treatment of minorities.

Exercising India's right to reply after Sharif's address, Petal Gahlot, First Secretary at India's Permanent Mission to the UN, while referring to Sharif as "the representative of Pakistan", rejected his allegations and underlined that Jammu and Kashmir was an "integral and inalienable part" of India and would remain so.

"This afternoon, the General Assembly heard some bizarre remarks from the representative of Pakistan. This happens just a fortnight after New York City and

the world marked the 25th anniversary of the horrendous 9/11 terrorist attack... Its mastermind, Osama bin Laden, was living right on the doorstep of the Pakistani Army's premier academy."

"They claim to uphold security during the day; they actually carry out terrorism at night... The world knows how minorities are treated in Pakistan. No pious platitude can mislead it," she said. Responding to Sharif's remarks on Kashmir, Gahlot said, "References were made to the Indian Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir. This is an integral and inalienable part of my country and will always remain so... let us turn our attention to Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir. Ask the people of Rawalakot about the wanton killings, brutal violence and denial of basic rights that they have long experienced."

Earlier, Sharif, in his address to the UNGA, raised the Kashmir issue and said people there had been waiting for the United Nations to fulfil its commitment to a "plebiscite" under its auspices.

He alleged that there had been attempts to alter the legal

status of Jammu and Kashmir through demographic changes and other measures.

Speaking on the issue of Indus waters — India put the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance in the wake of the Pahalgam terror attack in April 2025 — Sharif said that any attempt to stop, impede or divert Pakistan's share of the waters of the Indus river system would be treated as an "act of war". He again praised US President Donald Trump's "resolute and visionary leadership" and thanked him for his "timely intervention" in saving "millions of lives" in South Asia.

In her response, Gahlot said, "At the heart of the issue is the long-standing practice of cross-border terrorism by Pakistan. We demonstrated last year that terrorists will have nowhere to run and nowhere to hide. Our right to defend ourselves against terrorism will be exercised and continued. Terrorism by Pakistan will have consequences."

"We are confident that this Assembly will recognise Pakistan and its policies for what they really are, not what its representative mendaciously projects it to be..." she said. India has made clear that the Indus Waters Treaty will be kept in abeyance until Pakistan "credibly" stops cross-border terrorism.

CJI Kant defends confidentiality of Collegium dissent, bats for freedom of peaceful protest

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, September 26

CHIEF JUSTICE of India Surya Kant has defended keeping dissenting views recorded within the Supreme Court Collegium out of the public domain, saying disclosure could put judges and candidates under consideration in a publicly compromised position.

Justice Kant was responding to questions from law students during an open-house interaction at Chanakya National Law University (CNLU) in Patna on Friday evening, where he also spoke about the right to peaceful protest, financial support for first-generation lawyers, access to the profession and proposed changes to legal education.

Asked why dissenting opinions in Collegium are formally minuted but not made public, CJI said transparency had to operate within defined institutional boundaries, particularly where dignity and professional reputation of individuals under consideration were concerned. Public disclosure, he said, could place candidates and judges in an untenable position.

Students raised concerns over police action during cam-



CJI Surya Kant and Justice V Kameswar Rao during an open-house at CNLU in Patna on Friday. EXPRESS

pus protests. Responding to a question from a student, Vertika, Justice Kant reaffirmed the judiciary's commitment to protecting fundamental freedom of peaceful protest and said constitutional courts would not look the other way when lawful student expression was stifled.

On another issue concerning access to the legal profession, Justice Kant acknowledged the financial and professional difficulties faced by first-generation advocates entering practice. Referring to the Sarika Tyagi case, he advocated the creation of a dedicated professional assistance corpus, arguing that early financial support should be treated as a structural necessity

Son shot father, a cop in Chandigarh, after spat over marriage: Police

Hina Rohtaki
Chandigarh, September 26

THE CHANDIGARH Police Head Constable who died of a bullet wound on Friday was allegedly shot by his 19-year-old son after arguments over the latter's demand to marry, while the father insisted that he should wait at least until the marriageable age of 21, police sources said.

Head Constable Nitin Singh, posted in the Accounts Branch of the Chandigarh Police, was shot dead inside his Sector-22 residence. "His son, Armaan, who was initially detained for questioning, was subsequently arrested after we found discrepancies in his account of what had happened inside the house," SHO Sudesh Kumar told *The Indian Express*.

The father-son duo had an argument on the issue on Thursday night before both went to sleep, and it ended with the murder the next morning, preliminary investigation suggested. Nitin's wife, an Assistant Sub-Inspector with the Chandigarh Police, was also at home and sleeping in another room.

According to police sources, the son used a country-made

The son tried to mislead the police, saying unidentified persons had "shot papa", police said

pistol to shoot his father. Nitin's wife heard a noise and went towards the room. She found her husband lying in a pool of blood. In the chaos that followed, Armaan allegedly tried to grab his mother's neck as well. She managed to free herself and raised an alarm, sources added.

Armaan tried to mislead the police, saying unidentified persons had "shot papa", police said. During questioning and examination of the evidence, police allegedly found his version inconsistent. He was subsequently arrested. Police also recovered a country-made pistol from the house.

The murder investigation has also brought under scrutiny the 19-year-old's earlier brush with the law. He was last year arrested for allegedly running over two people while driving a friend's SUV. He was subsequently released on bail.

Two Naga civilians killed, two injured in gun attack in Manipur

Express News Service
Imphal, September 26

TWO NAGA civilians were shot dead by armed miscreants at Kalenjang village near Taphou Kuki in Manipur's Senapati district on Saturday afternoon, police said. The victims were reportedly attacked inside a house belonging to the village chief of Kalenjang. Two others were injured in the incident.

The deceased have been identified as Rocky from Chowainu village under Mao police station and Kumar from Laii Shirafii village under Tungjoy police station, both in Senapati district. Rocky belonged to the Mao Naga community, while Kumar was from the Poupmai Naga community, the police said.

It remains unclear how and under what circumstances the two Naga men were present at the Kuki village chief's residence at the time of the attack.

According to local sources, two houses in Kalenjang village were set on fire by miscreants in July. The village had been abandoned after the arson in July, the police said. A statement was also issued by the village chief, Lhingjahoi Hangshing, clarifying that the village had been abandoned.

The identities and condition of the two injured persons were not immediately known. They were rushed to a nearby hospital. A police team reached the area shortly after the incident and launched an investigation.

Condemning the killing of the civilians, Chief Minister Y. Khemchand Singh called it a "cowardly act of violence".

Former chief minister N. Biren Singh said there have been more than 60 murders this year. In a post on X, he said, "...These were civilians who deserved to live without fear... How long are we going to keep

counting bodies instead of holding those responsible accountable and bringing the deteriorating law and order situation under control?"

The latest killings come two days after four Tangkhul Naga civilians were killed in an armed attack at Pilong in Kamjong district, near the India-Myanmar border. The two incidents have further heightened concerns among Naga civil society organisations over the security of Naga residents in the state.

At least 13 people have been killed in separate gun attacks allegedly carried out by suspected militants in September in Tamenglong, Kangpokpi, Noney and Kamjong districts.

The Kalenjang incident also occurred on the day the United Naga Council (UNC) agreed to temporarily suspend its economic blockade after tripartite talks with the Centre and the Manipur government, in Assam.

EXPRESS special

On pashmina shawls, artists bring alive a voice that beckons all Kashmiris

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, September 26

PASHMINA SHAWLS have turned into art canvases. On them, the verses of the mystic Lalleshwari, popularly known as Lal Ded and revered by both Kashmiri Muslims and Kashmiri Hindus, have found expression through the paintbrush of celebrated Kashmiri artist Masood Hussain. The dyed motifs on the shawls barely touch; the dyes — at no point — have seeped into one another.

Hussain, in this unique medium pioneered alongside textile artist Mujtaba Kadri, brings to life the lush maximalism of Kashmir's design traditions and syncretic culture that has shaped the Valley in his latest exhibition, "Lal Ded -- Vaakhs of Silence". Currently on display are 20 pieces that have found a perfect home on the top floor of the luxurious Maqam, Kadri's ornately painted art studio in Rajbagh in uptown Srinagar.

"When I first saw a shawl, I was wondering how I would paint on it, because I'm used to paper and acrylic, or watercolour, and this is natural fibre," Hussain tells *The Indian Express*. Finding the right colour and tonal variations of each colour, he says, took months.

The exhibition began as a conversation between Kadri and Hussain in December 2024 and involved two years of labour.



Artists Masood Hussain and Mujtaba Kadri's art works are displayed at Maqam — a newly set up place for Kashmir arts and crafts in Srinagar. SHUAIB MASOODI

Kadri, who has been in the pashmina business for 28 years, calls it "art for Kashmir". "Everything here is so driven by the tourist market that sometimes we forget to interact with our own heritage, and what I wanted was to bring an artistic space to Kashmir for ourselves."

At first glance, the pieces may look like just paintings on cloth, but move closer and touch the fabric, and you will marvel. You see the intricacy of the designs and the elaborate work that went into every motif, a Hussain trademark. It is then surprising that for Hus-

sain, using fabric dyes to paint on Pashmina shawls — a technique earlier unheard of in the Valley — was a new lesson, at the age of 73.

Behind the pieces are Lal Ded's vaakhs, providing a cultural reference that cuts across Kashmiri communities. Hussain studied the verses for a year before allowing his imagination to render them in colour. The translations of Autar Mota — who is credited with familiarising a wider audience with Lal Ded — helped shape this journey. In the decades before these translations, Lal Ded's voice had been carried

from one generation to another in the oral tradition, so much so that her vaakhs are now an integral part of Kashmir's collective memory.

Possibly, one of Lal Ded's own vaakhs (verses) best captures the exhibition: "Ko'sam baa'gas heut' mai a'tsun/ Pa'tsi'yay man te a'tsun praa'v/ Swa roop dar'shun chu to'tuy a'tsun/ Koet chuy ga'shun pa'kun traav (I have prepared myself and entered the flower garden/ Should you wish it, make the mind fit, and you too may enter/ Within lies the direct beholding of one's own essential form/ Hence, discern what is to be reached and quicken your going.)"

Hussain, who is most celebrated for his "transparent strokes", which are said to reveal "the soul beneath the surface", has been moving between watercolour, relief, mixed media, paper pulp, oil, and installation, but learning a new style of painting still required many attempts.

Spinning the pashmina thread takes about 40 days per shawl. The weaving takes nearly 15 days. Part of preparing the pashmina for dyeing, Hussain says, is coating it with a layer of glue, "after which, it becomes like paper". The shawls are then steamed for hours before they can take the dyes — permanently.

While the inaugural exhibition took place in Srinagar, Kadri is also planning to take it outside the valley now.

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COURSE NAME	DURATION	FEES
Leather Shoe Making & Design	25 Days	FREE (Stipend also paid to Trainees)
1. Soap Making 2. Detergent Making 3. Essential Oil/ Perfume Making 4. Cosmetic items Making 5. Spice (Masala) Making 6. Agarbatti Making 7. Candle Making (Including Aromatic & Designer One's) 8. Honey Bee Keeping 9. Nail Art 10. Pottery	1 Week (5 working Days)	Registration Charges: Rs 50/- Course Fee: Rs 500/- (Female, SC/ST/OBC)
1. Fruit & Vegetable Processing 2. Kachi Ghani Oil Making 3. AC & Fridge Repair Course	2 Week	Registration forms available at the centre
1. Bakery 2. Make-up Artist 3. Beautician 4. Cutting & Tailoring	1 Months	

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NOTE:- Short duration Hobby Classes of some courses can also be organized within the premises of corporate houses/ High Commissions/ Embassies in Delhi NCR



Remembering Dr Singh

LoP Rahul Gandhi and Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi pay tribute to former Prime Minister Dr Manmohan Singh on his 94th birth anniversary, in New Delhi on Saturday. AMIT MEHRA

PM museum marks former PM's 94th anniversary with exhibition

New Delhi: An exhibition tracing former prime minister Manmohan Singh's distinguished career as an economist, scholar and a statesman was inaugurated on Saturday at the Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya on his 94th birth anniversary, officials said.

The curated exhibition titled *Dr Manmohan Singh: From Scholarship to Public Service* celebrates his legacy, contributions and public journey, the Prime Ministers' Museum and Library (PMML) said.

The exhibition traces Singh's

distinguished career as an economist, scholar and statesman. It highlights his significant contributions across academia, key economic institutions, the Ministry of Finance and the highest office of the country, the PMML said in a statement.

A central focus of the exhibition is Singh's pivotal role in shaping India's economic policies and reforms, promoting inclusive development, strengthening institutions and advancing India's engagement with the international community, it said.

PTI

As harassment cases pile, BJP MP flags 'collapsed' policing in Bihar

Santosh Singh

Patna, September 26

AS BIHAR'S Samrat Choudhary government tries to fend off the Opposition's attempt to back it into a corner over the spate of sexual harassment cases in the state, it's now facing criticism from an unlikely quarter — within its own ranks. On Saturday, BJP Rajya Sabha MP Shambhu Sharan Patel targeted the government over "deteriorating law-and-order", adding to the pressure on the ruling alliance.

"Bihar mein policing char-mara gayi hai (policing in Bihar has collapsed)," Patel told reporters, demanding a new chief secretary and DGP to regain control over the state's law and order. "We need a new chief secretary and director general of police in the state. We must thoroughly overhaul the law-and-order situation. Criminals no longer fear the law."

Patel's remarks come as a spate of sexual harassment cases has pushed the administration — and CM Samrat Choudhary — into a corner. The CM also handles the home portfolio, with the Opposition now piling on pressure for action.

'Donation racket': FIRs against 3 Gujarat parties for causing loss of over Rs 560 cr

Aditi Raja

Vadodra, September 26

THE GUJARAT Police have registered three cases against Registered Unrecognised Political Parties (RUPPs) on the basis of complaints from the Income Tax (I-T) department, alleging a Rs 560-crore loss to the exchequer through purported bogus donations of nearly Rs 1,870 crore in total.

The FIRs name four persons linked to Bharatiya National Janata Dal (BNJD), three persons associated with Swatantrata Abhiyakti Party (SAP) and eight persons linked to Garib Kalyan Party (GKP), in addition to the three parties themselves as accused. All three parties have fought elections in Gujarat since 2017.

The biggest of the three cases concerns the BNJD, which, as per the specific FIR, received Rs 1,143.85 crore from 56,238 donors, with an alleged tax loss of nearly Rs 343 crore. The Swatantrata Abhiyakti Party (SAP) allegedly received Rs 519 crore, causing a Rs 155-crore loss, while the GKP allegedly received Rs 206.76 crore, leading to an alleged loss of around Rs 62 crore.

The three RUPPs have been participating in elections in Gujarat since 2017 even though

their candidates forfeited deposits, Election Commission (EC) data shows.

A senior Gujarat Police officer told *The Indian Express* that the FIRs are based on four complaints filed by I-T Department officials accusing the parties of seeking dummy donations from shell firms and cashbacks after deducting commissions to evade tax by submitting fake documents with digital signatures to the EC.

The CID Crime, Gandhinagar Zone, registered the FIRs on Friday (September 25), under multiple provisions of the BNS dealing with cheating, criminal conspiracy, forgery and use of forged documents.

As per the I-T Department's complaint — based on scrutiny and investigations that lasted over a year, as per the Gujarat police — the parties are alleged to have rerouted political donations to donors for a commission and have caused a loss of over Rs 560 crore to the exchequer.

The FIR against SAP has named the office-bearers of the party as one Mehul Kumar Kumar Maheshkumar Khatri, Surendrasinh Parshottamdas Tiwari and chartered accountant Mukundbhai Chandansinh Rathod. According to the FIR, the party collected donations

The FIRs name four persons linked to Bharatiya National Janata Dal, three associated with Swatantrata Abhiyakti Party and eight linked to Garib Kalyan Party

from taxpayers through cheques or RTGS, issuing receipts that enabled the donors to claim a 100% deduction under Section 80GGC of the Income Tax Act.

The FIR alleges that after deducting the commission from the donation money, the party returned the remaining amount to the donors in cash after going through several layers of shell firms or bogus entities.

According to the police, the I-T Department has alleged this party "had no genuine political activity and was simply being used as a vehicle to collect commissions by rerouting money".

In the 2024 Lok Sabha election, SAP fielded Pramod Sahdevbhai Gudade from Ahmedabad East, Anilbhai Narendrabhai Chavda from Bhavnagar and Pravinbhai Ishvarbhai Chauhan from

Banaskantha. According to the police, the party's candidates remained concentrated in a limited number of constituencies rather than representing a broad statewide electoral presence.

The FIR against GKP names its president Neeraj Kumar Kshatriya, secretary Dhananjay Singh Rajput, treasurer Dhiraj Kumar Kshatriya, office-bearers Avinash Chandrakant Tiwari and Pradip Singh Parihar, and chartered accountants Kuldeepchandam Parvatsinh Tapariya, Ashokkumar Radheshyam Shah and Pankaj Agarwal.

According to the FIR, the donors transferred money through banking channels and received receipts, after which the funds were allegedly moved to firms identified as Jai Ram Enterprises and Kisan Enterprises. Fake bills showing purchases of foodgrains and other goods were allegedly created before the money was withdrawn. The FIR alleges commissions ranging from 2-10%.

The BNJD contested five seats in the 2022 Gujarat elections. Its candidates were Nikhil Bhikha Patel from Vatva, Rushabh Kaushikkumar Mehta from Ellisbridge, Molikumar Vinodchandra Shah from Anand, Kamleshkumar Jentilal Hirapara from Jamnagar South and Jagdish Manilal Meda from Garbada constituency.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

ing for 0.15% of the vote.

The BNJD FIR names party president Surendrakumar Vishnubhai Gajera and describes him as the "main accused and lynchpin" and alleges that he supervised the network and determined commission rates. Others in FIR named are General secretary Vipul Solanki, treasurer Ronaksinh Chavda and CA/auditor Adil Sayied, besides the party itself.

The BNJD complaint alleges that donations were routed through the party's bank accounts and subsequently transferred to firms including J Trading, Kajal Enterprises and Parmar Associates. False bills showing purchases of foodgrains and other goods were allegedly prepared, following which the money was withdrawn in cash. The FIR alleges commissions ranging from 2-10%.

The BNJD contested five seats in the 2022 Gujarat elections. Its candidates were Nikhil Bhikha Patel from Vatva, Rushabh Kaushikkumar Mehta from Ellisbridge, Molikumar Vinodchandra Shah from Anand, Kamleshkumar Jentilal Hirapara from Jamnagar South and Jagdish Manilal Meda from Garbada constituency.

'It was my dream to get a govt teacher job... kept trying': Meet Vijay who cleared UP teacher exam at 59 years

Manish Sahu

Lucknow, September 26

AT 59 years and seven months old, Baghat resident Vijay Kumar Sharma will embark on a new chapter of his life from Monday — stepping in as an assistant teacher at a government-aided school after spending nearly four decades teaching in private schools.

Sharma cleared the Trained Graduate Teacher (TGT) examination this year and will now join Inter College Ailum, a government-aided higher secondary school in Shamli district, located 15 km from his residence at Barawad village in Baghat



Vijay Kumar Sharma teaching at a private school in UP. EXPRESS

district. He will teach Sanskrit to students up to Class X.

"It was always my dream to get a government job as a teacher, and I made several at-

tempts over the last 27 years. I kept giving the exams, and now, at the age of 59, my dream has finally come true," said Sharma, a father of five, including three daughters, after clearing the exam conducted by the Uttar Pradesh Education Service Selection Commission (UPESSC). Kumar graduated in 1987, followed by dual postgraduate degrees in Hindi and Sanskrit, and completed his BEd in 2003.

Recounting his selection, Sharma said a vacancy opened this year for 292 posts of Sanskrit teachers. "I had cleared the written examination many times but repeatedly failed to clear the interview stage. There were

times I felt that the selection process itself was flawed, but I never let that hurdle make me feel hopeless — I kept trying... This time, there was no interview, and I believe that gave candidates like me an equal opportunity to prove ourselves," he said.

According to him, he will get about two years and a few months to teach in government schools, since the retirement age is 62. "I was born in February 1967. I will serve just over two years, but even that is deeply satisfying — it was my dream to teach at a government school," he said, adding CM Yogi Adityanath personally handed him his appointment

letter in Lucknow last Tuesday.

Vijay's two sons serve in the UP Police, while his wife, Kaushal Sharma, is a homemaker. Of his five children, four are married. Vijay's eldest daughter, Mamta Sharma, who also appeared four times for the government teacher exam, said her father is a huge inspiration for young people who give up on life over failures.

"My father failed 26 times, but I never once saw any helplessness or self-doubt in him. After our brothers were selected into the UP Police, we asked him not to take the exam anymore, but he never listened to us and kept trying," she said.

BRIDGE

There are many a time when declarer has to force an entry do dummy to succeed in his contract. Last week's problem dealt with the same theme. Dealer: East Vulnerable: North/South

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ J53		♥ AK109876	
♥ 973		♠ AK8	
♦ A102		♦ K95	
♣ KQ73		♣	

SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
	5♣		
2♣	pass	5NT	pass
6♣	pass	pass	pass

West leads the heart queen. Plan the play (trumps break 3-0). When South finds out about the three-zero trump break, he can count only ten sure tricks. He can get an eleventh trick by using the king-queen of clubs, and a twelfth trick by developing a squeeze against West.

THE WEST HAND: ♠ Q42 ♥ QJ1052 ♦ J8643 ♣

THE EAST HAND: ♠ ♥64 ♦ Q7 ♣ AJ10986542

To bring this about, declarer should win the opening lead, cash one high trump and, upon discovering the bad break, lead a low trump towards dummy's jack to create the necessary extra entry to dummy. West's best play is to win the queen of spades and continue hearts. South wins the heart continuation, leads a spade to dummy's jack, then leads the king of clubs, taking a ruffing finesse against East. It doesn't matter whether East covers or not. Suppose East covers. South ruffs and cashes all the remaining spades. In the end-position South has K-9-5 of diamonds and 8 of hearts, North, A-10 of diamonds, 9 of hearts, and Q of clubs. Declarer leads a diamond to dummy and cashes the queen of clubs, discarding a heart, to squeeze West between the red suits. From the start, East's bidding should have suggested the likelihood of a squeeze. Another slam hand for you. Dealer: South Vulnerable: None

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ 762		♠ KQJ	
♥ J85		♥ AKQ	
♦ A1052		♦ KQ83	
♣ K76		♣ AQ8	

SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
3NT	pass	6NT	pass
pass	pass		

West leads the ten of spades. East wins the spade ace and returns the spade five. Plan the play.

• SUNDAY CROSSWORD

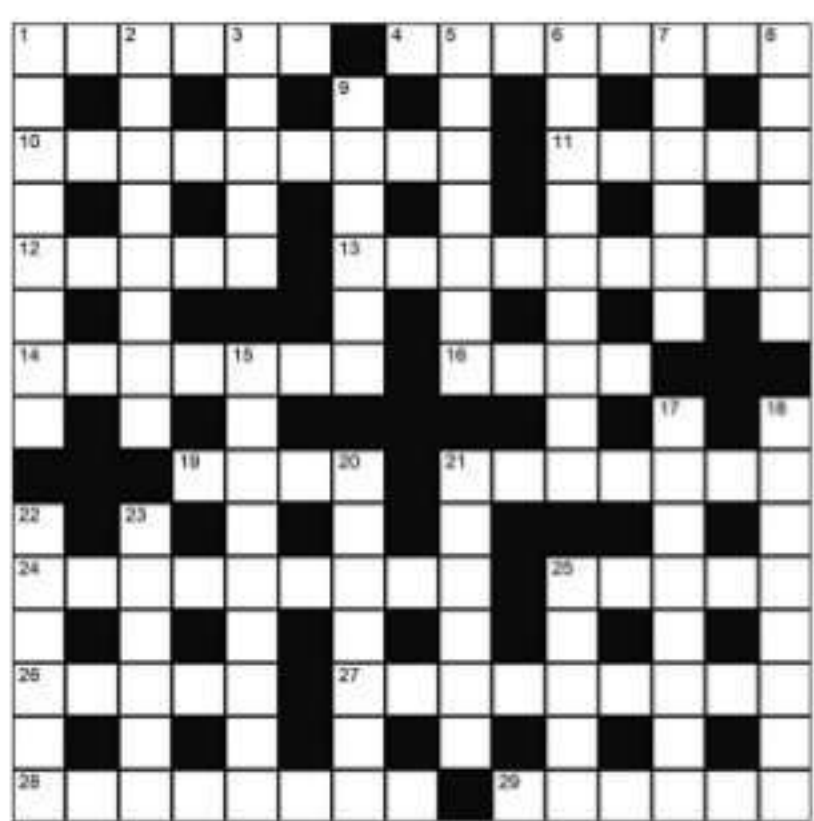
QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- Monetary unit of Ghana (6)
- Not quite (8)
- True to life or true to facts (9)
- Acquit (5)
- Excluded from (3,2)
- Aphoristic (9)
- Threats or intimidations (7)
- Got bigger (4)
- Foreign friend (4)
- Confuses, fouls up or befuddles (7)
- Not kindred (9)
- Japanese three-line poem of 17 syllables (5)
- Resided (5)
- Take another look at? (9)
- Disastrous collapse (8)
- Alignment of three celestial objects (6)

DOWN

- Acts (8)
- Commencing or inaugurating (8)
- Slight trace (5)
- Traveling by bicycle (7)
- Endorse (9)
- Puts out by force (6)
- A fellow of infinite jest (Hamlet) (6)
- Takes by theft (6)
- Done (9)
- Ability of a substance to flow (8)
- Cleverly or discerningly? (8)



- Suffer humiliation (7)
- Enrage (6)
- Soft-nosed bullet (6)
- Period of trial (6)
- Intoxicating (5)

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- It's so nice to resolve a trigonometrical term (6)
- They may toss at sea or on the pitch (8)
- From where to see the scene for what you believe to be right? (4-5)
- In winter, deer are relatively less common (5)
- Red-faced, former mayor embraces date (5)
- Team's opening bowlers stum-ped when

- in? End of story! (5,4)
- Used in making her kind of pickle (7)
- Melancholy about the first person mentioned (4)
- Torment uppity Wang (4)
- Gets back to profits once more (7)
- Relative's colleague is object of attack (4,5)
- Deposit put down for house (5)
- Flow control very necessary in valley (5)
- Cross when an extra N gets into gin-and-it, mistakenly (9)
- Prince ordering duck and hare (8)
- It might be dropped

SOLUTIONS TO 2600 QUICK CLUES ACROSS: 1 Firearm, 5 Dawdled, 9 Idiom, 10 Rebuttals, 11 Theatrics, 12 Roses, 13 Caps, 15 Endeavor, 18 Detritus, 19 Eoin, 22 Of woe, 24 Stockholm, 26 Insincere, 27 Masks, 28 Counsel, 29 Strayed **DOWN:** 1 Faints, 2 Reiterate, 3 Admit, 4 Merriment, 5 Debts, 6 Watergate, 7 Leads, 8 Desist, 14 Sergeants, 16 Discovers, 17 Ominously, 20 Zodiac, 21 Amused, 23 Wushu, 24 Swell, 25 Khmer **CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS:** 1 Beheads, 5 Moppets, 9 Gelid, 10 Dynasties, 11 Referenda, 12 Niter, 13 Writ, 15 In battle, 18 Shuffled, 19 Life, 22 Ambit, 24 Aggravate, 26 Pasturage, 27 Oboses, 28 Wheedle, 29 Slavery **DOWN:** 1 Begird, 2 Hold forth, 3 Alder, 4 Sad ending, 5 Manta, 6 Post-natal, 7 Exist, 8 Sisera, 14 Trust fund, 16 By degrees, 17 Left alone, 20 Pawpaw, 21 Jersey, 23 Baste, 24 Apace, 25 Agora

2601

in the harbour (6)

DOWN

- Press reports for many who are too old (8)
- Having stopped vacillating, made a dead set to capture one (8)
- Fast getting chilly (5)
- Unusually big task carried out by servicemen (3-4)
- Passing away as in extreme cold weather (9)
- Sat with her for the jobs of wiremen (6)
- Fairy gives a splendid start to the ceremony (6)
- China might be bad in a game (6)
- Image on the British coin prior to Queen Elizabeth? (5,4)
- Is one put up in the garden for dippers and divers? (8)
- A centre soundly built with his agreement (8)
- Golf club means to freshen up a dry old pen (4,3)
- Hardy novel about international capital (6)
- A television gives back-trouble round the Baltic state (6)
- That sounds altogether French (2,4)
- Record an article which may be stone (5)

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY SEPTEMBER 27: This is a year of new beginnings, adventures and major changes. What you do now will bring great benefits in the future.

MONDAY SEPTEMBER 28: This is a slower paced year. Rejuvenate your energy. Focus on friendships and partnerships with people who are kind, supportive and have your back. Ask for help if you need it.

TUESDAY SEPTEMBER 29: This year is about socialising and having fun. Your creativity and desire for life are at a pinnacle. Let your guard down and loosen up a bit. Old friends might reappear to rekindle relationships.

WEDNESDAY SEPTEMBER 30: This is a year of work and building foundations, both internally and externally. Take charge of your health. Stay grounded.

THURSDAY OCTOBER 1: This is a wonderful year to socialise and enjoy life. Let your guard down and loosen up a bit. Have fun, but don't lose sight of your goals. Old friends might reappear.

FRIDAY OCTOBER 2: This is a year of building structures. Simplicity is key. Take charge of your health. Physical exercise will play an important role. Stay grounded and levelheaded.

SATURDAY OCTOBER 3: This year exciting changes will give you increased personal freedom. Let go of whatever impedes your growth and progress. Be ready to act fast. Expect to travel.

• YOUR WEEK AHEAD



ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): The Moon in your sign is promoting domestic peace and happiness. It's a great day for business. But your top choice will be to socialise. This Week: Get more sleep. Make your good fortune work for you.



TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Count on getting a lot done today, especially at home. Get out into the garden or do what you can to make improvements to where you live. Family relations will be warmer. This Week: Get ready for financial opportunities and surprises.



GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Make an effort to chat with others today. You will enjoy increased popularity. Talk to others. Pleasure and fun activities are great choices. This Week: Surprises in the entertainment world and romance.



CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): You're high-viz today and you look successful. This will draw others to you. Home repairs might be on the menu. This Week: Sudden changes with home repairs and family events.



LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Do something different today. Travel if possible. If you can't travel, then be a tourist in your own town. This Week: You impress others with your original ideas.



VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Discussions about shared property, inheritances, banking issues and anything that you own jointly with someone else will go well today. Trust your moneymaking ideas. This Week: Keep an eye on your money and assets.



LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This is a feel-good day! Enjoy the company of others. Interactions with friends and groups will also be upbeat and energetic. You might use the energy of others to help get things done. This Week: Stand up for your freedom and your rights.



SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Decide to be as productive as possible today. You'll be surprised with what you will achieve. Your ambition is strong, plus your ability to attract the help of others is excellent. Make a to-do list. This Week: You have the drive to go after what you want.



SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Vacations, social outings, sports events and fun activities with kids are great choices today. Although you're tempted to put pleasure above work, you still want to work and get things done. This Week: Friends and groups will support you.



CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): This is a powerful day because the Sun is at the top of your chart. This means you make a wonderful impression on your world. Meanwhile, you're focused on your personal life and family matters. This Week: Speak up. You will be heard.



AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): If you work in sales, marketing, teaching, acting or the communications industry, you're fortunate today, because your words are like gold. You'll be persuasive, convincing and inspirational. This Week: Travel. Learn new ideas. Explore your world.



PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You can boost your earnings and assets today. Today your productivity could lead to increased wealth now and in the future. This Week: Tidy up your finances.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Security is mostly a _____. It does not exist in nature.... Life is either a daring adventure or nothing - Hellen Keller (12)

TOWER

PSYITT

ACKNPU

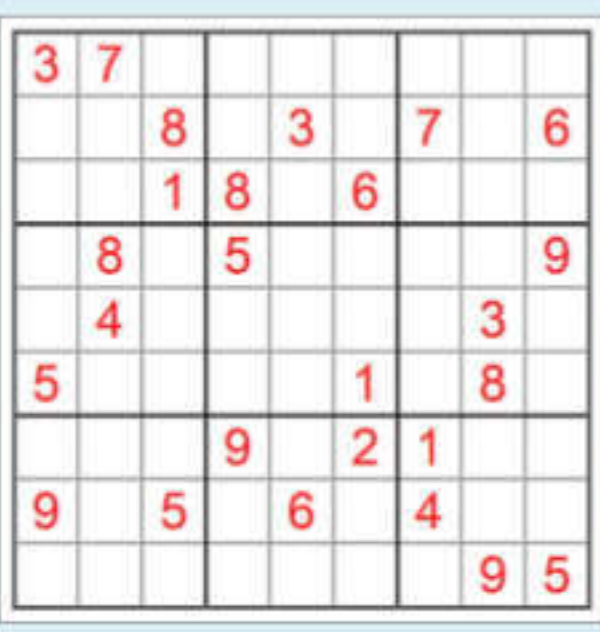
EUISS

ANSWER: Security is mostly a **superstition**. It does not exist in nature.... Life is either a daring adventure or nothing - Hellen Keller

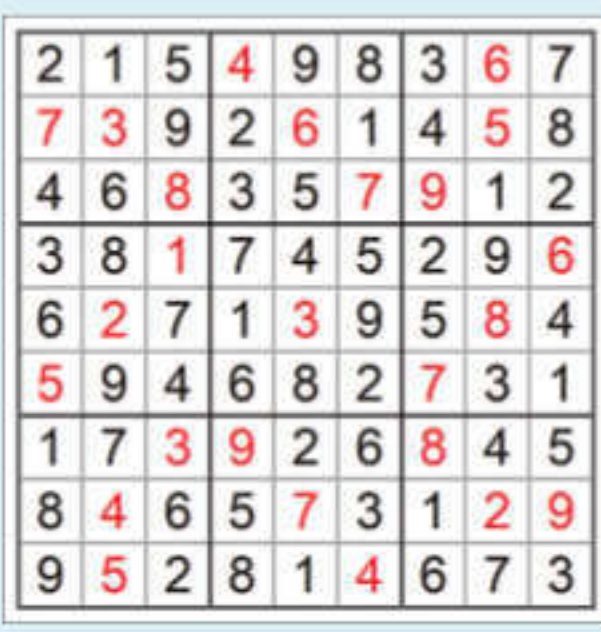
SUDOKU 6454

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius



SOLUTION SUDOKU 6453



Char Dham Yatra suspended, schools shut in Uttarakhand

Press Trust of India
Dehradun, September 26

HEAVY RAIN disrupted normal life in Uttarakhand, where authorities had to suspend Char Dham Yatra till September 27. The Yatra, which has already been suspended multiple times this year due to inclement weather conditions, was paused once again on Saturday till September 27. Schools were shut in five districts as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued ‘Red’ and ‘Orange’ alerts for several parts of the state. Most parts of the state have been experiencing heavy rain since morning, while high-altitude areas witnessed intermittent snowfall. So far, there have been no reports of casualties or major damage in the state, officials said.

Bhopal gets draft master plan: 51-km growth corridor proposed

Express News Service
Bhopal, September 26

DAYS AFTER the Supreme Court allowed the Madhya Pradesh government to publish a new masterplan for its capital city, Bhopal, the government on Saturday released the draft of the Bhopal Development Plan-2047. It proposes a new framework for the capital’s expansion with greater emphasis on green areas, mixed land use, redevelopment and metropolitan-scale planning. This is the first master plan for the city in over two decades, with the last approved plan notified in 1995 for a planning horizon ending in 2005. The most significant expansion proposal is a 51-km Growth Corridor, with approximately 3,000 hectares earmarked for development. Planned as an economic and urban spine, it will link the proposed Education Knowledge Artificial Intelligence (EKAI) City, airport, proposed CMU, logistics and wholesale areas and suburban developments. The plan envisages a mix of hotels, healthcare, IT and AI infrastructure, logistics, wholesale trade, malls, corporate offices, educational institutions and housing. The corridor is also intended to connect with regional routes towards Vidisha, Raisen, Narmadapuram and Indore, with areas around it as transit-oriented zones. Despite the scale of proposed expansion, the plan increases the city’s planned green footprint — from approximately 16% in the 2005 plan to 27% under the 2047 plan. The draft places particular emphasis on protecting Bhojtal and its catchment, forests, hills, ponds, water bodies and tiger movement corridors. Open space at the colony level is proposed to increase from 10% to 12%. A Green Transfer of Development Rights (TDR) mechanism has been proposed to compensate landowners whose land falls in designated green areas while allowing development rights to be transferred elsewhere.

Record rain lashes 63 districts across Uttar Pradesh, six dead

Press Trust of India
Lucknow, September 26

SIX PEOPLE died in rain-related incidents in Uttar Pradesh as several parts of the state witnessed downpour, with 63 districts recording rainfall above normal and some areas facing a moderate risk of flash floods. The heavy rain, thunderstorms and strong winds also damaged standing crops in rural areas and over 100 houses across the state, as it received 19 times the normal rainfall in the past 24 hours, according to officials. Lucknow recorded 125.8 mm of rainfall in the 21 hours ending Saturday morning; Farukhabad recorded 200 times its normal rainfall, while Kanpur Nagar received 160 times and Kannauj, Kanpur Dehat and Hardoi 130 times the normal rainfall. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast heavy to very heavy rainfall at several places in eastern Uttar Pradesh on Saturday, while thunderstorms and gusty



A waterlogged street in Lucknow on Saturday. VISHAL SRIVASTAV

winds are also likely. Rain and thundershowers may continue at several places on Sunday. The latest weather system, a depression over northeast Madhya Pradesh and adjoining north Chhattisgarh, was moving north-northwestwards towards southeast Uttar Pradesh. At 5.30 am on Saturday, it was centred about 230 km south of Prayagraj, officials said. The system is likely to remain a depression while moving towards southeast Uttar Pradesh till Saturday evening and subsequently weaken gradually into a well-marked low-pressure area during the following 12 hours, the IMD said. The weather office warned of heavy to very heavy rainfall across several parts of the state. Some watersheds (drainage basins) in central and Terai regions face a light to moderate risk of flash floods during the next 24 hours, it said.

Ex-principal of Gujarat school held for ‘raping’ minor student

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, September 26

THE FORMER principal of a residential school in Gujarat’s Kutch district was arrested on Saturday, a day after he was booked for allegedly raping a teenaged, minor student of the same school. The local police are now on the lookout for a school trustee, its administrator and the hostel warden for allegedly covering up the incident, which came to light only a month later. On Friday, the girl’s parents filed a rape complaint. The police inspector investigating the matter told *The Indian Express* that the accused,

who was terminated from service in August, was nabbed from a town in Anand district on Saturday.

In mid-August, a teacher at the school found a pregnancy test kit in the lobby of the institute. The teacher took the test kit to the hostel warden, who, in turn, checked CCTV footage.

The inspector said, “The warden found that the pregnancy test kit had fallen out of the pocket of the school principal, which set off an internal investigation that led them to finding out about the rape. The trustee then dismissed the principal from service. They informed the parents of the student and sent her home.”

Odisha starts evacuating people as rivers swell due to heavy rain

Press Trust of India
Bhubaneswar, Balasore, September 26

THE ODISHA government on Saturday started shifting people in low-lying areas to safety as all rivers in the state have swelled due to heavy rainfall over the past few days, and the Hirakud Dam has opened 16 gates to release excess water into the Mahanadi, officials said.

Flash floods have been reported from Balasore, Bhadrak, Jajpur, Kalahandi, Koraput, Nabarangpur, Malkangiri, Keonjhar and Jagatsinghpur districts. In Balasore alone, 14,660 people in 91 villages were affected as rivers flowing in spate inundated vast swathes of land. An official said 3,268 people have been removed from these areas.

According to officials at the Water Resources Department, 11 more gates of the Hirakud Dam had to be opened on Saturday to release excess water from the reservoir.

• BRIEFLY



Shimla and Dharamshala received light rain on Saturday. PTI

HIMACHAL PRADESH

Met predicts rain till September 29; Kinnaur gets season’s 1st snowfall

THE HIGHER reaches of Kinnaur witnessed light snowfall on Saturday, marking the season’s first snowfall in tribal district, while many parts of Himachal Pradesh, including Shimla and Dharamshala, received light rain. The Kuno Charang area under Pooh tehsil in Kinnaur received snowfall during the day, while rest of the district received rainfall. The Shimla Met centre has predicted continuous rain across the state till September 29, after which it will decrease in intensity. While light rain will continue in middle hills, the weather will be dry in the plains, low and high hills till October 2, the weather office said. The Met office has issued orange and yellow alerts, forecasting heavy rainfall in the state on September 27. PTI

Men open fire in Jamshedpur mall, 4 injured

FOUR PERSONS were seriously injured after unidentified men opened fire at a mall on Saturday afternoon, a police officer said. The victims were having food at a restaurant in Bindal Mall, which is located within Sonari police station limits, when the assailants allegedly opened fire indiscriminately. The accused fired 11 rounds, police said. Prima facie, personal enmity is suspected to be the reason, an officer said. Police examined CCTV camera footage and identified one of the accused, they said. A search operation is underway to track perpetrators, who fled the spot, police said. PTI

Punjab cop held ‘with over 3 kg heroin, weapons’

A PUNJAB Police inspector, posted in the Counter Intelligence wing, was arrested after over 3 kg heroin and weapons were allegedly seized from his car in Ferozepur, police said on Saturday. Acting on a tip-off, police set up a checkpoint and intercepted the car of inspector Baldev Singh on Ferozepur-Moga road, said a senior police officer. “During the search of the vehicle, the police recovered 3.350 kg heroin, six pistols with magazines, four additional magazines, seven live rounds and six mobile phones,” Ferozepur Senior Superintendent of Police Bhupinder Singh said. PTI

Man killed near police station, protests in Alwar

Parul Kulshrestha
Jaipur, September 26

THE DAYLIGHT killing of a 40-year-old near a police station in Rajasthan’s Alwar by a man who, police say, is mentally unstable has prompted protests and questions about the police response.

On September 24, Saikun Khan, of Bada Vas, went to Baroda Meo market on his motorcycle to buy a tyre, the police said. According to inspector Rajkumar, Khan dropped his fellow villager Noor Mohammad near a bank and was passing in front of the Baroda Meo police station around 10 am when the accused, Harsh Moortikar, allegedly stopped him, pulled him off the motorcycle and attacked his head repeatedly with a stone.

“There was no enmity between the two, and they didn’t know each other. It seems like the accused has some mental health issues. The incident happened on the left side of the police station, and as soon as we got to know about it, we reached the spot and arrested the accused. He has been presented before a magistrate. We will get a psychiatric evaluation done.”



Saikun Khan

Police denied speculation that the attack was communal in nature. Khan was rushed to a community health centre and later referred to Alwar, but died while being taken to the district hospital.

The killing led to protests outside the Baroda Meo police station and Alwar district hospital. Protesters demanded action against personnel posted at the station, compensation for Khan’s family and a probe into the circumstances of his death. Protesters also blocked the Alwar-Bharatpur road, disrupting traffic on September 24, while additional police teams were deployed in the area.

Tikaram Jolly, the Congress MLA from Alwar, called the incident a “black stain on the forehead of Rajasthan’s law and order”.

EXPRESS special

AK-47 bullets, Pakistan flags, and old rivalry: Inside ‘plot’ to frame Poonch jeweller

Arun Sharma
Jammu, September 25

ON SEPTEMBER 19, when security forces in J&K found AK-47 ammunition, some Pakistani currency notes and flags, and militants’ posters during search at a local jewellery shop in Poonch town’s main market, the first instinct of investigators was to treat it as a terror case. But the probe took an unexpected turn. Investigators allegedly unravelled a series of phone calls and messages all seemingly from Pakistan, a business rivalry and, most importantly, a conspiracy to frame a family in a terror investigation.

The J&K Police has taken into custody three persons — Amandeep Singh, Arvind and Mumtaz — for what the police said is a conspiracy to frame the family of Davinder Singh, owner of Ruby Jewellers. Police are also now looking for two others — brothers Gandeep Singh and Hardeep

Singh, who they said were the masterminds of the alleged plot. Amandeep Singh and Arvind are employees at a rival jewellery business, Saijan Jewellers. Mumtaz is a history-sheeter in police records. Police claim the plot had the Singh brothers, owners of Saijan Jewellers, at its centre.

The police’s suspicion that the material had been planted was later confirmed by Poonch SSP Shafqat Hussain, who said it had been placed on the premises by someone else, although he declined to share details of the investigation.

The raids

According to security sources, on September 19, J&K Police got a tip-off about some incriminating material at Ruby Jewellers. The information came from a “credible source”, prompting troops and some local police to conduct searches at the shop.

The search, sources say, led

the team to find five live AK-47 rounds, Pakistani currency worth Rs 105, 30 posters with alleged terror links, and two Pakistani flags just inside a door on the second floor. “An Army officer approached us seeking deployment of some policemen for this,” the officer said. “We asked him to verify his information again, but he insisted that the source was credible.”

By the time the security forces knocked on the family’s door that day, the family claims to have witnessed a series of events that puzzled them — unexplained phone calls, text messages, and even a previous police raid. The problem, according to the family, had been particularly acute since Davinder Singh’s return from Dehradun after two years.

“My daughter received a WhatsApp message from a Pakistani number asking ‘*Kam Kaisa Chal Raha Hai*’ (How’s your work going?). A text to my nephew, who had been run-

ning the shop in my absence, said: ‘*Aap ka samaan us jagah deliver ho jayega*’ (Your material will be delivered at that place),” Devinder Singh said. “But we didn’t respond to either and informed the police.”

What really began to raise suspicion among investigators was the manner in which the “incriminating” materials were found. “It was lying bare and uncovered on the floor, giving the impression that these were dropped by someone from an open space above the door,” a senior police officer said.

The Army left the investigation to the local police, who sent the seized material to an FSL. As they awaited results, the police began to dig deeper. The first thread they pulled was the bitter rivalry between Ruby and Saijan — the two jewellery businesses — and they picked up Aman-deep, an employee at the rival jewellers, for questioning. According to sources, that led the police to Mumtaz, a man from

Surankote that the police said bought the incriminating materials found at Ruby Jewellers.

“He had 13 FIRs against him and had previously been detained under the PSA. He had come out of jail recently,” a police officer told *The Indian Express*.

Devinder Singh’s family claims the Singh brothers of the rival shop were relatives and that “attempts to frame him in some terror case had begun around the same time he returned home two-three months ago”.

“The Army had raided my premises earlier too, claiming to have traced a call from a Pakistani number to one of my family members. However, they left after they found nothing incriminating,” he said.

The family alleges that on April 21, Rupinder Kour was assaulted by Singh brothers after she allegedly objected to liquor bottles being thrown at their house. An FIR has been registered in that case.



Sumitra (right) and her husband Satbir Singh

terview on October 26, 1988.

“All 43 others from our village were selected as daily wagers, and after two years, had

their services regularised at the plant. Sumitra and I, meanwhile, remained without regular employment and continued

working for factories and private companies,” Singh says.

In 1989, she approached a sub-judge in Karnal, who ruled in her favour. This came after a deputy manager at the IOC admitted that Sumitra “had fulfilled all the eligibility conditions but was not taken as she was a woman”.

Subsequent court rulings in the Karnal district court in 1993 and the Punjab and Haryana High Court in October 2025 went against her. This January, Sumitra approached the Supreme Court. In its defence in the SC, the IOC argued that Sumitra’s claim was based on the deputy commissioner’s recommendation that providing a job

to everyone whose land was acquired was “neither legally binding nor mandatory”.

“The question, however, which was required to be examined, was somewhat different. The issue is whether the appellant, having been treated as eligible, called for interview and subjected to the same recruitment processes as like [the] other candidates, could thereafter be excluded from consideration merely because she was a lady?” said a Bench of Justice Aravind Kumar and Justice Vipul M Pancholi.

The explanation that the work involved handling of cylinders, working at odd hours, and predominantly with male

employees “cannot be a lawful basis for excluding an otherwise eligible woman candidate when Corporation’s own recruitment requisition declared that women were eligible”, the court said.

Much has changed since she first approached court in 1990 — she’s now older, has two grown sons, both unemployed, and an illness forced her out of a job and into early retirement. The family now gets by with Satbir Singh’s income of Rs 20,000 as clerk-cum-supervisor at a factory in Panipat.

“I deserved more — at least pensionary benefits extended to others who were recruited with me in 1988,” she said.

• IN 1988, THEN 24-YEAR-OLD SUMITRA HAD APPLIED FOR A ROLE AT IOC’S BOTTLING PLANT IN KARNAL; A LONG LEGAL BATTLE AND A Rs 12 LAKH-COMPENSATION LATER, SHE SAYS SHE DESERVED MORE

Denied a day job for being a woman, Sumitra wins 37-yr battle against PSU giant

Sukhbir Siwach
Chandigarh, September 26

SUMITRA WAS 24 when she first applied for the peon or khalasi (helper) position at the state-owned Indian Oil Corporation’s (IOC) LPG bottling plant in her village Guda in Haryana’s Karnal. The pay was a measly Rs 34/day, but it was a job that came with pensionary benefits, and Sumitra was certain she would crack it — after all, she made it to the interview.

But when the final appointment letters came, 43 of the 49 people who had applied from her village made it through, but she was not one of them. “I was told it’s because I’m a woman.

All 43 gradually got promoted to the post of supervisor, and eventually earned a monthly salary of around Rs 1.5 lakh and pension benefits. But I was left to work for private companies and earn between Rs 100 and Rs 14,000 a month.”

Today, 63-year-old Sumitra feels vindicated. On September 17, the Supreme Court found the IOC’s ground for refusal discriminatory and awarded her compensation of Rs 12 lakh. For Sumitra, the ruling came after 36 years of legal battle — longer than her actual tenure would have been. “My husband wrote letters to the then chief minister and prime minister, but nothing came of it.”

Sumitra was registered as an unemployed person with the Employment Exchange in Gharaunda, Karnal, when the IOC decided to acquire village land to set up an LPG bottling plant.

Sumitra’s husband Satbir Singh, who has closely followed the legal battle over the years, says: “The IOC acquired 120 acres of land—80 acres of which belonged to the village panchayat and the remaining 40 acres was acquired from farmers—promising jobs to local youths.”

Among those who made it to the interview was Sumitra, who had studied up to Class 12. All 49 shortlisted candidates were asked to appear for an in-

IIT-B to dinner table, the camera is on



PARTHA SINHA

OUTSIDE IIT-Delhi last month, after a young student's death, protesters noticed a man who filmed everything and photographed nothing. No press card, no lanyard, only a phone held with the studied carelessness of someone pretending not to hold one. Word moved through the crowd in the efficient, unreliable way rumours do: plainclothes police, collecting faces for a file somewhere.

The students did not convene a seminar on privacy. They raised their own phones and filmed him back — 40 small black mirrors turned upon the watcher. By the time they met the administration, every chair had acquired its own cameraman. What might once have been a conversation became a production with 40 directors, each certain that his recording would contain the truth.

A few hundred kilometres south, at IIT-Bombay, a quieter version of the same story arrived this week: A student caught by a lens mid-exam, allegedly borrowing an answer from a chatbot because his own supply had run short. By nightfall, the exam was the least of it. Within hours, he had taken his own life — the fourth such loss on that campus in a single year. By

morning, his phone was in an evidence bag and the hostel's cameras were being re-played, frame by patient frame, reconstructing where he had gone and what he had done. The invigilator's eye had been quick enough to catch a stolen glance at a screen. No comparable instrument existed for the distress underneath it.

We have built formidable surveillance for small dishonesties, and almost none for the larger unravelling beneath them. The lens is exquisite at proof. It has never once been any good at care.

Both will be filed, eventually, under procedure — a disciplinary hearing, a departmental enquiry, a line in somebody's record. Filed there, both will be filed slightly wrong. Delhi wasn't really about a plainclothes man, and Bombay wasn't really about a chatbot. In both places, the camera had become more than a witness. It had entered the event itself.

I thought of an old hostel mate from IIT-Kharagpur who spent years at NASA's Jet Propulsion Laboratory working on imaging technology related to the sensors that would eventually transform the mobile phone. He still holds patents connected to that work. Such sensors were refined partly so cameras could travel aboard spacecraft and look at distant planets. Their greater consequence was here on Earth: they made human beings look constantly at one another.

The camera used to appear on occasions — weddings, holidays, a child beside a birthday cake, all of us standing stiffly before the Taj Mahal. You performed briefly for it and then returned to

The camera used to appear on occasions — weddings, holidays, a child beside a birthday cake, all of us standing stiffly before the Taj Mahal. You performed briefly for it and then returned to life.

life. The phone camera reversed the arrangement. Life now appears briefly between performances.

Meals cool while being photographed. Accidents acquire spectators before they acquire help. Children learn their good side before they learn long division. The police record protesters, protesters record police, and everyone records himself recording everyone else. Memory, once private and notoriously inaccurate, has become public evidence — still inaccurate, but available in high definition.

We Indians had understood the danger of concentrated attention long before Silicon Valley gave it a valuation. We called it *nazar*. The black dot on a baby's cheek and the lemon and chillies above a shop carried an old social intelligence. To be looked at too intensely, by people whose intentions you could not know, was a form of exposure. Attention could take something from you.

The aunty at the window also watched, of course. The neighbourhood gaze was nosy, disciplinary and occasionally cruel. But it was human in one important respect — it forgot. It returned to its tea, found a new scandal, forgave by Tuesday. The digital gaze has an employer and unlimited storage. It reports to the State when trained on a protest, to a platform when trained on a teenager, and to the crowd when trained on somebody's worst 10 seconds. Shame wanted to keep you within the community. Surveillance wants to keep your file.

Jeremy Bentham imagined a prison in which one unseen watchman might be looking at every prisoner. We have built the opposite architecture and reached much

the same destination. Everyone is visible, everyone is watching, and nobody knows who occupies the tower. We arrange the table because a photograph may be taken. We adjust the face because a video may survive. We begin experiencing ourselves from the viewpoint of an audience that has not yet arrived.

A second self now stands just outside us and asks how the moment will look. That self can protect us: without a camera, authority owns the only version of events. The students at IIT-Delhi were right to film the man filming them. A watched species eventually grows an eye of its own, if only for the dignity of saying, "I saw you seeing me".

But an eye grown for defence does not close when the danger passes. It follows us home, to dinner, into grief. We film the concert instead of hearing it, the funeral instead of mourning, the child instead of watching him become himself. The sensor was built to extend human sight towards worlds we may never visit. Its deepest effect has been here: it has made ordinary life behave as though it may later be called as a witness.

We once photographed what we wanted to remember. Now we photograph because we are afraid of what others may say happened. Somewhere between Mars and the IIT courtyard, the camera stopped being an instrument of memory and became a negotiation over reality. Forty phones rise. The watcher becomes watched. Everybody has proof. Nobody, quite, is present.

The writer is a senior advisory professional

Democracy at work or disaster



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

IN TIMES of trouble, the worst thing a government can do is respond with arrogance and disdain. Narendra Modi is among the most skilled and sophisticated political leaders I have ever met, but this is one lesson he appears not to have learned. So, when this newspaper published its excellent investigation into the Election Commission last week, his response was to deploy his most articulate spokesmen onto TV chat shows and social media platforms to fight back hard. They did, but in the stupidest, most arrogant way.

With smug expressions and fake smiles pasted on their faces, they repeated, ad nauseum, that serious disagreements among the three election commissioners were a sign that India was a 'vibrant democracy'. A puzzling and farcical viewpoint. But afterwards, the ones who are always too clever by half changed tactics and as usual, blamed the Congress Party. They recounted how many times election commissioners had been controlled by the government in Congress times. Names such as Naveen Chawla and MS Gill were brought up to prove this. One was a family friend of the Gandhis, and the other had been rewarded with a seat in the Rajya Sabha and made a minister after he retired from the Election Commission. True.

It is also true that elections in Kashmir were openly rigged for decades. But does that justify what has been done now, in the name of the Special Intensive Revision, or SIR, to give it the acronym that has gained a notoriety that strikes dread in the hearts of those whose election credentials it seeks to 'revise'? Shashi Tharoor wrote a detailed and disturbing piece in this newspaper last week, so I am not going to go into the numbers of voters who have been deleted wrongly. What I learned from it was that half the Delhi voters had been deleted. And in West Bengal nearly all those who had appealed against being deleted had found their voting rights restored after appealing to tribunals, but by then the election was over.

There have been doubts about this SIR for months, as there have been about the integrity of the election process itself. Rahul Gandhi has led the charge and in Bihar tried to make 'vote chori' the fulcrum of his campaign. I have been among those who doubted the charges because I continue to believe that no matter how much tampering happens, and it does, it usually does not change the result of an election. Besides, if you have been in journalism for as long as I have, it is hard to forget how bad things used to be. Especially in rural India.

I remember ballot boxes being stolen by mafioso-types. I remember lower caste voters being forced to vote with a gun pointed at them by rural thugs. One reason so many criminals ended up in Parliament and our legislative assemblies is because these mafias discovered that if they could win elections for others, they might as well start winning for themselves. In the process, they discovered that there was more money to be made from 'serving the people' than from crime. Indian democracy has been deeply damaged because of this.

So, what happens now that Gyanesh Kumar has become the villain of a very ugly story? If I were him (thankfully I am not), I would gracefully exit the stage after declaring with a pained expression on my face that I have done no wrong but am happy to resign until a commission of inquiry establishes my innocence. Who knows, but he may have done this by the time you read this piece — which would be good for him. But the damage done to the Modi government still needs repair.

It needs to prove to the Indian people that it has not been trying to steal elections by disqualifying voters who do not vote BJP and by conducting an SIR that now has a huge cloud hanging over it. Instead of ordering its supporters and social media trolls to bang on about toolkits and foreign money, it should spend some time introspecting about why so many things are starting to go so wrong. Why is Modi these days appearing to be constantly misreading the political mood? When the Cockroach Janta Party descended on Jantar Mantar, there was such mishandling that shooting at students with pellet guns became more important than paper leaks. Then came the disastrous handling of Modi's birthday celebrations. The acres of 'diyas of blessing' that were lit brought shame to the birthday boy when small children were seen collecting oil from *diyas* to take home for their families.

The latest mishandling has been the way his government responded to *The Indian Express* story. BJP spokesmen were seen openly defending Gyanesh Kumar on TV and social media without anyone noticing that, in doing this, they were proving the opposition parties' charge that the Election Commission had become a tool of the government. With so many things going so wrong, the Prime Minister needs to conduct a special intensive revision of his team if he wants to regain a measure of lost credibility. And if he has not already asked Gyanesh Kumar to make a graceful exit, he would do well to do so because he has become a major liability for the government. Besides, it can be said with certainty that he has lost the trust of voters.

The writer is Assistant Editor, The Indian Express

Memories of Maharashtra's 1972 drought



HISTORY HEADLINE
BY SHUBHANGI KHAPRE

WITH EL Niño causing rainfall deficits and crop losses in rural Maharashtra, the state could be heading for a drought. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis said last week, "We are bracing for a severe drought, which could be worse than 1972." NCP (SP) chief Sharad Pawar said the same: "This year's drought could be worse than 1972."

From 1960 to 2026, Maharashtra has gone through at least 15 droughts. Yet, 1972 remains unparalleled for many reasons. The state of Maharashtra, which came into existence on May 1, 1960, was beginning to settle down, focusing on agriculture to drive its rural economy, when devastation struck. Much of the state, especially Marathwada, Vidarbha and parts of Western Maharashtra, was dependent on rain-fed agriculture. However, the south-west monsoon's failure for three consecutive years, beginning 1970, would break the backbone of its rural economy and culminate in the worst famine the state has witnessed in 1972.

During that time, the calamity — devastated nearly 75 to 80 per cent of Maharashtra's population of 5.4 crore, with official records putting the number of affected between 1.8 crore and 2 crore. This havoc was unprecedented for a state actively evolving a cooperative-sector economic model.

In 1972, Maharashtra had 26 districts, and 21 had been drought-affected. Now, the state has 36 districts, and 21 have logged rainfall deficits. With the lack of rain turning vast swathes of agricultural land into barren fields in 1972, farmers became most vulnerable. The question before them was how to survive?

The water in wells, lakes, and rivers had dried. With no food grains to draw sustenance from, no water to drink, and no work to earn from, rural Maharashtra, for the first time in its history, saw mass migration to urban ghettos. In Mumbai (then Bombay), the population rose by 3.5 lakh in the drought year.

The Maharashtra government, then led by the Congress's longest-serving CM, Vasantrao Naik, took some drastic and innovative decisions, redefining the socio-economic policies of the state and the nation. Of them, the Employment Guarantee Scheme (EGS) remains relevant to this day. The idea came from a visionary Gandhian leader, also the first state legislative council chairman — VS Page. Based on the concept that work is a fundamental right, a government resolution for EGS was issued in March 1972.

Through the EGS, villagers rendered jobless by the drought were given an alternative to agricultural work they no longer had. Major public works, such as water and soil conservation, digging wells, building tanks and ponds, and constructing canals and roads, were undertaken across the rural belt with heavy government backing. During the worst of the drought, the state poured over Rs 200 crore into the scheme. While nearly 15 lakh enrolled during the initial rollout, estimates suggest that over the course of the crisis, the program absorbed a record one crore workers.

Another critical decision taken to avert starvation deaths was providing villagers with *sukdi*, a calorie-dense, nutrition-rich supplement made from wheat flour, jaggery, and oil or ghee. Amid the domestic shortage of food grains, *sukdi* utilised substandard red wheat imported from the US under aid programmes. During this crisis, the Public Distribution System (PDS), which provided essential grains through fair-price ration shops, emerged as a foundational component of the state's drought relief measures.

In 1978, the government adopted the EGS Act, which mandated providing unemployed people in rural Maharashtra with jobs on daily wages within 15 days. Tailored for drought mitigation as an emergency measure, the Act soon became a model for the country through the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Act, 2005. The calamity also hit the cattle and farm animals hard. But, despite the severity of the crisis, human starvation deaths were avoided, even as malnutrition persisted.

Decades later, history threatens to repeat itself. Moreover, as All India Kisan Sabha national president Ashok Dhawale says, "The 1972 drought was catastrophic. But what we are heading for is going to be far more dangerous." The prolonged dry spell, says noted water expert Pradeep Purandare, has made winter rabi season uncertain. "We failed miserably in addressing challenges in water conservation. We are still stuck in a 19th-century irrigation system, which is not compatible with the demands of the 21st century."

The writer is Senior Editor, The Indian Express

Filter coffee doesn't wake you up, it's what you wake up for



VIBHA KRISHNAMURTHY

I HATE it when someone says, "Let's meet for a coffee", and means it literally. Why not talk over ice-cream? Or a walk? At least then I won't be sitting in a cafe, confronted with a menu that has 12 different kinds of coffee and a choice of regular/skimmed/almond/oat milk. Apart from disliking the cognitive burden of making these choices, I find they taste uniformly awful. I love coffee, but unfortunately only one kind, the kind my father makes.

I learnt to drink South Indian filter coffee as a teen during my summer holidays in Tamil Nadu. Every May, my sister and I made the 48-hour journey by train, with my mother, from Delhi to Tamil Nadu. At some point during the lazy summer, my mother would swoop down on us and announce that we needed to meet our relatives, to 'get to know our culture'. My sister and I were sullen and truculent, having been plucked out from a *sapota* tree in my grandfather's backyard. As soon as we entered the relatives' home, the lady of the house would ask if we wanted coffee. If I said no, she would ask "Tea?" in a tone that conveyed how disappointed she was in me. When I declined, she would look relieved and disappear into the kitchen. She would emerge in a bit and triumphantly plonk a glass of lukewarm Horlicks, or worse, rose milk, in front of me. I quickly learnt to accept the initial offer of coffee.

Back home in Delhi, my father was a filter coffee aficionado before it was a thing in boudie restaurants. As children, we woke up to the annoying sound of the coffee grinder every morning. The aroma of fresh grounds is the background to my memories of getting ready for school on cold winter mornings. My father was bright-eyed and



The American Heart Association says 3-5 cups of coffee a day may be beneficial for metabolism.

GETTY IMAGES

bushy-tailed at 5 am, going to the kitchen with alacrity, so he could begin the process. Hot water would drip slowly through the fresh grounds in the stainless-steel filter, taking its time to travel through and soak in the flavour. When the decoction was finally ready, it was mixed with steaming hot milk and a bit of sugar. No spoon could sully the tumbler's insides. The mixing involved swishing the milk, decoction, and sugar between the *dabara* and tumbler. My father would be appalled if I shared the stereotype of a groggy person reaching for his first cup of coffee to wake himself up. For my father, coffee is not a thing that wakes you up; it is what you wake up for.

I asked my father a few months ago how he learnt to make coffee. His answer had me learn to travel back 82 years, to my father's home in Salem, Tamil Nadu. Krishnamurthy, 10, is in the kitchen at 6:30 am, before he leaves for school. The skinny boy in his school uniform lights the *kari adupu* — the wood-fired stove in the kitchen. His mother is 'out of doors', the euphemism for having your periods, literally and figuratively. She is peering in through the kitchen window and giving him instructions. I imagine her saying, "Now, put three heaped spoons of coffee powder in the filter, and be careful with the hot water..." Three days she gets to rest, so she does not complain about being banished from the kitchen. But she misses her coffee, and her son loves to come in early, before the house

is awake, and make her coffee. He hands it to her between the bars on the window and watches her. His face lights up as she closes her eyes and sighs.

Cut to over eight decades later, we are in my father's kitchen. We are just back from our morning walk. I tell my father that it is now official: coffee is good for your health. Apparently, it heals livers that have been ravaged by modern diets. The American Heart Association just announced that three to five cups of coffee a day may be beneficial for metabolism. The tone is prescriptive, sort of like a recommendation for fish oil or vitamins. But in my father's home, the making of coffee is and remains a spiritual experience. He is a bit sad because drinking more than half a cup now gives him heartburn. He still loves making it, though, for those who enjoy it. I watch him and Karun, my 25-year-old son, as they make it together.

Karun listens intently as my dad explains to him how to pack the coffee powder: first, wet it with water ("50 ccs, no more!"). Then he instructs him to add more hot water to the filter. He knows that Karun carries his stainless-steel filter all over the world in his backpack. He eschews coffee shops and coffee machines. My Dad potters about the kitchen, measuring and heating, and finally hands me my tumbler. He scans my face as I take my first sip. "It's perfect" I say, and he beams.

The writer is a developmental paediatrician

Women, lust, and no apologies

Stories all the more refreshing.

Be it Radhika Apte's Kalindi exploring intimacy in an open marriage (S1) to Tilotama Shome's Ishita finding her release in someone else's union (S2), or Kiara Advani's Megha (S1) finding her mojo in a vibrator (the series is said of have encouraged many women to invest in such devices) to Mrunal Thakur's Veda (S2) confiding in her *dadi* that she did not orgasm, *Lust Stories*' women are not brushing aside sex as something that they do for men. They want to feel wanted and are taking the lead in making it happen.

And they don't always have to look young and conventionally desirable while at it. I can still not forget the image of a very-much-in-her-middle-age Manisha Koirala emerging from the sea in a swimming costume, and without a hint of makeup, as her lover outside marriage, the friend of her husband no less, sighs on with desire.

These women pursue pleasure, because they want it. Because it is as much a bodily need for them as it is for men. It is not something they are doing out of "majboori" or as a favour, or as a means to an end. Sana



SHE SAID
BY DEEPIKA SINGH

Thampi's Lisa (in the brilliantly directed Kiran Rao chapter in S3) may be a little bit guilty of the latter but pleasure, again, was a very big part of why she was doing what she did.

My favourite part? I still can't decide. While Apte's Kalindi reminds me a little of myself — a woman not wanting to be inside a conventional box but still feeling all the conflicts and pain that convention brings — I want to be Koirala's Reena as I grow older: a successful career woman who is comfortable in her skin, steals whatever frame she is in, and is not one to take all the blame for something in which she is just one of the participants.

I loved Apte's Padma in S3 as she says "Hum Kandivali mein rehte hain" to Konkona Sen Sharma's suggestion of a couple swap, and felt deeply for Radikha Madan's Sailee (again S3) whose hunger for her husband doesn't shield her from the painful realisation that love, and lust, may not always be enough.

But what surprised and delighted me the most is Aditi Rao Hydari's Saira in Season 3. In Siddharth's Badru, she has the ro-

mance-novel husband: They are very much in love and regularly make time for intimacy. But then, a Mills-and-Boons type book makes her realise what she didn't know she has been missing. And so, she goes on to write her own story, quite literally. Because in Hyderabad, people make love in Hyderabad Urdu. "English *nakko*", as she says in a fantasy.

And in weaving her fantasies, she helps the rest of us see the fantasies we didn't know we had. Who could have thought that what we needed to fix 2026 was the sight of a towel-clad Siddharth? Move over, Ranbir Kapoor.

There is a scene where Saira gazes at Badru dusting off his Yamaha, shakes off a thousand dirty thoughts forming in her head, and goes: "Reham, mere miyaan. Reham (have mercy, my love)". Us, Saira Jaan. Us.

The writer is Assistant Editor, The Indian Express

Editor (Planning & Projects) Shalini Langer curates the fortnightly 'She Said' column

RISING POWER DEMAND TRIGGERS EMERGENCY MEASURES

Captive coal plants asked to run at full capacity from Oct 1

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, September 26

AMID RISING power demand, the Centre on Friday invoked emergency mechanisms to issue directions to about 112 captive coal-fired power plants to operate at maximum capacity from October 1 till December 31. The country is witnessing an unusual surge in electricity demand this September, with peak power demand nearing the level recorded during peak summer. On September 10, the country's peak power demand touched 269 gigawatt (GW), the highest-ever peak demand recorded for the month. So far, the peak power demand for the year was 270 GW which was recorded during the peak summer in May. A captive power plant is a dedicated power-generation facility which is built and operated by an industrial company or a group of factories primarily to supply electricity for their own use, rather than selling power to the public grid.

The direction has been issued under Section 11 of the Electricity Act, which allows the government to mandate power generation in extraordinary circumstances.

The directive is applicable to all coal-based captive power plants with 50 megawatt capacity and above which will be required to "operate and generate power to the maximum extent of their available capacity."

"The generators shall offer their available surplus generation, after meeting their own captive demand, through the power exchanges, in accordance



India is witnessing an unusual surge in electricity demand this September, nearing peak summer levels. REUTERS

with the applicable market regulations and procedures," it read.

The government said the move was aimed at maximising electricity availability. "Entire capacity of all the sources of generating electricity including the captive generating plants" needs to be utilised to the maximum possible extent, it said, asking the generators to maintain adequate coal stock to ensure availability of fuel for operation of the plant and enable maximum generation.

"The generators shall submit a weekly report to the Central Electricity Authority indicating generation, captive consumption and sale of power through the power exchanges/other permitted avenues, along with details of available capacity and coal stock, as may be prescribed," it added.

Separately, the power ministry also extended the same emergency mechanism to Tata Power's imported coal-based plant, Coastal Gujarat Power Ltd, till December 31.

Notably, the plant has been running under this provision since March, and it was slated to end this month.

Before March, the 4 GW capacity plant had remained largely idle for nearly six months due to high fuel costs and the absence of a viable power purchase arrangement. Earlier this year, the Gujarat government also gave approval of a revised power purchase arrangement with the plant, clearing the way for the resumption of long-term supply from the plant.

A senior government official said the emergency provision was extended only to Tata Power's plant, as other imported coal-based plants were operational and were not facing any challenges.

The invocation of the emergency provisions is not unprecedented. The government has invoked it in previous years during peak summer months to ensure adequate power supply.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Net FDI inflows surge to \$7.3 bn in July, highest since May 2021

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 26

AMID CONTINUED pressure on the external front due to changes in the global investment environment and better opportunities elsewhere, India saw a jump in net foreign direct investment (FDI) inflows in July, with data released late Friday by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) showing that it soared to an over five-year high of \$7.35 billion. This is the highest monthly inflow since May 2021's \$8.80 billion.

On a gross basis, FDI in July was \$14.58 billion, the third-highest in the last six years.

Compared to July 2025, the latest net and gross FDI figures are up 64% and 24%, respectively.

The latest FDI print comes even as the government warns of challenges on the external front, with Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran cautioning on Friday that "even if even if we tick (all the) boxes", money may not flow in immediately.

"You can do everything right, the public will see that there is no result, and will therefore be clamouring for more. But the point is global context has shifted," Nageswaran had said at an event, adding that higher global interest rates, among other factors, were key factors.

The government and the RBI have tried to encourage foreign inflows in the last four months, with the concessional swap window for Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) de-

posits turning out to be overwhelmingly successful. However, the rupee is not too far away from its all-time low of 96.96 per dollar. It closed at 95.82 on Friday.

"Communication, financial and computer services were the major sectors, receiving more than four-fifths of the equity inflows," the RBI said in its monthly State of the Economy article. "Mauritius, the UAE, and the US were the major source countries, accounting for about 70% of equity inflows."

For the first four months of 2026-27, net FDI inflows amounted to \$13.43 billion, up 38% from the same period last year. Meanwhile, gross FDI was 13% higher at \$43.85 billion.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

6 states had 67% share in cost of pvt projects sanctioned by banks in FY26

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 26

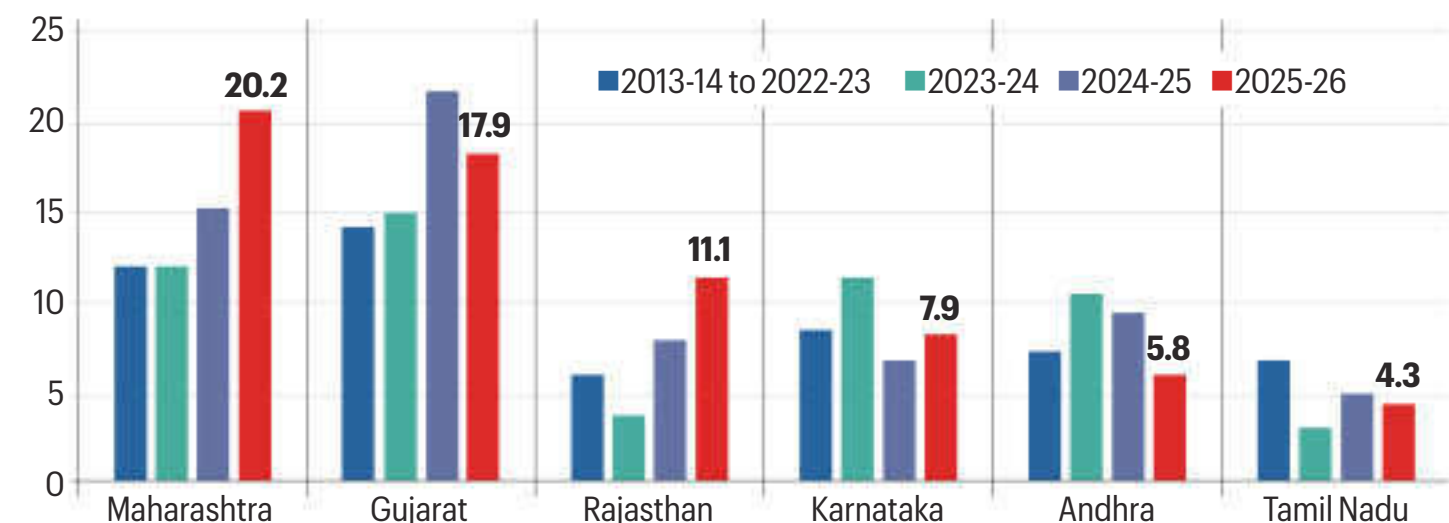
SIX STATES, led by Maharashtra and Gujarat, accounted for 67.1% of the total project cost sanctioned by banks and financial institutions (FIs) in 2025-26, as private-sector investment intentions strengthened, according to a Reserve Bank of India study.

Maharashtra overtook Gujarat to emerge as the largest destination for projects sanctioned by banks and financial institutions, accounting for projects worth about Rs 88,880 crore, or 20.2% of the total Rs 4.4 lakh crore sanctioned during FY26. Gujarat followed with Rs 78,760 crore (17.9%), while Rajasthan accounted for Rs 48,840 crore (11.1%).

The increase in project sanctions came against the backdrop of a strengthening investment cycle. The aggregate cost of projects sanctioned by select banks and financial institutions rose to Rs 4.4 lakh crore in 2025-26 from Rs 3.7 lakh crore in 2024-25, an increase of nearly 19%.

The RBI study, authored by Purnendu Kumar, Snigdha Yogindran, Sukti Khandekar and Bhavyashree K, said the increase reflected sustained investment intentions in the private corporate sector. The study also said the investment outlook was expected to remain healthy in 2026-27. Karnataka accounted for Rs 34,760 crore, or 7.9%, while Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu accounted for Rs 25,520 crore (5.8%) and Rs 18,920 crore (4.3%), respectively. Together, the six states accounted for about Rs 2.96 lakh crore, or 67.1%, of the total project cost sanctioned by select

● Share of major states in sanctioned project cost (in %)



SOURCE: DATA ON PROJECT FINANCE GATHERED FROM SELECT BANKS/FIS AND RBI STAFF CALCULATIONS

banks and financial institutions in FY26. Northern states like UP, Bihar and MP are way down in attracting projects.

In 2024-25, Gujarat had the largest share of project investment sanctioned by banks and financial institutions, at 20.6%, or about Rs 76,220 crore of the total Rs 3.7 lakh crore. Maharashtra followed with a 14.6% share, or Rs 54,020 crore.

Maharashtra and Gujarat together accounted for about 38% of the total project cost sanctioned in FY26.

The state-wise distribution points to a shift in the geography of investment. The shares of Maharashtra, Rajasthan and Karnataka increased from the previous year, while Gujarat's share declined from 20.6% in 2024-25 to 17.9% in 2025-26. Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu also recorded lower shares than in the previous year.

Banks and financial institutions sanctioned 1,032 projects in FY26, compared with 907 projects a year earlier. Banks and FIs financed about 55% of the aggregate project cost, implying financing of

roughly Rs 2.4 lakh crore against the sanctioned projects, as per the RBI Monthly Bulletin. The investment picture becomes broader when sources of funding outside the banking system are included.

During FY26, 509 private non-financial companies raised about Rs 1 lakh crore through external commercial borrowings (ECBs) for capital expenditure. Another 298 companies raised Rs 23,809 crore through domestic equity issuances under the IPO route to fund capital expenditure. These companies were not part of the project-financing data reported by the select banks and financial institutions covered in the RBI survey.

Taken together, investment intentions were recorded for 1,839 projects involving Rs 5.6 lakh crore in FY26, compared with 1,581 projects involving Rs 5 lakh crore in FY25. This is an increase of about 16% in the number of projects and 12% in the value of investment intentions.

The RBI analysis also points to a gradual change in the size composition of investment projects in the post-

India-US trade deal

90% done, says

State Dept Official

New York: The US-India trade deal is going to "unleash another level" of bilateral relations that haven't been accomplished in decades, a senior State Department official has said.

He said the two countries were "90% there" with the deal, with only a few final issues being worked out.

"I would say stay tuned, which we keep saying, but we are very close. It's like a 90-per cent-plus there and just those final things being worked out, so I hope you're going to see something very soon on that," the official said.

"And that's really going to just unleash another level of US-India relations, something that we haven't been able to get there in decades when it comes to trade. This has always been the most sticking point in the relationship. And so I think we're very close and it's going to be, I think, very, very exciting when we get there," he said. PTI

Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Ltd.
Notice Inviting Tenders (E-Tendering Process)

Specification No.	Tender Inviting Authority	Name of the Work
M.260	CE / MM	Supply and erection of 16 MVA 33_11 KV Indoor Cable Box Type Power Transformers

For details of works / Procurement / Due date of submission / Opening, viewing and downloading of e-tenders, please visit the websites www.tnpdcl.org, www.tenders.tn.gov.in, www.tntenders.gov.in **DIPR/2949/Tender/2026**

Rajasthan State Road Development And Construction Corporation Ltd., JAIPUR.
No. NT/2026-27/7431-44 Date: 25.09.2026

निविदा सूचना/2026-27

निम्नलिखित कार्य के लिए केन्द्र/राज्य सरकार के अधिकाधिक विभागों एवं उनके अधिकृत संगठनों में पंजीकृत एवं अनुपस्थिति संवेदकों की निष्पत्ति प्रत्यक्ष में ई-प्रोक्चरमेंट प्रक्रिया हेतु ऑनलाईन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती है:-

कार्य का विवरण	कार्य की कुल अनुमानित लागत (₹.)	निविदा सूचना संख्या
Strengthening/Renewal Proposal for SH-134, Triveni-Jahazpur-Deoli on Jahazpur-Mandalgarh Road. UBN: RRC2627NSOB006010	402.87 Lakh	अनकारालय ई-374/26-27
SITE of 250 KLD STP and 25 KLD Effluent Treatment Plant at Govt. Hospital, Naganur. UBN: RRC2627NSOB006069	230.00 Lakh	
Const. of Govt. Senior Secondary/Upper Primary/Primary Schools in Rural Area in District Sikar (Khadra, Bhairupura Jangir and Dajod & Khicho ki Johri, Pसाना) (Total 4 Schools) UBN: RRC2627NSOB006041	499.00 Lakh	अनकारालय ई-376/26-27
Const. of Govt. Senior Secondary/Upper Primary Schools in Rural Area in District Sikar (Mokhalwas, Tirulopura & Shyampur) (Total 3 Schools) UBN: RRC2627NSOB006012	465.50 Lakh	

निविदा के सम्बंधित प्रश्न में निविदा बुक, फोरम रजि, डाकडल करने व खोलने को तब तक रजिस्ट्रार समुचित विवरण एवं संशोधन केसाईट: <http://procrajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.rajjasthan.nic.in> तथा <http://pwr.rajjasthan.gov.in/rsrde> पर देखा जा सकता है। इच्छुक संवेदकों को अपने निविदात हस्ताक्षर के साथम से केसाईट <http://procrajasthan.gov.in> पर रजिस्टर्ड करवाना आवश्यक है।

महाराष्ट्रकर

VASANTDADA SUGAR INSTITUTE
Manjari Bk, Tal. Haveli, Dist. Pune 412307.
Ph.: 020-26902316/26902286 Website : www.vsisugar.com

e-TENDER NOTICE

We are inviting e-tender for the following works.

Sr. No.	Name Of Works
1	Proposed Construction of advanced Photoperiodic and Speed Breeding Facilities for Sugarcane at VSI, Pune
2	Construction of Civil works in the Alcohol Technological Park at Manjari Campus
3	Providing & Fixing Chain link Fencing for Demonstration Plots at Manjari

From the reputed / registered Government / PWD Civil contractors or having bid capacity equivalent amount of work can apply for tender which is on Item Rate/percentage basis.

● **NOTE** : For Detailed tender notice please visit MKCL Website : <https://sugarmart.sets.co.in> All right to reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason whatsoever is reserved by VSI.

Director General

GUJARAT METRO RAIL CORPORATION (GMRC) LIMITED
(SPV of Govt. of India and Govt. of Gujarat)
Block No.1, First Floor, Karmayogi Bhavan, Sector 10/A, Gandhinagar, 382010, Gujarat. (CIN): U60200GJ2010SGC059407

TENDER NOTIFICATION
Dated : 27.09.2026

E-Tenders are invited from reputed and experienced Contractors for the following tender :

Tender No. and Name	Tender Fees
Tender No.: GMRC/CONS/STNS+VDCT - 6/2026 "Construction of 4.84 km Elevated Viaduct from Veer Sawarkar Sports Complex to Arhant Nagar, including 5 Nos. Elevated Stations of Ahmedabad Metro Rail Project"	INR 50,000/-
Tender No.: GMRC/CONS/STNS+VDCT - 7/2026 "Construction of 4.62 km Elevated Viaduct from Dudheshwar to Vadaj, including 3 Nos. Elevated Stations of Ahmedabad Metro Rail Project"	INR 50,000/-

Interested bidders are requested to visit <https://tender.nprocure.com> for eligibility criteria, applying / downloading the tender document from **07.10.2026 onwards. Last date and time for Bid Submissions is 15:00 Hrs. on 21.11.2026.**

Any alterations in Eligibility Criteria and terms of the Tender Document, or any amendment to the Tender Document, etc, will be uploaded on <https://tender.nprocure.com> and GMRC's Website www.gujaratmetrorail.com without any obligation or press notification or other proclamation.

Director (P&P), GMRC

Centre notifies 2 offshore mineral blocks near Great Nicobar

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, September 26

THE MINISTRY of Mines has notified two more offshore mineral blocks near Great Nicobar Island in the Andaman Sea, covering a combined area of 1,632 square kilometres, for grant of composite licences for polymetallic nodules and crusts.

A composite licence requires the successful bidder to undertake further exploration and establish the mineral potential of the block before proceeding to mining operations.

The two blocks are West Sewell Ridge-01, off Great Nicobar Island, covering 1,000 square kilometres, and Sewell Rise-01, in the southern part of Sewell Rise near Great Nicobar Island, covering 632 square kilometres.

Polymetallic nodules and crusts are seabed mineral deposits containing metals such as nickel, cobalt, manganese, copper and rare earth elements.

The latest notification comes after the ministry failed to auction seven offshore mineral blocks containing the same minerals in the same area during the country's first-ever auction of offshore mineral blocks.

In November 2024, the ministry had put 13 offshore mineral blocks up for auction for grant of composite licences, including seven blocks near Great Nicobar Island.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
DEPARTMENT OF SPACE
CMG, SDSC - SHAR SRIHARIKOTA - 524124

Brief E- TENDER NOTICE: CORRIGENDUM-III (SALE EXTENSION)
e-Tender Notice No.CMG/C/CON/268716 Dtd 06-08-2026
Corrigendum Dt:25-09-2026

Refer above Tender No. for "Planning, Design, Construction, Commissioning of Crew Isolation and GAGANYATRI NIVAS facility at SDSC SHAR Sriharikota, Tirupati District of Andhra Pradesh (Civil, PH, Road, Site development, Swimming pool, Landscape, Electrical, AC, and allied works in EPC MODE- II). (Est. cost ₹2602 Lakhs);

Sale period extended up to 06.10.2026

Interested tenderer may visit <https://www.isro.gov.in/Tenders.html> or www.tenderwizard.com/ISRO for details.

SD/- GROUP HEAD, CMG/SDSC SHAR

BENGALURU NORTH CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Executive Engineer, Dasarahalli Division, Zone-2, MEI Layout, Hesarghatta Main Road, Bagalagunte, T. Dasarahalli, Bengaluru - 560073.

No: BNCC/EE/DD/TEND/15/2026-27 Date: 25-09-2026

INVITATION FOR TENDERS (IFT) - (SHORT TERM)
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal only)

The Executive Engineer, Dasarahalli Division, Zone-2, BNCC, Bengaluru invites Tenders from eligible Tenderers for the Construction of Works detailed below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work / Category
SINGLE COVER SYSTEM	
1	Repair and Maintenance of Footpaths at Kammagondanahalli in Ward No. 66: (Call-2) - (ST) - Estimated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 25.00, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 25,000/-
2	Improvements to Roads and Drain in Ashoka Nagara, Munikondappa Layout and Surrounding Area in Ward No. 18, Bagalagunte. (Call-3) - (Others) - Estimated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 42.37, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 85,000/-
3	Improvements to Roads, Drains and Culverts in Kalasti Nagara (Block No. 106-1) in Ward No. 19, T. Dasarahalli. (Call-3) - (Others) - Estimated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 10.22, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 25,000/-
TWO COVER SYSTEM	
4	Providing Thermoplastic Painting for Rumbler Strips, Lane Marking, Junction Markings, Different Types of Sign Boards, Pelicon Signals and Kerb Stones, HRPC and Other Safety Furniture's as per Traffic Police Requests in Dasarahalli Division. (Call-2) - (Others) - Estimated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 202.47, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 3,03,800/-
5	Improvements to Roads, Drains and Culverts at Chikkasandra in Ward No. 17, T. Dasarahalli Sub Division. (Call-3) - (Others) - Estimated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 84.75, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 1,69,500/-
6	Improvements to Roads, Drains and Culverts at Abbiger in Ward No. 15, Shettyhalli Sub Division. (Call-3) - (Others) - Estimated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 84.70, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 1,69,400/-

Calendar of Events: 1) Tender Documents may be Downloaded from the GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> from 30-09-2026. 2) Last Date for Submission of Queries (for SI No. 4 to 6): 08-10-2026 before 16.30 Hours. 3) Pre Bid Meeting will be held on (for SI No. 4 to 6): 09-10-2026 at 15.00 Hours in the Office of the Chief Engineer, Zone-2, BNCC, Bengaluru. 4) Tenders must be Submitted online through Karnataka Public Procurement Portal on or before 16.00 Hours, on 15-10-2026. 5) Technical Bids will be Opened on the Website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> at the Office of the Executive Engineer, Dasarahalli Division, BNCC on 16-10-2026 at 16.30 Hours. 6) Financial Bids will be Opened on the Website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> at the Office of the Executive Engineer, Dasarahalli Division, BNCC on 17-10-2026 at 16.30 Hours (if Possible). Further details can be had from the above office.

Sd/- Executive Engineer,
 Dasarahalli Division, Zone-2, BNCC.

IRAN IS NOT SEEKING WAR, BUT WILL DEFEND ITSELF AGAINST THREATS AND ATTACKS: PEZESHKIAN

Trump rejects Iranian proposal to open Hormuz and end fighting

Says Tehran wants to reopen the Strait urgently due to its economic woes

Reuters
Washington, Cairo, United Nations, September 26

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Saturday he had rejected an Iranian proposal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz and end fighting in West Asia.

Iran raised the initiative at the UN General Assembly in New York, saying it had been transmitted to the Americans via Qatari mediators and that it could reopen the strategic waterway and put an end to hostilities in the region within seven days.

But in comments to reporters at the White House, Trump said: "I reject their proposal. ... I rejected their deal. They want to make a deal to open the Hormuz Strait immediately because they're losing so badly. We're winning tremendously."

"They want to make a deal and I think that's fine, I like making a deal too. What they want to do is immediately open the Hormuz Strait ... because they have no money coming in, because they get their money from the Hormuz Strait," Trump said.

The US has imposed an economic blockade on Iran to put pressure on Tehran to lift its blockade of Hormuz, which has drastically reduced shipping through the strait, even though Trump again asserted that the US had control of the waterway.

The *Wall Street Journal* first reported that Trump had rejected the Iranian proposal, citing unnamed US officials.

It said Trump was privately sceptical that Iran would meet his demands and had told his staff that he sees a renewed bombing campaign as likely after the November US midterm elections to Congress.

A US official had said earlier that discussions with Iran through mediators were "positive and constructive".

The Iranians also engaged their Saudi rivals regarding the Strait, underscoring stakes of a seven-month-old conflict that has disrupted oil flows through a critical shipping lane and taken a toll on the global economy.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi told reporters at the United Nations on



US President Donald Trump speaks to mediapersons as he departs the White House on the South Lawn in Washington on Saturday. REUTERS

Friday the proposed deal would trigger a seven-day countdown to reopening the strait and a pause in regional fighting.

"If there is seriousness on the US side to come to a deal and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, everything is now prepared," Araghchi said. If the US were to agree, the warring parties could start wider talks "on mutually agreed subjects."

That could potentially include discussions of Iran's nuclear programme. Trump has said Tehran must never acquire a nuclear bomb, while a senior Iranian official told *Reuters* Iran

would show no flexibility over its nuclear programme even if the US accepted its peace deal.

Iran would grant no concessions over its rights, including enriching uranium or shipping its highly enriched uranium out of the country, the official said.

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, in an interview with the CBS show *Face the Nation*, said Tehran was ready for talks on its nuclear programme and other issues, but would not accept "bullying or coercion".

"Iran is not seeking war, but will defend itself against pressure, threats and attacks," Pezesh-

Houthi missiles and drones intercepted, says Saudi coalition

Cairo: Yemen's Saudi-led coalition said early on Saturday it had intercepted two ballistic missiles and two drones launched by the Iran-backed Houthis towards the kingdom.

The coalition said the missiles were headed towards Khamsi Mushait and the drones towards the capital, Riyadh, adding that it was monitoring the missile threat and drones launched at the kingdom, without providing further details.

The Saudi civil defence had sent alerts overnight for Khamsi Mushait and Abha but not for Riyadh. REUTERS

kian said, adding it had already agreed that "we're not supposed to develop nuclear weapons".

Previous attempts at diplomacy have failed to end the war, which began on February 28 with US and Israeli attacks.

Since then the war has alternated between pauses and renewed strikes, killing thousands while degrading Iran's conventional forces and damaging Iran's already ailing economy.

China, US agree to \$30bn tariff cut, AI dialogue during Xi visit

Chinese Foreign Ministry: The two sides also agreed to set up trade council

Reuters
Shanghai, September 26

CHINA SAID on Saturday it had agreed with the US on a \$30 billion reciprocal tariff-reduction arrangement and on launching a dialogue on AI, under an eight-point consensus reached during President Xi Jinping's visit to Washington.

The two sides have also agreed to set up a trade council and extend the outcomes of earlier talks in Kuala Lumpur, the Chinese Foreign Ministry said.

The agreement follows an earlier move by world's two largest economies to extend by two months a trade truce that had been due to expire on November 10, allowing more time to work on a potentially bigger trade deal, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said Wednesday.

The three-day summit between Xi and President Donald Trump, which ended on Friday, showcased personal diplomacy rather than big public breakthroughs. Xi has since landed in Beijing, Chinese news agency *Xinhua* reported Saturday.

"This historic visit enriched the constructive and stable China-US relationship, upheld the overall stability of bilateral ties, opened a new chapter in China-US relations, and will have a far-reaching impact on world peace and development," Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi said in a statement.

On artificial intelligence, the two sides agreed to hold a dialogue on the technology's risks



US President Donald Trump and First Lady Melania Trump with Chinese President Xi Jinping and his wife, Peng Liyuan, in the Red Room of the White House on Friday. REUTERS

Trump says he does not want to 'integrate' with China on AI

Washington: President Donald Trump said on Saturday that despite a "big talk" this week with Chinese President Xi Jinping on AI, the US should not join efforts with China on the technology.

"We had a big talk on SI," Trump told reporters at the White House, using his preferred name of super intelligence.

"What they want to do is stop our progress because we're lead-

ing China by a lot, and we're going to keep it that way. We didn't spend that much time talking about it," he added.

Trump said he did not want to "integrate" AI initiatives with China because of US dominance. "I would rather not integrate because we're leading by a lot," he said, adding: "When you're leading, you don't open it up to each other". REUTERS

Russian, Ukrainian strikes leave 10 dead as aerial war escalates

Associated Press
Kyiv, September 26

RUSSIAN ATTACKS killed four people across Ukraine on Saturday, officials said, as the aerial war between Moscow and Kyiv intensifies. Russia has hammered Ukraine with cruise and ballistic missiles, powerful glide bombs and jet-powered drones while front-line progress has slowed, nearly five years after Moscow launched a full-scale invasion of its neighbour.

"It is essential that our partners not forget: Russia is escalating every single day. If the Russians have chosen to make their strikes even more brutal, the world must choose stronger responses to keep the war from spreading further," Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy wrote on Saturday morning.

He listed "numerous strikes on residential homes" in the cities of Kyiv and Zaporizhzhia, and the Odesa, Sumy, and Kharkiv regions. Two women in Zaporizhzhia died when they were trapped beneath the rubble of their home, Zaporizhzhia's military administration said.

Putin says Ukraine peace proposals remain on table

Moscow: Russian President Vladimir Putin said Friday all proposals for a settlement in the 4-1/2-year-old war with Ukraine remained on the table, but Moscow still needed to assess what was in its best interests.

Putin also said Moscow had been ready to resume negotiations with Kyiv after last week's Russian parliamentary elections, but Ukraine launched attacks on Moscow and hit polling stations.

"They are all on the table. It's all possible," he said. "But after everything they have done, we will still have to think carefully about what we need to do in response." REUTERS

Meanwhile, Ukraine's long-range drones have targeted Russian oil refineries and businesses. A drone attack killed three people and wounded two, officials in Krasnodar said Saturday.



Deluge Brings Bangkok To Standstill

Flooded streets in Bangkok on Saturday after heavy rain lashed Thailand's capital since Thursday, disrupting traffic and forcing hundreds into emergency shelters. More than 84,000 people across 21 provinces were affected by flooding. AP

13 killed, 30 injured in suicide attack at police checkpoint in KPK province

Press Trust of India
Peshawar, September 26

AT LEAST 13 people, including two women and two children, were killed and 30 sustained injuries when an explosives-laden vehicle rammed into a police checkpoint in northwest Pakistan Saturday, an official said.

According to Pakistan's national emergency response service Rescue 1122, the incident occurred in Darazinda tehsil of Dera Ismail Khan district, near the border between the restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan provinces.

The banned terror outfit Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) has claimed responsibility for the attack.

A suicide bomber rammed a

tractor-trolley loaded with explosives into a joint police and customs checkpoint in the Aman Mela area, Regional Police Officer Khan Mubashir Malik said.

The checkpoint had been set up to curb smuggling and check the illegal movement of goods along the Dera Ismail Khan-Quetta road.

The blast destroyed a large portion of the checkpoint and completely demolished a nearby house, killing four people, including two children.

Overall, 13 people were killed, including the suicide bomber, six excise and customs department officials, two policemen, two women and two children, a security officer said, adding 30 sustained injuries.

The injured were shifted to

the District Headquarters Hospital for treatment, while the bodies were also taken there.

In a related development, Rescue 1122 said two of its workers were killed while another was seriously injured when an ambulance transporting some bodies recovered from the blast site was targeted by unidentified assailants.

President Asif Ali Zardari condemned the blast in a statement issued by his office and expressed grief over the casualties.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Governor Faisal Karim Kundi condemned the attack and sought a report from the concerned officials, while Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi expressed condolences to the bereaved families.

At UN, Russian and German Foreign Ministers hold first talks since 2022

Reuters
United Nations, September 26

RUSSIA AND Germany's foreign ministers met on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly on Saturday, officials from both sides said, in the first such talks since before Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022.

Russia's Sergei Lavrov and Germany's Johann Wadephul discussed bilateral relations and the war in Ukraine, the Russian foreign ministry said.

Wadephul urged Russia to do "everything possible to reach an agreement on grain exports via the Black Sea", a German delegation source said.

Russian and Ukrainian exports via the Black Sea have been sharply curtailed in recent months as Kyiv and Moscow targeted each other's port infrastructure and vessels. Ukraine and its allies are now pushing to secure a limited ceasefire in the Black Sea and on strikes on energy infrastructure.

Russia has not given any clear indication publicly that it supports these initiatives.

Wadephul told Lavrov, "Time is of the essence: given the food shortages in many countries — particularly in the Global South — all parties must be willing to engage constructively," the German delegation source said.

• BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

CNN says it was left off Air Force One for Trump's trip to Tennessee



Trump waves from the stairs of Air Force One on Saturday. AP

THE WHITE House left CNN off Air Force One for President Donald Trump's trip Saturday to a college football game in Tennessee, marking latest media restriction from the administration in an ongoing dispute with First Amendment implications. CNN reported it had been scheduled to fly aboard president's plane for a scheduled visit to a game between University of Tennessee in Knoxville and University of Texas. But a White House guidance issued Friday instead included Real America's Voice, a conservative outlet. AP

CONGO

Plane crash kills 14, including two military officers

AT LEAST 14 people, including two senior military officials, have died in a plane crash in Congo, the military said Friday. The two senior military officials are Lieutenant General Mutombo Katalayi Tiende, head of the military court, and Lieutenant General Bakumi Likulia, auditor general of the armed forces. "In addition to the two general officers, twelve members of the delegation and crew also lost their lives...." Major General Efomi Ekenge, said. AP

CROATIA

5 migrants drown while crossing into Slovenia

FIVE MIGRANTS have drowned while trying to cross the Kupa river on the border between Croatia and Slovenia, Croatian police said on Friday. An officer who arrived first at the scene jumped into the river, which is called Kolpa in Slovenia, police said. He helped rescue five other people from the river, while the remaining migrants crossed into Slovenia, a statement said. No other details were immediately available. AP

• ON OCTOBER 1, GOOGLE IS SET TO LAUNCH AN EXPERIMENTAL SATELLITE INTO ORBIT THAT WILL HAVE ENOUGH COMPUTING POWER TO ANSWER SIMPLE A.I. QUERIES FROM SPACE

As AI's energy needs grow, Google takes the data centre race to outer space

Kate Conger & Cade Metz
San Francisco, September 26

AT A lab in San Francisco last month, a team of technicians in protective suits and hairnets poked, prodded and inspected a refrigerator-size satellite commissioned by Google.

First, they examined the satellite's solar panels, which would unfurl in space and face the sun. The satellite was then placed on a table and shaken rapidly in a vibration test, to see whether the chips inside would be damaged or the machine would come apart during a journey into space. The technicians painstakingly painted a small line over each screw to

help indicate any loosening during the shaking.

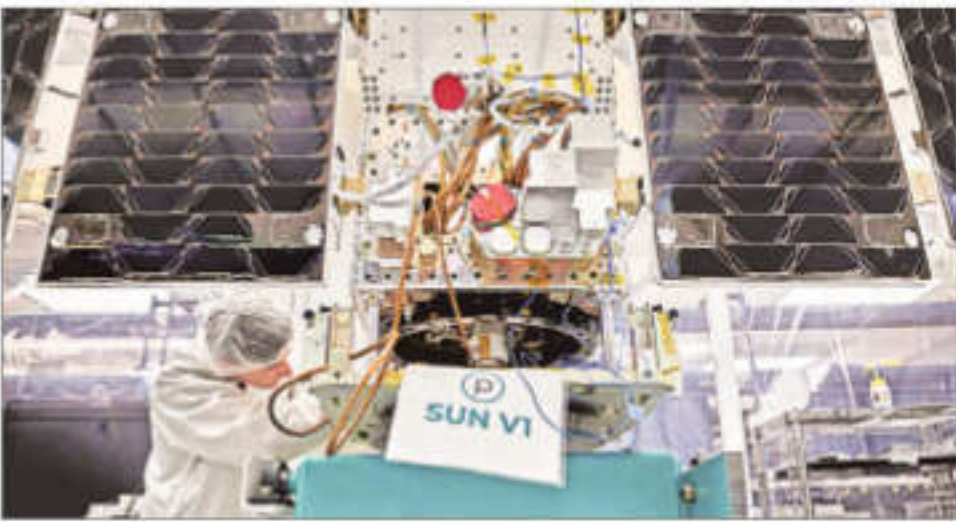
The satellite passed the vibration test, with its screws staying put and the chips remaining intact. James Manyika, Google's senior vice president for research, called the results "great," but he said he still wondered what would happen when the satellite went to space.

The work was part of an ambitious effort from Google called Project Suncatcher, which aims to put artificial intelligence data centers into space and to harness the sun's energy to power them. On October 1, the satellite from the San Francisco lab — which Google has named MVP — is set to become the first step toward

that goal by a major tech company. It will be loaded onto a SpaceX Falcon 9 rocket at the Vandenberg Space Force Base near Santa Barbara, California, and then launched into orbit.

Google provided *The New York Times* with the first inside look at the project, which seemed like a science-fiction dream just a year ago.

Elon Musk, Jeff Bezos, Sam Altman and others have pledged support for orbital data centers, but the idea faces many challenges, including withstanding radiation in space and the costs of getting machines beyond the atmosphere. Yet as data centers grapple with terrestrial opposition and physical li-



The satellite's solar panels will unfurl once it is in orbit, collecting energy to power Google's AI chips. NYT

mits, having computing facilities float above Earth has become increasingly attractive.

To be clear, Google is not

sending up a full data center — only an experimental precursor to one. MVP contains four specialized computer chips

called "tensor processing units," which have the computing power of one server in a data center. The satellite's solar panels will supply only about one kilowatt of power — roughly the amount needed to run a hair dryer — to the chips.

But that will be enough for Google to test its hardware against the harsh conditions of space. The satellite will answer simple AI queries and operate for a year, though it is set to circle Earth for up to six years. Eventually, it is expected to succumb to Earth's gravitational pull and burn up as it descends through the atmosphere.

Manyika said Google's expectations for the satellite were

tempered. "We don't expect, to be perfectly frank, that we'll have anything usefully operational in the next few years," he said, comparing the mission to the company's early efforts to build driverless cars. "Remember how Google was researching for like 15 years, before anything showed up? I think this is going to look like that."

Expanding from one satellite to a vast network of them that operates like a giant data center will take years and enormous funds, said Brandon Lucia, a professor of electrical and computer engineering at Carnegie Mellon University.

"If you do this on a large scale, there are additional en-

gineering problems," he said. "That is uncharted waters."

Project Suncatcher was the brainchild of Blaise Agüera y Arcas, 51, a Google vice president and AI researcher who leads a team studying intelligence. About three years ago, he attended a gathering of entrepreneurs and AI researchers where the main topic was the escalating energy needs of AI systems. Agüera y Arcas left the event convinced that data centers needed to move to space to harness solar power.

The idea "has been on my mind since I was kid," he said. "There are longstanding ideas in science fiction about using stars for computation." NYT

छत्तीसगढ़ शासन, जल संसाधन विभाग

कार्यालय मुख्य अभियंता, गोदावरी कछहर, जल संसाधन विभाग, जगदलपुर (छ.ग.)

(प्रथम आमंत्रण निस्तीकरण)

सिस्टम निविदा क्र. 195800/निविदा सूचना क्र. 16/च.ले.लि./2026-27 दि. 22.07.2026

कार्य का नाम – सुकमा जिले के नगर पालिका परिषद् सुकमा के वार्ड क्रमांक 03 में स्थित नकदी तालाब का जीर्णोद्धार एवं पार्क निर्माण कार्य

अनुमानित लागत रु. 406.98 लाख (जी.एस.टी. छोड़कर) उल्लेखित कार्य का निविदा आमंत्रण दिनांक 23.07.2026 को G-262700696 के माध्यम से समाचार पत्रों में प्रकाशित किया गया है। अतः उक्त निविदा को निरस्त किया जाता है।

हस्ता./- कार्यपालन अभियंता जल संसाधन संग्राम, सुकमा कृते मुख्य अभियंता गोदावरी कछहर जल संसाधन विभाग, जगदलपुर, छ.ग.

No. 262703502/6

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER

TRANSMISSION LINE MAINTENANCE

DIVISION II

SRINAGAR PAMPORE

Subject: Extension of e-NIT No. TLMD-II/ 04 of 2026-27 dt: 05.09.2026.

No: TLMD II/2088-90 dt:25.09.2026.

(Extension-I)

Due to the poor response to the tender , the fresh dates for e-filling of e-NIT No.TLMD-II/ 04 of 2026-27; dt: 05.09.2026 for the work “Insertion of Transmission towers at critical locations of 132KV D/C Mirbazar-Lisser Transmission line” are hereby extended as detailed below:-

Last Date of online filling of e-bids

06.10.2026 up to 02:00 pm

Date of opening of e-bids

07.10.2026 at 02:00 pm

Sd/-

Executive Engineer

TLMD II Pampore

DIPK-NB-1734/26 – DATE 26 SEP 2026

ई० प्रोक्स्यूरमेंट सेल,

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय

भवन निर्माण विभाग, भवन प्रमण्डल संख्या-02, रॉची

अल्पकालिन ई-प्रोक्स्योरमेन्ट नोटिस

ई-टेंडर रेफरेंस नं०-23/2026-27/EE/BCD/DIV-2,RANCHI.

दिनांक- 27.09.2026

1. कार्य का नाम

Infrastructure Upgradation Work at JAP-IT, Engineering Hostel No-01, HEC, Dhuwa, Ranchi.

2. प्राकलित राशि (रु०)

राशि रु० 4,65,76,200.00/- (चार करोड़ पैंसठ लाख चियहत्तर हजार दो सौ) रुपये मात्र।

3. कार्य पूर्ण की अवधि

7 (सात) माह

4. वेबसाइट पर निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि

06.10.2026 को 11:00 बजे

5. बिड प्राप्ति के लिए अंतिम तिथि/समय

12.10.2026 को 11:00 बजे तक

6. निविदा प्रकाशित करने वाले कार्यालय का नाम एवं पता

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय, भवन निर्माण विभाग, भवन प्रमण्डल संख्या-02, रॉची।

7. निविदा खोलने की तिथि/ समय एवं स्थान

13.10.2026 को 11:30 बजे नोडल पदाधिकारी, ई० प्रोक्स्यूरमेंट सेल, मुख्य अभियंता का कार्यालय, भवन निर्माण विभाग, लाईन टैंक रोड, झारखंड, रॉची

7. प्रोक्स्योरमेंट पदाधिकारी का सम्पर्क संख्या

6203309676

8. ई-प्रोक्स्योरमेंट सेल का हेल्पलाइन संख्या

7992430721

9. परिमाण विपत्र की राशि घट-बढ़ सकती है तदनुसार अग्रधन की राशि देय होगी।

10. सूचना प्रौद्योगिकी एवं ई-गवर्नेंस विभाग, झारखण्ड, सरकार के आदेश झापाक 120 दिनांक 03.10.2023 के द्वारा निर्गत SOP (मानक संवाचन प्रक्रिया) एवं भवन निर्माण विभाग, झारखण्ड, सरकार के पत्रांक 2229 दिनांक 06.10.2023 के आलोक में निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि केवल Online Mode द्वारा स्वीकार्य होगी।

11. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि का ई-भुगतान जिस खाता से किया जायेगा, SOP के सहित अग्रधन की राशि उर्री खाते में वापस होगी। अगर खाता को बंद कर दिया जाता है तो उसकी संपूर्ण जवाबदेही निविदादाता की होगी।

• अन्य किसी भी प्रकार के बदलाव की सूचना <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है।

कार्यपालक अभियंता

भवन निर्माण विभाग,

PR 390555 Building (26-27)_D भवन प्रमण्डल संख्या-02, रॉची

कार्यालय कलेक्टर

(आदिवासी विकास शाखा)

जिला-महासमुन्द (छ.ग.)

Email ID :- tribalmahasamund@gmail.com,

Phon/Fax No-07723-223912

क्रमांक/1946/आदि.वि./निर्माण/निविदा/2026-27महास/निविदा/2026-27

महासमुन्द, दिनांक 18/09/2026

(ई-प्रोक्स्योरमेंट निविदा आमंत्रण)

एकीकृत पंजीयन प्रणाली अंतर्गत सक्षम श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से निम्नलिखित निर्माण कार्य हेतु ऑनलाईन (Online) निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है :-

एन.आई.टी. क्र. / सिस्टम टेन्डर नं.

कार्य का विवरण

अनुमानित लागत रु. (लाख में)

1

2

3

198926

REMANIG WORK CONSTRUCTION OF 50 SEATER POST MATRIC BOYS (SC) HOSTEL MAHASAMUND BLOCK- MAHASAMUND DIST-MAHASAMUND BUILDING WORK

रु. 174.998 लाख

निविदा डाउनलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि दिनांक-09.10.2026

उपरोक्त निर्माण कार्यों की निविदा की सामान्य शर्तें, धरोहर राशि की विस्तृत निविदा विज्ञप्ति, निविदा दस्तावेज व अन्य जानकारी <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> पर देखी जा सकती है एवं डाउनलोड की जा सकती है।

हस्ता./- सहायक आयुक्त, आदिवासी विकास महासमुन्द

No.262703468/4

Public Works Department

Office of The Superintending Engineer, Pwd,

Durg Circle Durg (C.G.)

REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RFP)

(1st Call)

No. 02/Durg/2026-27 Durg, Dated. 23.09.2026

Public Works Department (PWD) invites proposal for Planning, Design, Estimation and related services for the work

रेस्ट हाउस परिसर जिला दुर्ग में नवीन सफ़्टि हाउस निर्माण के योजना डिजाइन एवं प्राकलन तैयार करने हेतु वास्तुविद् चयन करने बाबद्।

Situated at Durg

Probable cost of project Rs. 800.00 Lakh.

Estimated cost of project Rs. 800.00 Lakh

Minimum eligibility for participants shall be as below :-

S. N.

Building project cost

The applicant firms, firms forming Joint venture/consortium shall be

Earnest money (In shape as per annexure I) Favor of Executive Engineer, PWD Durg Division Durg

1

For project cost Between 1 Crore to 10 Crore

Empanelled as architect in Class “D” Class in C.G. PWD.

Rs. 15,000=00

General Condition: All the documents & Information as per para 6.4, shall be submitted through speed post/Registered post. so as to reach the office of under signed on or before dated 12.10.2026 by 17.30 hour. Any documents received after the last date and time will not be entertained.

नोट:- उल्लंघनीय है कि सक्षम स्वीकृति प्राप्त होने के उपरांत ही कंसल्टेंसी फर्म को देयको का नियमानुसार भुगतान सुनिश्चित किया जाएगा।

The detailed RFP is available on the website www.cg.nic.in/pwdraipur & <http://cgstate.gov.in/> from where it can be downloaded for submission. CGPWD reserves the right to reject all or any of the application without assigning any reason. Right to modify the process of Pre-qualification is reserved with CGPWD.

Sd/- Superintending Engineer Public Works Department Durg Circle Durg

NO 262703524/4

Office of the Director

INDIRA GANDHI INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES,

SHEIKHPURA, PATNA – 800 014 (Bihar, India)

Tel.: 0612 – 2297631, 2297099; Fax: 0612 – 2297225; Website: www.igims.org

Email id.-director@igims.org

Ref. No. EC/EW/E834/06/2026/182

(To Publish in daily News Paper)

E-Tender Notice No: IGIMS/EC/EW/07/2026-27

TENDER NOTIFICATION FOR ELECTRICAL WORK

Percentage rate for Schedule items and rate of non-schedule items in two bid systems (Technical and Price Bid) are invited from eligible and experienced contractors/firms registered in appropriate class under CPWD, BCD, Energy Department, PESU, Railway or in any government organization under which similar nature of work has been carried out for the electrical work at IGIMS, Patna-14. Last date and time for submission of complete tender document is 21.10.2026 upto 03:00 P.M. through speed post/Registered post/Courier service only. The received bids (Technical only) will be opened on 22.10.2026 at 03:00P.M. Details of the tender can be seen and downloaded from institute website: www.igims.org & www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in. Undersigned reserves the right to accept/reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason. Prospective bidders are advised to regularly visit www.igims.org for corrigendum/amendments etc. if any will be notified on this portal only and no separate advertisement will be made.

Director, I.G.I.M.S. Patna

PR. No. 012572 (B&C) 2026-27

For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar

सुरक्षित जीवन अपनाओ , अपनी नियमित एच.आई.वी. जाँच कराओ।

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल, गोड्डा।

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

ई- निविदा सूचना संख्या – RWD/SD/GODDA/08/2026-27

1.कार्य की विस्तृत विवरणी :

क्रम

प्रखंड

कार्य का नाम

प्राकलित राशि

अग्रधन की राशि

परिमाण विपत्र का मूल्य

कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि

1

Sunderpahari

Construction of 50 Beded Hostel For Residential Upgraded H igh School At Sunderpahari, Dangapara.

2,68,97,700.00

5,38,000.00

10,000.00

12 माह

2.

वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि – 29.09.2026

3.

ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की तिथि एवं समय – दिनांक 29.09.2026 से दिनांक 13.10.2026 को अपराह्न 5:00 बजे तक

4.

ई-निविदा खोलने का स्थान – कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय, ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमण्डल, गोड्डा।

5.

ई-निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय – 15.10.2026 अपराह्न 2:00 बजे

6.

ई-निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता :- कार्यपालक अभियंता, ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल, गोड्डा।

7.

ई-निविदा प्रकोष्ठ का दूरभाष सं० – 9771979309

8.

परिमाण विपत्र की राशि घट-बढ़ सकती है तदनुसार अग्रधन की राशि देय होगी।

9.

निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि केवल Online Mode द्वारा स्वीकार्य होगी।

10.

निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि का ई-भुगतान जिस खाता से किया जायेगा, उसी खाते में अग्रधन की राशि वापस होगी। अगर खाता को बंद कर दिया जाता है तो उसकी सारी जवाबदेही आपकी होगी।

11.

ई निविदा रद्द करने का अधिकार अधोहस्ताक्षरी के पास सुरक्षित रहेगा।

12.

किसी भी निविदाकार के यंत्र-संयंत्र एवं बिड क्षमता के मापदंडों पर प्रत्येक में सक्षम होने पर ही तकनीकी योग्यता पर विचार किया जायेगा।

13.

जिस संवेदक का विभाग में पूर्व आवंटित कोई कार्य लंबित है अथवा उनका कार्यान्वयन संतोशजनक नहीं रहा है, उन्हें कार्य आवंटन पर विचार नहीं किया जायेगा।

14.

किसी भी संवेदक को कार्य आवंटन के उपरांत सबलेट करना एकरारनामा शर्त का उल्लंघन होगा एवं समुचित सूचना प्राप्त होने पर एकरारनामा रद्द करते हुए संवेदक को काली सूची में डालने की कार्यवाही की जायेगी।

15.

किसी भी संवेदक के कार्य आवंटन के क्रम में उनके ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग के अन्तर्गत कुल कार्य भार के आलोक में उपलब्ध यंत्र-संयंत्र एवं वित्तीय क्षमता की सीमा तक नये कार्य आवंटन पर विचार किया जायेगा।

16.

पथ निर्माण विभाग, झारखंड, रॉची का पत्र संख्या 2146 (S) दिनांक 09.09.2020 में निहित प्रावधान के आलोक में निविदा की कार्यवाही की जा रही है।

आमंत्रित निविदा के समय निर्धारण के लिए JPWD Code 2012 के Para-159a का अनुपालन किया गया है।

विस्तृत जानकारी के लिये वेबसाइट www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in एवं कार्यालय की सूचना पट्ट पर देखा जा सकता है।

कार्यपालक अभियंता

ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल,गोड्डा।

PR 390525 Rural Development(26-27)D

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER

PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT, E/M CIRCLE, RAIPUR (C.G.)

e-Procurement Tender Notice

Online tenders are invited on behalf of Governor of Chhattisgarh from contractors, C.G. P.W in new Registration system (unified Registration system) for the following work :-

NIT No.

Name of work

Probable amount of contract

10/SE E/M/2026-27 (IV th Call)

Shifting & Height Raising Of LT/11KV/33KV Overhead Line Including Transformer & Dp For Road Widening Work Of Sukhari-Jhinka-Diwanbhedhi Road From Km 1/2 To Km 5/2 (4.20 Km), District Rajnandgaon (C.G.)

Rs 23.89 Lacs

47/SE E/M/2026-27 (IInd Call)

Providing & Installation of Street Road Lighting, High Mast Lighting & LED Strip RGB Lighting E/F work System in Rajnandgaon-Gundardehi-Dhamtari Nagri-Sihawa-Borai (SH-23) from Mujgahan-Ratnabandha Chowk (Four Lane) Road Work(Phase I:- Ratnabandha Chowk to Loharsi Road Junction), Distt. Dhamtari (C.G.)

Rs 144.00 Lacs

48/SE E/M/2026-27 (IInd Call)

विला धमतरी के राजनान्दाघ-गुडदेही-धमतरी-नगरी-सिहावा-बोराई मार्ग के सिहावा चौक से चलोहरी जंक्शन तक 4 लेन निर्माण कार्य के अंतर्गत स्ट्रीट लाइट, हाई-मास्टर लाइट, एल.ई.डी. स्ट्रिंग आर.जी.बी. लाइट इत्यादि विद्युत्करण कार्य।

Rs160.50 Lacs

50/SE E/M/2026-27 (IInd Call)

विला धमतरी के राजनान्दाघ-गुडदेही-धमतरी-नगरी-सिहावा-बोराई मार्ग के लोहरी जंक्शन से राम-भुजगहन तक 4 लेन निर्माण कार्य के अंतर्गत स्ट्रीट लाइट, हाई मास्टर लाइट, एल.ई.डी. स्ट्रिंग आर.जी.बी. लाइट इत्यादि विद्युत्करण कार्य।

Rs 157.76 Lacs

37/SE E/M/2026-27 (IInd Call)

Providing Shifting & Installation work of Electric Poles from Jharagathi to Dhourai (Palli) Chhotedongar Orchha Road 1.00 to 12.00=12.00 km) at District Narayanpur (C.G.)

Rs 18.01 Lacs

Date of bid submission 09-10-2026

The tender documents can be downloaded from the web-portal <http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>. Only those contractors/bidders, interested in bidding shall pay the tender document cost online.

Sd/-

Superintending Engineer

P.W.D. (E&M) CIRCLE,

RAIPUR (C.G.)

NO. 262703504/2

75th

आज के भारत का भविष्य

भारत सरकार

UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU & KASHMIR

OFFICE THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD (R&B)

DIVISION SATWARI

SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Short e-NIT No. 77 of 2026-27 Dated 24-09-2026

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir e-tenders are invited on percentage basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State/Central Governments for each of the following works: -

S. No.

Name of Work

Advertisd Cost (In Lacs)

Cost of documents (In Rupees)

Earnest Money (In Rupees)

Time allowed for completion

Time and date of opening of tender

Class of Contractor

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

1

Construction of Lane and Drain, land filling, material filling and blacktopping of Road from shop of Faaji Bodi raj upto H/O Sartaj Singh at Village Shiv Nagar.

10.00

600/-

(2% of the Advertised Cost)

06 Months

09/10/2026

A, B, C, D

2

Construction of Street near Friends Enclave Jervan Nagar

11.90

600/-

(2% of the Advertised Cost)

06 Months

09/10/2026

A, B, C, D

3

Construction of Lane and Drain to Guru Harikrishan Public School, Gajjar Basti(Back Side Police Line)

10.00

600/-

(2% of the Advertised Cost)

06 Months

09/10/2026

A, B, C, D

4

Construction of Lane and Drain from the Rashpal to Pinka and Labha Ram to barham lai manager bhour kaillian wardno 73

15.00

600/-

(2% of the Advertised Cost)

06 Months

09/10/2026

A, B, C, D

5

Construction of Deep drain in Vikram Nagar area to its outfall in Landoi Choi Nallah in Bhour Camp Jammu Ward no 73

25.00

600/-

(2% of the Advertised Cost)

06 Months

09/10/2026

A, B, C

6

Construction of Lane and Drain at Belicharam Jammu

15.00

600/-

(2% of the Advertised Cost)

06 Months

09/10/2026

A, B, C, D

7

Construction of Lane and drain from Manohar Singh house to Guru Asharam ward no 73 Gadgaah

20.00

600/-

(2% of the Advertised Cost)

06 Months

09/10/2026

A, B, C

8

Upgradation of Link Road near H/o Rajinder Singh to Bridge Sahib Bandagi Asharam along Canal Dhiodey.

20.00

600/-

(2% of the Advertised Cost)

06 Months

09/10/2026

A, B, C

9

Construction of Lane and Drain Garudwara Sahib Panchayat Tekri to Post Office

10.00

600/-

(2% of the Advertised Cost)

06 Months

09/10/2026

A, B, C, D

10

Construction of Lane and drain near Petrol Pump to house of Tarlok Singh at Karan High Lower Gadgaah

25.00

600/-

(2% of the Advertised Cost)

06 Months

09/10/2026

A, B, C

Position of AAA

>= Accorded

Position of TS

>= Accorded

Major head of account

=/UT expes

The Bidding documents Consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website <http://jtenders.gov.in> as per below schedule:

1

Date of Issue of Tender Notice

24/09/2026 at 1800 Hrs.

2

Period of downloading of bidding documents

24/09/2026 at 1800 Hrs.

3

Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting

26/09/2026 at 1300 Hrs. in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Satwari

4

Bid submission Start Date

24/09/2026 at 1800 Hrs.

5

Bid Submission End Date

09/10/2026 up to 1600 Hrs.

6

Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)

09/10/2026 up to or after 13.00 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Satwari

7

Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)

To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

Executive Engineer

PWD (R&B) Division

Satwari

No:- XEN/SAT/PWD/Tender/2026-27

DIP/J-11169/26 – DATE 26 SEP 2026

Jawaharlal Nehru Aluminium Research Development and Design Centre

(An Autonomous Body under Ministry of Mines, Govt. of India)

Amravati Road, Wadi, Nagpur - 440 023.

www.jnarddc.gov.in (07104-220701) e-mail: purchasejnarddcnagpur@gmail.com

निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना/NOTICE INVITING TENDER - September 2026

Director, JNARDDC, Nagpur, invites online bids from reputed firms for the following services/items.

निदेशक, निम्नलिखित निविदा की आपूर्ति के लिए प्रतिष्ठित कंपनियों से ऑनलाइन प्रस्ताव आमंत्रित किया है।

Tender/ GeM Bid No.

Description of Equipments/Work

Refundable EMD (₹)

Last Date of Tender Submission

GEM/2026/B/ 8074870

Water Supply System for RPD Shed JNARDDC

30,000/-

23.10.2026 (18:00 Hrs.)

GEM/2026/B/ 8063017

Fume and Dust Extraction System

2,95,000/-

22.10.2026 (18:00 Hrs.)

GEM/2026/B/ 8006840

Supply of Aluminium & Alloys Scrap

2,25,000/-

03.10.2026 (18:00 Hrs.)

The details are available in the tender document which will be available for download from our office website <https://www.jnarddc.gov.in> or <https://gem.gov.in/>

वरिष्ठ प्रशासनिक अधिकारी

GOVERNMENT OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR

JAL SHAKTI DEPARTMENT

Office of the Executive Engineer Flood Control Division Anantnag

Phone Fax: 01932464212, 225119

D.C Office Complex Anantnag192101

RENTENDER Corrigendum

Subject: This office e-NIT No. 18 of 2026-27 Dated: -09-09-2026

Reference: -01. Issued under this office No. FCD/Anp/2026/3735-57-09-09-2026

Due to "single response in the subjected e NIT for S.No/01,02 & 03, the works are hereby retendered as under.

S. No.

Description

Date

Time

1

Publishing date of NIT

26 09 2026

16:00 PM

2

Download start date

26 09 2026

16:00 PM

3

Bid submission start date

26 09 2026

16:00 PM

4

Bid submission end date

01 10 2026

06:00 PM

5

Bid opening date

03 10 2026

10:00 AM

The bidders whose bids were accepted and were found qualified in the subjected e NIT there Treasury Receipt Affidavit & CDR will be accepted in this retender Corrigendum. All other terms and conditions will remain unchanged.

Sd/-

Executive Engineer,

Flood Control Division Anantnag

Dated: -

DIPK-6123/26– DATE 26 SEP 2026

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल, दुमका

(rdsddumka1@gmail.com)

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या- RDS/DMK/MMGSY/02/2026-27

1.कार्य की विस्तृत विवरणी :-

क्रम संख्या

कार्य का नाम

प्राकलित राशि

अग्रधन की राशि

परिमाण विपत्र का मूल्य

कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि

1

2

3

4

5

6

1.

दुमका जिला अन्तर्गत मसालिया प्रखंड के कुसुमघाटा पंचायत के आस्ताजोड़ा एवं बेतियाजोड़ के बीच नूबिल नदी में उध्वरस्थीय पुल निर्माण।

4,75,95,400

9,52,000

10,000.00

18 माह

2.

दुमका जिला के दुमका प्रखंड अन्तर्गत पंचायत भातमंडारों के ग्राम बड़ामूलीदुम से डडुजोड़ के बीच उध्वरस्थीय पुल निर्माण।

2,69,50,200

5,39,500

10,000.00

18 माह

1. वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि :- 05.10.2026

2. ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की तिथि एवं समय :- दिनांक 05.10.2026 से दिनांक 05.11.2026 को अपराह्न 5:00 बजे तक।

3. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि केवल Online Mode द्वारा ही स्वीकार्य होगी।

4. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि का ई-भुगतान जिस खाता से किया जायेगा, उसी खाते में अग्रधन की राशि वापस होगी। अगर खाता को बंद कर दिया जाता है तो सारी जवाबदेही आपकी होगी।

5. निविदा खोलने का स्थान-- e-Procurement Cell, कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल दुमका।

6. निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय :- दिनांक 07.11.2026 अपराह्न 2:00 बजे

7. निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता :- कार्यपालक अभियंता, ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल,दुमका।

8. ई-निविदा प्रकोष्ठ का दूरभाष संख्या :- 8292322880

9. परिमाण विपत्र की राशि घट-बढ़ सकती है तदनुसार अग्रधन की राशि देय होगी।

विस्तृत जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in एवं कार्यालय की सूचना पट्ट पर देखा जा सकता है।

कार्यपालक अभियंता,

ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल,दुमका

PR 390559 (Rural Work Department)26-27*D

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS

E-NIT 16 of 2026-27 Dated: 24.09.2026

For and on behalf of Managing Director J&K, Power Development Corporation tenders are invited by the Executive Engineer, Civil Maintenance Division BHEP Chanderkote by E-tendering mode for below mentioned work on percentage rate basis from experienced & reputed contractors registered with J&K state Govt./CPWD/MES and Railways having sufficient experience in execution of civil works and possessing sufficient man power & machinery.

S. No

Name of work

Approximate cost in crore

Cost of tender document

Earnest Money

Time of Completion

Class of contract

01

Installation of chain link fencing along the periphery of the Project Area BHEP Chanderkote

3.3378107 cr

Rs 5000.00

Rs. 667563.00

180 days

"A"

Date of issue of Notice Inviting Bid:

24/09/2026 (11:00 hrs)

Period of Downloading

From 13:00 hrs of 25/09/2026 up-to 12:00 hrs of 15/10/2026

Tender Documents:

Places(s):

<http://jktenders.gov.in> and <https://jkspdc.co.in>

Pre-Bid Meeting

29/09/2026 at 15:00 hrs (Office of the Executive Engineer CMD BHEP Chanderkote)

Period of Receiving Bids Online

From 13:00 hrs 25/09/2026 up-to 12:00 hrs of 15/10/2026

Time & Date of Opening technical Bids:

16/10/2026 at 15:00 hrs

Place of Opening Bids:

Office of the Chief Engineer Civil BHEP Chanderkote

Bid Validity:

120 Days.

Officer Inviting Bids:

Executive Engineer Civil Maintenance Division JKPDC BHEP Chanderkote.

Sd

Executive Engineer

Civil Maintenance Division

JKPDC BHEP Chanderkote

No:CMD/BHEP/T-1/1432-37

Dated:24.09.2026.

DIP/J-2370/P-26 – DATE 26 SEP 2026

Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER PMGSY CIRCLE Batote.

Short NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS

e-NIT No:-PMGSY/SE/B/34 of 2026-27 Dated:-24-09-2026

Invitation of Expression of Interest for Engagement of DPR Consulting Agency

Expression of Interest is invited for Engagemen consultant for Providing Consultancy Services Including Survey, Detailed Investigations, Study, Soil Testing, Structural Design, Estimation, Preparation of Detailed Project Report & Getting it vetted from DIQC / NIT / IIT for 10 No. of missing bridges under PMGSY I, II, & III in PMGSY Division Ramban of Jammu Province J&K



विकसित गांव विकसित राजस्थान

विकसित भारत गारंटी फॉर रोजगार एंड आजीविका मिशन (ग्रामीण)

(VB-G RAM G)



देश में अग्रणी राज्यों में राजस्थान



प्रत्येक पात्र ग्रामीण परिवार को 100 दिवस के स्थान पर प्रतिवर्ष **125 दिवस** का रोजगार

अब तक का सर्वाधिक बजटीय प्रावधान वित्तीय वर्ष 2026-27 के बजट में योजना के लिए

₹12,636.44 करोड़ का प्रावधान

शिक्षा विभाग, राजस्थान ग्रामीण आजीविका विकास परिषद, पंचायती राज विभाग, आयुर्वेद विभाग, युवा मामले एवं खेल विभाग, स्वच्छ भारत मिशन, पशुपालन विभाग, जन स्वास्थ्य अभियांत्रिकी विभाग, जल जीवन मिशन और जल ग्रहण विकास एवं भू-संरक्षण विभाग के साथ कन्वर्जेंस के माध्यम से

₹3700 करोड़ के कार्य करवाया जाना प्रस्तावित

राज्य में 75,782 कार्यों पर
8.51 लाख श्रमिक नियोजन

338.22 लाख मानव
दिवस सृजित

मानव दिवस सृजन में
राजस्थान देश में **दूसरे स्थान पर**

श्रमिक नियोजन में
राजस्थान देश में **तीसरे स्थान पर**

रोजगार के स्थायी अवसरों का सृजन सुनिश्चित

योजना में जल संबंधी कार्य (जल सुरक्षा के लिए), मूल ग्रामीण अवसंरचना, आजीविका संबंधी अवसंरचना, आपदा प्रबंधन के
375 प्रकार के अनुमत कार्य

गुणवत्तापूर्ण क्रियान्वयन के लिए प्रशासनिक
व्यय 6% के स्थान पर 9%

वर्षभर पर्याप्त कार्य उपलब्ध कराने के उद्देश्य से राज्य में
6 लाख से अधिक कार्य जीआईएस आधारित युक्तधारा पोर्टल पर सम्मिलित

ग्राम पंचायत में औसतन
55 से अधिक कार्यों की उपलब्धता

सूचना एवं जनसम्पर्क विभाग, राजस्थान



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER
RURAL WORKS CIRCLE, BOLANGIR
e-Procurement Notice

25001/1204/2627

1. Name of work	: Construction of Bridge in the district of Bolangir and Subarnapur under SBY for the year 2026-27
2. No. of works	: 19 (Nineteen) works
3. Time for completion	varies from 12 (Twelve) to 18 (Eighteen) Calendar months
4. Approximate estimated cost	varies from Rs. 300.92 lakhs to Rs. 825.26 lakhs
5. Mode of Submission of tender	: Tender should be submitted online in www.tendersodisha.gov.in
6. Other details are as follow	

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender on line for bidding From To	Last date and time of seeking tender clarification	Date & Time of opening of Tender
Chief Construction Engineer, R.W Circle, Bolangir	BLGR. Online- 21/2026-27	12.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M.	27.10.2026 upto 5.00 P.M.	26.10.2026 upto 5.00 P.M.
				28.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M.
				The date will be intimated later on

● Further details can be seen from the website www.tendersodisha.gov.in

● Any Corrigendum/Addendum will be displayed in the above e tender website only.

Sd/-
Chief Construction Engineer
R. W. Circle, Bolangir

OIPR-25001/25118/1/26-27/0023



UTTRAKHAND POWER CORPORATION LTD.
OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
ELECTRICITY DISTRIBUTION CIRCLE 33/11 KV SUB
STATION CAMPUS TANAKPUR CHAMPAWAT-262309
E-Mail:- edc.champawat@upcl.org



उत्तराखण्ड पावर कॉर्पोरेशन लि०
कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता विद्युत वितरण मण्डल 33/11 के०वी० उपसंस्थान टनकपुर चम्पावत-262309
E-Mail: edc.champawat@upcl.org

फ़ॉक- 3484 /वि.म.(च.) /
दिनांक 24/09/2026

इ-निविदा सूचना

विद्युत वितरण मण्डल चम्पावत निम्नानुसार ई० निविदा आमंत्रित करता है।
क्र०सं- 01 वि०वि०० चम्पावत से पूर्व में आमंत्रित ई० निविदा संख्या 48/2026-27/EDC (CH), 49/2026-27/EDC (CH), 50/2026-27/EDC (CH) एवं 51/2026-27/EDC (CH) को अंतिमलाइन निविदा जमा व खुलने की तिथि विस्तारित कर निविदा जमा की तिथि 12/10/2026 एवं खुलने की तिथि 13/10/2026 की जाती है। निविदा की अन्य शर्तें पूर्ववत् रहेंगी।
क्र०सं- 02

निविदा सं०	निविदा कार्य का नाम व संक्षिप्त विवरण	निविदा मूल्य (जी०एस०टी० सहित)	निविदा धरोहर धनराशि	निविदा ऑन लाईन व ऑफ लाईन जमा की अनिवार्य तिथि व समय	निविदा ऑनलाइन खुलने की तिथि व समय	निविदा ऑनलाइन खुलने की तिथि व समय
52/ 2026-27 /EDC(CH)	केपिटल एस०आई० मद में वि०वि०० चम्पावत के उपसंस्थान लोहाघाट से निकलने वाले वाराकोट एवं मुल्ता पोषक में स्थापित 100/63 के०वी०ए परियोजना में ए०सी०वी० एवं एस०सी०सी०वी० की स्थापना व अगुर्ति का कार्य, निविदा विनिर्दिष्ट के अनुसार किया जाना।	₹ 5,900/-	₹ 1,61,000/-	13-10-2026 (upto 11:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (10:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (10:30 AM)
53/ 2026-27 /EDC (CH)	केपिटल एस०आई० मद में वि०वि०० चम्पावत के देवीपुर एवं खेतीखान सेक्टर में स्थापित 100/63 के०वी०ए परिवर्तकों में ए०सी०वी० एवं एस०सी०सी०वी० की स्थापना व अगुर्ति का कार्य, निविदा विनिर्दिष्ट के अनुसार किया जाना।	₹ 2,360/-	₹ 75,000/-	13-10-2026 (upto 11:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (11:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (11:30 AM)
54/ 2026-27 /EDC (CH)	ओ० एण्ड एस० मद में वि०वि०० चम्पावत के उपखण्ड टनकपुर के अन्तर्गत ए०वी० लाइन हेतु स्थानीय सामग्री की अगुर्ति का कार्य, निविदा विनिर्दिष्ट के अनुसार किया जाना।	₹ 1,180/-	₹ 68,000/-	13-10-2026 (upto 11:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (12:00 PM)	14-10-2026 (12:30 PM)
55/ 2026-27 /EDC (CH)	ओ० एण्ड एस० मद में वि०वि०० चम्पावत के उपसंस्थान लोहाघाट से निकलने वाले मुल्ता, सलना, गुलगाँव एवं पॉलिटेक्निक पोषको के अन्तर्गत लाइन, परिवर्तक व उपसंस्थान का अनुसूची एवं उपयोक्ता शिक्कावत निवारण का कार्य, निविदा विनिर्दिष्ट के अनुसार किया जाना।	₹ 5,900/-	₹ 1,08,000/-	13-10-2026 (upto 11:00 AM)	14-10-2026 (13:00 PM)	14-10-2026 (13:30 PM)

निविदा सम्बन्धित अधिक जानकारी, नियम व शर्तों हेतु प्रथम ई० निविदा की वेबसाइट www.uktenders.gov.in पर देखें। विद्युत बिलों के 24x7 ऑनलाइन भुगतान हेतु www.upcl.org पर जाएं। Customer Toll Free No-1800 419 0405"

"सदृ हित में बिजली बचाये"

अधीक्षण अभियन्ता
विद्युत वितरण मण्डल चम्पावत

UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU & KASHMIR
OFFICE THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER PWD (R&B)
CIRCLE SOUTH JAMMU
TENDER NOTICE INVITING

e-NIT No.SESJ/22 of 2026-27

Dated 22-09-2026

For and on behalf of the Lt. Governor of Union Territory of J&K, e-tenders are invited on percentage rate basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K/CPWD / BRO/ Railways/ MES and other State/ Central Government for the work mentioned below:-

S. No	Name of Work	Advertised Cost	Cost of document (in Rs.)	Earnest Money Deposit in the form of CDR/FDR/ BG	Time Allowed for completion	Time and date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
Executive Engineer, PWD(R&B)Division, Gandhi Nagar	Macadamization of Marshalling Yard, PWD Workshop, Transport Nagar, Jammu (Under Capex Budget 2025-26).	Rs. 253.35 lacs	6000/-	2% of the advertised cost Rs.506700/-	04 Months	At or after 1200 hrs on 14-10-2026	'A' Class

Position of AAA :- Sanctioned
Position of Tech. sanction :- Sanctioned
The Bidding documents Consist of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website <http://jktenders.gov.in> as per below schedule:-

1. Date of Issue of Tender Notice	22.09.2026
2. Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 22.09.2026 to 13.10.2026, 1800 Hrs
3. Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	07.10.2026 at 1400 hours in the Office of the Superintending Engineer, PWD (R&B) Circle South, Jammu
4. Bid submission Start Date	22.09.2026 From 1800 Hrs
5. Bid Submission End Date	13.10.2026 up to 1800 Hrs
6. Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	14.10.2026 at 1200 hours in the Office of the Superintending Engineer, PWD (R&B) Circle South, Jammu
7. Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

No:-SESJ/DB/5945-52
Dated:-22-09-2026

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer
PWD (R&B)Circle South Jammu

DIP/J-11105/26- DATE 25.09.2026



POSTGRADUATE INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL EDUCATION & RESEARCH, CHANDIGARH

TENDER NOTICE

Sealed tenders are invited from the manufacturers or their sole authorized distributors/sole agents on the prescribed form for below mention items for two years.

Sr. No.	Name of Drug/Material
1.	Inj. Fentanyl Citrate 100mcg/2ml amp.
2.	Lidocaine Lozenges 200mg/unit.
3.	Isabgol Husk 100gm.
4.	Neomycin 3400 + Bcitracin400 + Polymyxin B 5000 units/gm, 10gm powder
5.	Rate Contract for "Discount on Maximum Retail Price (MRP) of Drugs/Medicines under Local Purchase" for Patient and PGI staff from licensed Chemist/Druggist holder, who has shop/service outlet at Chandigarh on emergency basis to cater day-to-day requirements for two years.

The Pre-Bid meeting for drugs mentioned at sr. no. 1 and 5 is to be held on 29.09.2026 at 03:15PM in the office of Superintendent Dispensary, Room No. 18A, Ground Floor, Nehru Hospital, PGIMER Chandigarh.

The Tender Form and specification of the products are available on the institute website www.pgimer.nic.in and eprocure.gov.in. Above mentioned tenders will be received by 12:30 Hours on 13.10.2026 (Due date) in the office of Prof. In-charge (EP), Room No 18-A, Nehru Hospital, Drugs & Dressing Section, Ground Floor, PGIMER, Chandigarh and will be opened at 02:30 PM on the same date at Committee Room Medical Superintendent office, Ground Floor, Nehru Hospital, PGIMER Chandigarh.

Officer In-charge (HPD), Proc. Drugs & Dressing

राजस्थान सरकार
कार्यालय अधीक्षाधी अभियन्ता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग खण्ड किशनगढ़बास
Email: celalwar2.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in & pwdalwar2@rediffmail.com

क्रमांक:-1654
दिनांक:- 22.09.2026

NIT No 12/2026-27
Bids are Invited Const. of Missing Link roads Under Pkg. No. RJ-Khairthal/02/ML/2026-27, Const. of Missing Link roads Under Pkg. No. RJ-Khairthal/03/ML/2026-27, Renewal of Non Patchable roads Under Pkg. No. RJ-Khairthal/07/NP/2026-27, Civil works in DJ Court Khairthal Building at Kishangarh Bas HQ & Patan Mewan road to Nimbhara Ki Aur Via Ismal Ki Dhani are invited from interested bidders upto 12.10.2026 time 6:00 PM. Other particulars of the bid may be seen on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 787.27 Lacs.
NIB No. PWD2627A2847
UBN No. PWD2627WSOB12791, PWD2627WSOB12792
PWD2627WSOB12793, PWD2627WSOB12794
PWD2627WSOB12795

Sd/-
Executive Engineer
DIPR/C/16340/2026 PWD Div KISHANGARH BAS



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

Sr. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HARYANA ROADWAYS ENG'G CORP., GURUGRAM	PROVIDING MANPOWER FOR FABRICATION OF HARYANA SHAKTI DISTRICT TYPE ALL METAL BUS BODIES COMPLETE BUS WORK ON TATA BUS CHASSIS ALONGWITH SPARE WHEEL BOX.	25.09.2026 12.10.2026	92.82 LACS	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	9250570002 gm.hrec27@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.-49648/HRY



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

Sr. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, FARIDABAD	LIFTING OF MUNICIPAL SOLID WASTE FOR 6 MONTHS FROM GVP AND NON-GVP POINTS (HOT SPOTS, STREET SWEEPING, VACANT PLOTS WASTE ETC) TO TRANSFER STATION FROM VARIOUS WARDS UNDER WEST ZONE CLUSTER OF DTCT, MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, FARIDABAD +1	24.09.2026 15.10.2026	1262 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01292411649 memandep188@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.-49654/HRY



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

Sr. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HVPN	PROCUREMENT OF 11 KV 13 PANEL BOARD VACUUM TYPE SWITCHGEAR (1250A) IN HVPNL(PANCHKULA)	26.09.2026 27.10.2026	EMD 5,600,000/-	http://www.hvpn.org.in	0172-258378 PRO@HVPN.ORG.IN
2	HVPN	PROCUREMENT OF 11 KV 15 PANEL BOARD VACUUM TYPE SWITCHGEAR (2000A) IN HVPNL(PANCHKULA)	26.09.2026 27.10.2026	EMD 10,426,952.06/-	http://www.hvpn.org.in	0172-258378 PRO@HVPN.ORG.IN

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.-49655/HRY



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

Sr. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	BOARD OF SCHOOL EDUCATION HARYANA, BHIWANI	PRINTING AND SUPPLY OF ANSWER BOOKS FOR SEC./SR.SEC./D.E.L.ED. EXAMINATION YEAR 2026-2027	24.09.2026 15.10.2026	RS. 2,50,00,000/-	http://www.bsesh.org.in	7988665495 ascc@bsesh.org.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.-49681/HRY



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

Sr. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, ROHTAK	ESTIMATE FOR REPAIR AND RENOVATION OF SERVICE CLUB, M.C ROHTAK.	24.09.2026 01.10.2026	21 LACS	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	9467717422 engg-rohtak@ulbharyana.gov.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.-49653/HRY



AXIS FINANCE LIMITED
(An ISO 9001:2015 & ISO 14001:2015 Certified Company)
Axis House, C-2, Vastia International Centre, Parkside Budhkar
Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 025

Under Section 13 (2) of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 ("Act") read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 ("Rules").
Whereas the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Finance Limited (AFL) under the Act and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Rules already issued detailed Demand Notice dated below under Section 13(2) of the Act, calling upon the Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Guarantor(s) (all singularly or together referred to "Obligors")/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) listed hereunder, to pay the amount mentioned in the respective Demand Notice, within 60 days from the date of the respective Notice, as per details given below. Copies of the said Notices are served by Registered Post A.D. and are available with the undersigned, and the said Obligor(s)/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s), may, if they so desire, collect the respective copy from the undersigned on any working day during normal office hours.
In connection with the above, Notice is hereby given, once again, to the said Obligor(s) /Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) to pay to AFL, within 60 days from the date of the respective Notice/s, the amount indicated herein below against their respective names, together with further interest as detailed below from the respective dates mentioned below in column (d) till the date of payment and / or realization, read with the loan agreement and other documents/writings, if any, executed by the said Obligor(s). As security for due repayment of the loan, the following Secured Asset(s) have been mortgaged to AFL by the said Obligor(s) respectively.

Sr. No	Loan Account No.	Name of Obligor(s)/ Legal Heir(s)/ Legal Representative(s)	DETAILS OF SECURED ASSET	Total Outstanding Dues (Rs.) as on below date'	Date of Demand Notice	Date of NPA
1.	0456MMA00011710	Lord Ganesh Education Society, Ravi Kumar, Naveen Kumar, Renu Bala, Ramesh (Since Deceased, through Legal Heirs), Lilo, Hans Raj, Sushil Kumar & Anupama	All the piece and parcel of the Property bearing no. – Property Building Property i.e. Part of Bearing Khawat No. 532 min, Khatoni No.836 Min, Khasra No. 41/24-7-11, 58/42-4-4, measuring 11K-15M, situated at Village Shodia Bishnoiyan, Tehsil Adampur District Hisar Fatehabad Haryana-125052 and same is bounded as under: East :-Agri Land of Ramesh West :-Shubhash Agri Loand North :-Main Road South :-Agri Land	INR 28,04,911/- (Rupees Twenty Eight Lakhs Four Thousand Nine Hundred Eleven Only) as on 08th September 2026	21.09.2026	03.09.2026

*with further interest, additional Interest at the rate as more particularly stated in respective Demand Notices dated mentioned above, incidental expenses, costs, charges etc incurred till the date of payment and/or realization. If the said Obligor(s) shall fail to make payment to AFL as aforesaid, then AFL shall proceed against the above Secured Asset(s)/Immovable Property (ies) under Section 13(4) of the said Act and the applicable Rules entirely at the risk of the said Obligor(s)/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) as to the costs and consequences.
The said Obligor(s)/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) are prohibited under the said Act to transfer the aforesaid Secured Asset(s)/Immovable Property(ies), whether by way of sale, lease or otherwise without the prior written consent of AFL. Any person who contravenes or abets contravention of the provisions of the Act or Rules made thereunder shall be liable for imprisonment and/or penalty as provided under the Act.

Place: Fatehabad, Haryana

For Axis Finance Limited
Authorised Officer



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

Sr. No.	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD (BAR) BRANCH, SIRSA	SPECIAL REPAIR ESTIMATE FOR AGRICULTURE COTTON BUILDING AT SIRSA IN SIRSA DISTRICT.	24.09.2026 05.10.2026	1,09,51,655/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01665220530 pwt-eestd@sirsa@hry.nic.in
2	AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE DEPARTMENT YAMUNANAGAR.	CONSTRUCTION OF RETAINING WALL AT VILLAGE KHOL, FATEHGARH BLOCK CHHACHRAULI, DISTT. -YAMUNANAGAR.	23.09.2026 30.09.2026	2,51,93,77/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9991166622 acoyayunanagar25@gmail.com
3	PWD BAR, HISAR	RECONSTRUCTION AND STRENGTHENING OF DUNGS. ROADS (1) PATTAN TO HINDRAWAN ROAD RD 0.00 TO 4.286 (ROAD ID 10614) (2) GORICHA TO MEHRAJ ROAD RD 0.00 TO 4.286 (ROAD ID 10615) (3) BALSAMAND SARASNA TO SARASNA ABADI RD 0.00 TO 0.250 (ROAD ID 5048) IN HISAR DISTT. (NALWA CONSTITUENCY WORK PROGRAMME 2026-27) (GROUP NO. 6)	CLOSING DATE 01.10.2026	4,63,95,578/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9878384999 pwt-eestd@hisar@hry.nic.in
4	PANCHAYATI RAJ BHIWANI	CONST. OF IPB RASTA FROM PWD ROAD TO FIO MAHENDER S/O KARYSINGH VILLAGE -RATERA BLOCK -BAWANI KHARA.	24.09.2026 29.09.2026	51,04,018/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01664243927 premseng.bhw@hry.nic.in
5	PANCHAYATI RAJ BHIWANI	COMPLETION OF GRAM SACHIVALYA AT VILL- GORIPUR BLOCK BHIWANI. + 3 WORKS	24.09.2026 29.09.2026	45,04,469/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01664243927 premseng.bhw@hry.nic.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.49674/HRY



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

Sr. No.	NAME OF BOARD/ CORP./A UTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HVPNL	TENDER REF NO. 2026EPPF044 39E34E8B3FF060946114B197HVP FOR REPAIR AND MAINTENANCE WORK IN QUARTER NO-B-11/5-B-12/A/2 AT RESIDENTIAL BUILDING MEHRAJ ROAD HVPNL GURUGRAM (ONLINE TENDER REF. ID 2026_HBC_540992_1.)	18.09.2026 05.10.2026	2,78,447/-	www.hvpn.org.in	0172-2583789 PRO@HVPNL.ORG.IN
2	HVPNL	CREATION OF 33 KV BAY AT 132 KV SUBSTATION JUNDLA TO ACCOMMODATE THE CREATION OF 33 KV S/STN BANSA, CHIRAO ROAD AND CAPACITOR BANK AND AUGMENTATION OF 132 KV JUNDLA FROM 1X40/50MVA 132/33 KV PLUS 2X16/20MVA 132/11 KV T/PS TO 1X40/50MVA PLUS 1X20/25 MVA PLUS 2X16/20 MVA 132/11 KV T/PS (CONSTRUCTION OF 01 NO DT-2, 3NO 33KV LA, AND 2NO NCT (CIVIL WORKS)).(DISTRICT KARNALI)	22.09.2026 01.10.2026	1,17,701/-	www.hvpn.org.in	0172-2583789 PRO@HVPNL.ORG.IN
3	HVPNL	REPLACEMENT OF EXISTING CONDUCTOR 8.4 S/ACSR CONDUCTOR WITH EQUIVALENT HTLS CONDUCTOR OF CURRENT CARRYING CAPACITY OF 1200 AMP ON TURUNKY BASIS(PANCHKULA)	23.09.2026 16.10.2026	EMD 194 LACS	www.hvpn.org.in	0172-2583789 PRO@HVPNL.ORG.IN
4	HVPNL	CREATION OF 132 KV & 66 KV TRANSMISSION LINE IN KARNALI, AMPALA & SIRSA AREA	23.09.2026 16.10.2026	EMD 89.36 LACS	www.hvpn.org.in	0172-2583789 PRO@HVPNL.ORG.IN
5	HVPNL	REPLACEMENT OF EXISTING CONDUCTOR 0.5 S/ACSR CONDUCTOR WITH EQUIVALENT HTLS CONDUCTOR OF CURRENT CARRYING CAPACITY OF 1200 AMP ON TURUNKY BASIS(PANCHKULA)	23.09.2026 16.10.2026	EMD 127 LACS	www.hvpn.org.in	0172-2583789 PRO@HVPNL.ORG.IN

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No.49645/HRY



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-Tendering Tender Notice

Dy. Chief Engineer/ workshop/ Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invite "Open Tender" through On Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

E-Tender No. : DY-CE-JHSW-103
Earnest Money Rs. : 648100/-

Description of Work : RSK/STL-Comprehensive infrastructure upgradation at RSK/STL.

Approx Cost Rs. : 32402387.45 (Three crore twenty four lakh two Thousand three hundred eighty seven Rupees and forty five paise Only)

Cost of Tender Form Rs. : NIL
Date of closing of Tender. : 22.10.2026 At 15:30 hrs

Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 12 Months

* For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.reps.gov.in 2175/26 (AS)

f North central railways **@** www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in **X** CPNCR@

Additional Chief Engineer P.W.D. Zone-II, Jaipur
PWD Campus, Jacob Road, Jaipur
Phone:- 0141-2226537 Ex.:-299
E-mail:- acezoneii@yahoo.com/acejprii.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in

File No.- 1322
Date- 19.09.2026

NIT NO-28/2026-27
Bids for "Budget Announcement Year 2026-27, 08 Packages/ Road Works in Jaipur-Rural District are invited from interested bidders upto 6.00 PM on dated 15-10-2026. Other particulars of the bid may be seen on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>) of the state; and <http://pwd.rajasthan.gov.in>. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 4028.05lacs.

S.No	UBN	S.No	UBN	S.No	UBN
1	PWD2627WLOB12740	2	PWD2627WSOB12846	8	PWD2627WLOB12849

Addl. Chief Engineer
PWD Zone-II Jaipur

DIPR/C/16388/2026

EXPORT PROMOTION COUNCIL FOR MEDICAL DEVICES
(Set-up by Department of Pharmaceuticals, Ministry and Chemical and Fertilizers & YEIDA)
YEIDA, Second Floor, Commercial Complex, P-2, Sector Omega 1, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh – 201308

Reference No.: EPCMD/EVENTS/09/2026-01 Dated: 26th September 2026

Request for Proposal (RFP) for Selection of Event Management Agency for India MedTech Expo 2027

Detailed tender document is available on the Export Promotion Council for Medical Devices website (<https://www.epcmd.in/tenders>) from 26/09/2026.

Interested applicants are required to submit their bids to EPCMD Office on or before 15/10/2026, 1000 hrs (IST) as per the tender document.

In case of any queries, the bidders are invited to contact on the following email id.

ED, EPCMD
E-mail: ed@epcmd.in



Directorate of Tourism, Government of Jharkhand
2nd Floor, FFP Building, HEC Campus, Dhurwa, Ranchi – 834004
Email: dirjharkhandtourism@gmail.com/jtcdtld02@gmail.com

EOI Reference No.: 937/2026
EOI Reference No.: 937/2026

● MEDAL TALLY

Po	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	107	41	28	176
2	Japan	31	49	49	129
3	S Korea	16	21	36	73
4	Uzb'stan	8	17	9	34
5	Kaz'stan	8	8	19	35
10	India	4	12	14	30

DAY 8 CAPSULE

Haul: 2 Gold, 3 Silver, 2 Bronze

2 GOLD

● **Men's & Women's Kabaddi**

Both the men's and women's teams won their respective finals against Iran to win the third and fourth gold medals for India at the Asiad.

3 SILVER

● **Men's Marathon**

Sawan Barwal won silver with a national record of 2:11:37. This was India's 1st men's marathon medal since New Delhi 1982.

● **Men's Shot put**

After golds in 2018 and 2022, Tajinderpal Singh Toor won a silver medal with a throw of 20.64m.

● **50m 3P Women's team**

India's women's team of Tilotama Sen, Vidarsa K Vinod and Ashi Chouksey won the team silver with a combined score of 1763.

2 BRONZE

● **Mixed doubles squash**

Joshna Chinappa-Velavan Senthilkumar lost to Tang Ming Hong-Lee Ka Yi of Hong Kong in the semifinal.

● **Women's 400m**

Prachi won a bronze medal in the 400m, clocking a time of 53.21s for her bronze medal.

● TODAY'S PICKS

DAY 9

Squash: Men's singles final (12:30 PM)

● Abhay Singh faces Eain Yow NG in the final.

Squash: Women's singles final (1:30 PM)

● Anahat Singh will face Sivasangari Subramaniam in the final.

Shooting: Women's 25m pistol qualification precision (6:10 AM)

● Esha Singh, Manu Bhaker and Rahi Sarnobat will participate in the precision stage of the 25m pistol qualification.

Athletics: Men's decathlon (7:30 AM onwards), Women's Long jump (3:25 PM), Men's High jump (4:15 PM) Women's 3000m steeplechase (5:52 PM)

● Tejaswin Shankar is leading after the first five events in Decathlon. He will aim to upgrade his silver medal from 2023. Sarvesh Kushare in high jump and Parul Chaudhary in 3000m SC will be in action.

Badminton: Women's doubles (6:00 AM onwards), Women's singles (6:00 AM onwards)

● Treesa Jolly-Gayatri Gopichand along with Unnati Hooda and PV Sindhu will play their quarters.

MEN'S KABADDI FINAL

With Manga fans watching, India beat old foes Iran for gold

A needle-filled final, referencing 2023's chaotic finish, ended 40-33 in India's favour



Mihir Vasavda

Nagoya, September 26

HIRAMATSU HISAMOTO had come to watch manga come alive. The 16-year-old Nagoya resident had discovered kabaddi through the pages of *Burning Kabaddi*, the award-winning Japanese graphic novel. Forty minutes later, after watching India and Iran turn the mat into a blur of flying limbs, twisting bodies and desperate escapes, he left with a new urge, to try kabaddi himself. It was India who left with the gold.

The 40-33 victory gave them their second kabaddi gold of the Asian Games and fourth overall, pushing them into the top 10 of the medal table.

For those who had discovered the sport through drawings, the live version was considerably more visceral: raiders twisting away from ankle holds, defenders launching themselves at legs, a hand stretching for the line while the rest of the body seemed to be travelling in another direction. At times, the acrobatics looked straight out of manga. "I feel like trying it now," said Konsei Kani.

This was the Clásico de kabaddi. There is history between these two teams, and there is memory too. Iran ended India's run of seven successive men's Asian Games golds in 2018, beating them in the semi-final. India waited five years to reclaim the title, and when they did, it was against Iran again, a 33-29 victory in Hangzhou in 2023, in a final that descended into arguments, protests and an hour-long stoppage with the scores locked at



India men's kabaddi team celebrating after winning the gold. (Below) The cover of *Burning Kabaddi*, a Manga (a graphic novel). AP/FILE

28-28. So this was never going to be just another final. There was a needle, too.

"When Iran travelled to Pakistan before the Asian Games to prepare, that time (Mohammadreza) Shadlou said the gold medal will be theirs," said captain Sunil Kumar. "I just want to remind him they were playing India." And so, there were fireworks. Every raid seemed to carry something from the previous encounters. Defenders celebrated tackles in the faces of raiders. Raiders paused, provoked and probed. Players exchanged words after points.

The Iranian bench reacted to Indian challenges; the Indian bench reacted right back. There was little routine about the opening 20 minutes, except the sense that neither side wanted merely to beat the other. They wanted to impose themselves.

For a while, Iran did. India's raiding lacked penetration, while Amirmohammad Zafar Danesh and Ali Samadi kept finding cracks in the defence. Zafar moved laterally, dragging defenders away from position

before attacking the space he had created. Devank, India's principal raider, was swallowed up twice by Fazel Atrachali. Aslam Inamdar once went too deep and couldn't make his way back. India led 13-10, but Iran turned it around, took an all-out, and went into half-time 18-17 ahead.

Then India changed the game, and with it, the mood. The defence stopped giving Iran the same openings. The raiders stopped offering Iran the same targets. India began moving defenders across the mat, making them commit before attacking the space behind them. Shadlou and Zafar were picked off. Arjun Deshwal got Bastami. Amirhossein Taghipour came on and was immediately caught. Devank, after being frustrated by Atrachali twice, finally got the veteran defender on a raid.

Iran were suddenly chasing. India went from 23-21 to an all-out and 26-23, then stretched the lead further. Sumit's tackle on Zafar made it 32-25.

Devank and Arjun, who alternated raids in the first half, got steadier returns and kept Iran's defence guessing, while Aslam Inamdar began to turn the clock into another Indian weapon. With 3:21 left and India 36-29 ahead, Aslam stood almost teasingly close to the line, waiting for the Iranian defenders to come to him.

When they did, he slipped through the opening and took two with him. It was a raid that seemed to contain everything kabaddi does best: speed, balance, deception, body control, and the ability to see a gap before it exists. India had spent the first half trying to break through Iran's defence. In the second, they made Iran move until it

WOMEN WIN TITLE AFTER CAGEY AFFAIR

New Delhi: The Indian women's kabaddi team defeated Iran to secure what at the time was India's third gold medal at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games, before the men's team had followed suit. In a tense encounter that ebbed and flowed throughout its course, India won the contest by a 37-34 margin. India have won the gold medal in every previous edition of women's kabaddi at the Asia Games, save for the 2018 iteration in Jakarta, where they finished second behind Iran. This was their fourth gold medal at the Asiad, taking India's total Kabaddi gold tally — across categories — to thirteen. Overall, India now has four gold medals to its name — won by the men's and women's kabaddi team, the women's cricket team, and the mixed 10m Pistol team of Kamaljeet and Suruchi Phogat. ENS

broke itself apart. And still, the rivalry needed one final scene.

On Iran's last raid, Sunil stood in front of Shadlou, almost taunting him with the certainty that India had had the last word. "I just wanted to remind him that they were playing India and the gold medal is India's," Sunil said. The two had to be separated. Moments later, Sunil and Shadlou hugged. The embrace did not erase what had happened over the previous 40 minutes. It made it mean more.

For all the arguments, provocation and old scores carried onto the mat, there was also the recognition between two rivals who keep meeting, keep pushing each other, and keep producing nights like this.

The Japanese spectators had come to watch manga come alive. They left wanting to play the game themselves.

Aslam's path: From ticketless journeys & odds jobs to podium

Mihir Vasavda

Nagoya, September 26

WHEN HE was in his early teens, Aslam Inamdar would scavenge discarded bottles and sell them to scrap dealers to afford a meal. He would travel across Maharashtra to play kabaddi tournaments, sleeping under train seats, boarding trains without tickets, surviving on vada pav or whatever food he could find. Sometimes he would save leftover tournament food in his bag to eat later, even after it had gone bad.

On Saturday, the 26-year-old from Taklibhan village in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar found himself on the other side of that struggle.

Having helped India beat Iran in the Asian Games final, the all-rounder had a gold medal around his neck and, for nearly 30 minutes, posed for selfies and made reels with it. For a man who had once worked at tea stalls, washed utensils, cleaned washrooms and laboured in the fields to make ends meet, the moment was almost impossible to comprehend. "It still feels like a dream to me," Inamdar said. "I often think about how someone who didn't even have food at home now holds two international medals."

When his father died, his mother was left to raise five children. She worked in other people's homes, doing chores and washing utensils, to keep the family going. His elder brother, Waseem Inamdar, joined the police force and took on responsibility for the family. Inamdar was determined to make a name for himself in kabaddi, the way his brother had.

He took what-

On the mat, Inamdar became a versatile all-rounder, playing the left cover position and contributing to both India's defensive and attacking efforts. He was instrumental in the win over Iran on Saturday, coming on as a substitute in the first half, when India were trailing, and changing the game with his raids.

He now shares his journey with younger players at his training ground in Thane. "Pro Kabaddi gave me name, fame, money and respect. I have represented India and won medals," he says. "So I want young, underprivileged players to dream big and aim to achieve even more than I have."

with a games record of 20.75m. Toor defended his crown in Hangzhou with a throw of 20.36m. This year, Toor crossed 20 metres nine times but has only one 21-metre-plus throw. For an athlete who has suffered injury after injury, his third Asian Games medal was a mini-miracle. Before the Commonwealth Games, he suffered a Grade-One tear in his calf. "Prior to CWG, I suffered a calf strain and post the CWG, the MRI revealed that it was a Grade-One tear. I manage by adjusting technique. My coach MS Dhillon tells me never to stop," Toor said.

Competing with injuries

ever work he could find: washing tea glasses at stalls, working at juice bars, cleaning washrooms, labouring in the fields. There were days he worked through the day and night, only to head to the kabaddi ground for practice. "I faced many hard situations without letting them break me," he says.

By 15, he was travelling alone to local weight-category tournaments. "I traveled extensively on trains without tickets, sleeping under seats to play local tournaments, earning Rs 200 to 500 per match. Sometimes, I would compete even if they would just give me food," he says, clutching his medal.

It was enough to keep him going. Kabaddi, he says, offered a chance to build a life beyond the one he had known. His elder brother's reputation as a kabaddi player across several districts, and the example of senior player Rahul Bhor, fuelled his ambition. It was also a sport he could afford, requiring little beyond a playing surface and the will to keep turning up.

There was a time, though, when even that dream seemed out of reach. In 2014, when India won gold at the Asian Games, Inamdar was watching on television with a fractured leg. "I believe God's plans are always better," he says. "My hard work never stopped. If your intentions are good and you stay a good human being, God supports you 100 per cent."

The breakthrough came with the Pro Kabaddi League. In his first season, in 2020, he earned Rs 8 lakh, a sum that, he said, felt like Rs 8 crore to him. "With that money, I bought my mother a gold necklace," he says.

On the mat, Inamdar became a versatile all-rounder, playing the left cover position and contributing to both India's defensive and attacking efforts. He was instrumental in the win over Iran on Saturday, coming on as a substitute in the first half, when India were trailing, and changing the game with his raids.

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Toor misses out on third gold, but silver brings joy after pain

Nitin Sharma

Chandigarh, September 26

DESPITE MISSING out on a hat-trick of gold medals in the men's shot put, there was a takeaway for Tajinderpal Singh Toor. He dedicated his silver medal to his 10-month-old daughter Rabab Kaur Toor. Rabab, Toor said, was his lucky charm. Her birth took away the pain he and his wife experienced after she had two miscarriages. Their dream of becoming parents lay shattered before the little one came into

their lives last November.

"This medal is for my daughter Rabab Kaur Toor. My wife lost two babies during her pregnancy, in 2022 and in 2024. Rabab has been the lucky mascot for me," Toor told *The Indian Express* from Nagoya.

Toor, 31, won silver with a best throw of 20.64m. But it was a bittersweet day as he saw his Asian Games record of 20.75 metres being bettered by Iran's Mohammadreza Tayebise, who won gold with 20.81m. When it was confirmed that he would finish second, Toor folded his hands in prayer before posing for pictures while holding the Tricolour aloft.

This medal is an answer to all those who questioned my ability. Winning a third Asian Games medal is a special feeling."

TAJINDERPAL SINGH TOOR

Saturday was also a comeback of sorts for Toor, who seemed to have gone off the boil when was third in the Inter-State National Cham-

pionships in Bhubaneswar earlier this year. At the Inter-State, he finished behind Karamveer Singh and Samardeep Gill, but when it mattered on the big day Toor finished on the podium. Karamveer, the only other Indian in the shot put final, finished 10th.

"People had started talking after my performance at the Inter-State. This medal is an answer to all those who questioned my ability. Winning a third Asian Games medal is a special feeling," Toor, who hails from Khosa Pando village in Moga district, said.

In 2018, Toor had won the Asian Games title in Jakarta

● NEW NATIONAL RECORD

Two history-making runs: Barwal's stunning five-month marathon career

Prithish Raj

New Delhi, September 26

SAWAN BARWAL has run two marathons in his life. Both have gone into the record books.

The first, at Rotterdam in April 2026, lowered a national record that had stood since Shivnath Singh set it 48 years earlier. The second, at the Asian Games five months later, lowered that record again, and ended a 44-year wait for an Indian medal in the event. "The plan was always to challenge for the podium. I had been training for this moment for so long, so if I didn't win a medal, all of it would have felt like a waste of effort," Barwal said after his win.

Saturday's race in Nagoya was run in damp conditions, with a light drizzle throughout. Of the 20 athletes on the start list,

eleven had a faster personal best than Barwal. On paper, he wasn't among the favourites. Marathon running, though, rewards guile and resilience over a start list.

"I knew the conditions and predicted a 2:10 or 2:11 race. Sawan only had to execute what we did in training given his fitness at the moment, and his self-belief makes him more lethal and efficient in tough conditions," coach Scott Simmons told *The Indian Express*.

In the five months between his two marathons, Barwal moved to Colorado Springs to train under Simmons, the coach who has also worked with Gulveer Singh and Avinash Sable.

The move changed who Barwal trains alongside. "Training with faster athletes has really pushed me a lot. All those training sessions with such athletes

help you in a championship race," Barwal told this paper. Simmons put a number on the gap: Barwal now trains regularly with Zouhair Talbi (2:03:45), Yemane Haileselassie (2:06:06) and Hillary Bor (2:08:40), each five to six minutes faster than him over the distance.

In Colorado Springs, Barwal ran 190 kilometres a week and completed three marathon simulations before arriving in Aichi. "He was a middle distance runner before. After the switch, things have changed. There are longer sessions now for him, which he has adapted to pretty well," Simmons said.

The plan for Saturday was simple in outline, harder in execution. "Our strategy was to approach the race just as he has approached our big marathon workouts. One has to under-



Sawan Barwal won a silver medal in men's marathon. REUTERS



Sawan has got immense potential. It will be important for him to continue his marathon-specific development and compete at major marathons."

SCOTT SIMMONS, SAWAN'S COACH

stand that in the marathon, 30k is half way. The last 10k is where the medals are decided," Simmons said.

That is roughly how it played out. By halfway, Barwal was in the leading pack, running shoulder to shoulder with eventual gold medalist Ichitaka Yamashita. "Our target was to stay with the group till the end. If we could maintain that position, the chances of winning the medal would increase," Barwal said. After the 30km mark, the race narrowed, as Simmons had predicted. By the final 10km, only three runners remained in contention. "His fitness means that he can sustain the last 10km. Consistent training and his work with faster athletes culminated in the podium. A personal best in a championship race is excellent," Simmons said.

Simmons believes Barwal is in shape to run 2:09 in future marathons. Barwal wants to go lower still. "When I switched to marathons, the target was to break the national record. I believe I can lower it further down to 2:08," he said.

Simmons sees more races ahead. "Sawan has got immense potential. It will be important for him to continue his marathon-specific development and to have opportunities for major marathons so he can test his ability. Ideally, he will target to qualify for the World Championships and Olympics to represent India there," he said.

What time Barwal eventually runs is a question for later. For now, in two marathons, he has broken a national record twice and given India a medal it had waited 44 years for.

2027 ODI World Cup will be ‘my last for India’, confirms Kohli



Virat Kohli has scored 14,941 runs in the 50-over format. FILE

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 26

INDIAN BATTING titan Virat Kohli has confirmed that the 2027 ODI World Cup in South Africa and Zimbabwe will be his final one.

“For me, it’s the last World Cup I’m going to play for India,” Kohli told broadcaster JioStar on Saturday. “That is my motivation and like, you know, to leave everything out there. And of course, the goal is absolutely to win the World Cup and whatever it takes, I’m absolutely ready.”

Kohli has scored 14,941 runs in the 50-over format, second only to his fellow countryman Sachin Tendulkar’s 18,426 runs on the all-time top-scorer list. The former captain won the World Cup on home soil in 2011, but has since had to deal with multiple heartbreaks in this tournament, perhaps none more agonising than the defeat to Australia in the final of the 2023 iteration.

Rohit Sharma, who also plays only this format, said he is motivated to play the next World Cup

The upcoming World Cup will be Kohli’s fifth in the 50-over format. “The intensity of a 50-over World Cup is greater than anything. Because now, it’s about 10 games at a Twenty20 level of intensity. But you are playing 2.5 T20 games in one day. And to maintain that intensity for 10 games in a big tournament and World Cup is a big deal. Also now, it’s in foreign conditions. It takes a lot out of you,” he said.

Rohit Sharma, who also plays only this format, said he is motivated to play the next World Cup.

“The thought will never cross my mind that the business I had is finished,” he said. “As long as you’re playing, there is always something to look forward to. And I’m looking forward to the World Cup,” the captain of India’s 2023 World Cup further added. Should he be selected, the upcoming World Cup will be his fourth.

SQUASH: TWO INDIANS IN SINGLES FINAL FOR THE FIRST TIME

A bloodied finger, two match points saved and a final berth



Anahat Singh’s reflection is seen in the glass wall during her squash women’s singles semifinal against Japan’s Satomi Watanabe. PTI

Anahat, 18, fights back from brink of defeat; Abhay also advances to the summit clash

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, September 26

NOTHING COULD derail Anahat Singh on Saturday. Not a world No. 6 opponent. Not two match balls. Not a nasty collision. Down 9-10 in the second game, after losing the first, Anahat banged her head into Satomi Watanabe’s shoulder while chasing a return. The blow looked painful in replays. Her finger bled, her neck hurt. She received medical attention and returned to court. She fought on, drilled an opening, and moved for the Kill.

The 18-year-old later called it the best win of her life. Minutes later, Abhay Singh added a fresh chapter to Indian squash history: the country had two individual finalists at the Asian Games for the first time. Sunday offers the prospect of two gold medals, and with them, two spots at the Los Angeles Olympics, where squash will make its debut.

Though she trailed 0-2 and 8-10 at one point against Watanabe, Anahat never looked beaten. The first three games were taut, the Indian matching her better-ranked rival stroke for stroke. She saved two game balls in the opener and had a game ball of her own in Game 2.



Abhay Singh (L) shakes hands with Pakistan’s Muhammad Irfan after their semifinal. PTI

The shots Anahat was missing from the back of the court in the first half became audacious winners in the second, which made the turnaround all the more remarkable. Two drop shots into the backhand corner at 8-10 in Game 3 saved the first match ball.

Another, into the same spot, saved the second. A contentious call for obstruction followed. Commentators felt it should have been a let, but it was given as a stroke to Anahat. She capitalised with a winner off the side wall and let out a shriek. Watanabe was shaken, and Anahat never looked back. The next two games saw the full weight of the teenager’s shotmaking, as she conceded just nine points. The scoreline read 9-11, 11-13, 12-10, 11-6, 11-3 after 51 minutes.

“When I was losing, the first thought in my head was that I can’t let the Olympic spot go by so quickly and that kept replaying in my head. It really motivated me,” Anahat told re-

Though she trailed 0-2 and 8-10 at one point against Watanabe, Anahat never looked beaten

porters after her match.

Watanabe is ranked 11 places above the Indian. The last time the two met was at the Tournament of Champions in January, where the Japanese player won 3-2 in an equally tense match. “I have never defeated anyone ranked this high. She is ranked six in the world and I have lost to her before. So, this is easily the best and biggest win of my squash career,” Anahat said.

She will need to go one better on Sunday against top seed and defending champion Sivasangari Subramaniam. Anahat sounded upbeat about the final. “She is a great player, I have played her numerous times before. I am excited to get on the court and see what I can do. Hopefully I can turn it around like this time.”



Unlike Anahat’s thriller, Abhay’s semi-final against Muhammad Irfan was one-sided. The second seed lived up to his billing, outclassing the Pakistani in straight games. Abhay was rampant in Game 1, before Irfan levelled up somewhat. He still won with ease, the scoreline reading 11-3, 12-10, 11-6.

“When an event comes once in three or four years, I think

you turn up and do well. You don’t really get these chances that often, so yeah, I’m making the most of it,” Abhay said after his win.

He was far more composed on Saturday than at the previous Asiad, in Hangzhou. After losing his rubbers in the early rounds of the team event there, Abhay had cursed himself for letting his team-mates down.

He recovered eventually, and dug deep in the final to help India beat Pakistan for gold. The animated player from that campaign was at odds with the calm one on show now. Asked about the change, Abhay said: “Yeah, I was a bit more immature last time, a bit more mature this time, a bit more calm. So yeah, pumped up, yes, but I know how to keep my nerves a bit better.” He put it down to “age, experience and working with people”, crediting coach James Willstrop.

“Multiple Commonwealth (Games) gold medallist, world number one. If someone knows how to keep their nerve in big matches, it’s players like these,” the 28-year-old said. Like Anahat, Abhay faces a stiff test, in the form of reigning champion Ng Eain Yow.

The Malaysian top seed beat Pakistan’s Noor Zaman in the semis. His opponent was decided much later, but Abhay’s reaction to a potential India-Pakistan final was clear. “I think all the people listening to you (journalists) love the India-Pakistan stuff, but for us it’s just another opponent, just another match. We’re here for gold.”

Treesa-Gayatri, Unnati continue to upset applegart en route QFs

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, September 26

GETTING INTO the Asian Games team isn’t always easy. Though, once there, you might even reach the quarterfinals like Treesa Jolly-Gayatri Gopichand and Unnati Hooda did.

A fortnight before the World Championships, those in charge of firming up badminton entries were politely asked by those clearing the squads headed to Nagoya, if Treesa-Gayatri deserved to be on the Asiad team. Their ranking was down because Treesa was nursing an injury and hadn’t been on the circuit. Those asking, were politely told that the selection would hold.

The pair of 23-year-olds haven’t stopped creating one upset, after another, ever since. The World Championships at Delhi saw them claim India’s only bronze. And though the doubting-drama never reared its head again, Treesa-Gayatri have gone about the Asian Games, doing the “needful.”

In the space of a week, the duo has twice brought down the Japanese World No 3 pairing, first in the Team event, India’s only win in a 1-3 tie loss. And on Saturday, in the Round-of-16 of the individual event, as they defeated the hugely experienced Yuki Fukushima and Mayu Matsumoto, who have 7 World Championship medals between them, with a 24-22, 21-18 take-down, to reach quarterfinals.

This means they are in Asia’s best 8 at the moment, after being in the World’s best 4 at Delhi, a month ago. Treesa-Gayatri politely proved a point with wins – four top-ten scalps in a month. They won’t pretend former World runners up, Pearly Tan and Thinaah Muralitharan of Malaysia, will be easy to beat. But they will work hard on their plans, and execute them earnestly, and a shade impolitely – like Treesa’s wicked corner-net dribbles, that saw decorated Fukushima, literally pull her hair out in frustration.

These dribbles were practiced on days spent nursing the ankle – sometimes sitting on a bench because she could barely stand up. There were other tactics. Matsumoto and Fukushima might’ve learnt exactly what the Indians do to confuse them. Treesa reins in her titanic smash attack and turns it into a proper tease – sliced drops after a jump that plop like the first of raindrops on the front court. The Japanese, 31 and 33, were left pleading for the smash to arrive, for their defense could tackle it. Then there was Gayatri.

Her hand-speed is two clicks quicker so the reactions are lightning fast. She knows a smash is a drizzle, a tadkaa, a lime-squeeze or a garnish – not the main course. She kept alternating attacks on the body with the one on flanks, the tipples to



Unnati Hooda defeated World No. 6 Putri Kusuma Wardani. BAI

the net with the clears to the back, keeping them constantly guessing. It’s creative, yet physically demanding. But opponents are struggling to know what Indians are up to.

That said Indians themselves don’t overthink the rally. Coach Gopichand kept asking Treesa to not use the smash as a sledgehammer, but a syringe-prick. Hit one, then back off, float the next, then one more, and then sting with the smash again.

The top Japanese pair, with home support, and two seasoned coaches, just couldn’t clear the maze. But for those who politely wondered if this pairing were good enough for India, these wins might momentarily suffice.

Big win

Unnati Hooda, who has dared to enter the Top 30 realm to line up behind PV Sindhu, has faced edgeways-questions too. Does she deserve to play India’s second singles? Why doesn’t she join up with a known academy? And the most laughable of all: Why is her footwork so poor?

After she defeated World No 6 Putri Kusuma Wardani, 21-19, 21-13, court-side coach Guru Saidutt sitting for her match, guffawed. “Both her opponents were technically solid, had great footwork. She still beat them! She has something else-

the ability to keep the shuttle in play. Grit. Even when she is tired, she just doesn’t leave the shuttle. And that wins you matches. Footwork is alright,” he chuckled.

Unnati had played an arduous, sapping 80-minute match against Malaysian Wong Chin Lin, winning 21-14, 20-22, 21-19. The Asian Games schedule demanded she show up within three hours, to play the World No 6.

After Wardani went from 11-15 to 17-15, Unnati dragged it back on sheer persistence, going on in long rallies, underterred in the first set. That patience ate into Wardani’s resolve and with desperation came the errors.

Not giving up when tired is what wins you matches. And Unnati used her discipline and blinkers to simply do everything to keep the shuttle in play. Wardani started cracking and went into survival mode, stopping to hit her smashes altogether.

“Wardani could’ve come back. But Unnati didn’t make errors that top players like pouncing on. Our girl held on; she didn’t leave a single shuttle despite being tired,” Guru said. “You have to give it to her mental strength. She was just not leaving the shuttle even when physically exhausted. This grit is rare, I’ve seen it only in Saina,” Guru added.

World Cup plans rest on Hardik’s fitness

Sandip G
Thiruvananthapuram, September 26

THERE IS no countdown clock peering at Team India in Thiruvananthapuram, no ticking needles to remind them that the World Cup is 373 days away. But the reminders are frequent enough. In the press conference rooms. In the pleasantries exchanged with acquaintances. In the calendar, which carves out more days for a format now some way past middle age.

The house, on first impressions, is beatific. Half a dozen of its inhabitants could win a day, or a night, on their own. Champagne bottles and trophies sit on the mantelpiece. Three of them, Virat Kohli, Rohit Sharma and Jasprit Bumrah, are among the greatest the game has produced.

Vaunted talents push for spots, Yashasvi Jaiswal, Ruturaj Gaikwad, Tilak Varma among them, keeping the seniors on their toes and giving the selectors a headache no aspirin will fix. At full strength, the house looks dazzling.

But as with many grand old houses, you need to step inside to spot the shapeless rooms, the leaking drainage, the clumsy wiring, the creaking furniture. Not uninhabitable, but not as magnificent as it looks from outside.

The series against West Indies, ranked tenth, will not



Hardik Pandya was the missing link in the 2023 final. FILE

test the foundations the way a World Cup will, but it is a chance to check how sturdy those foundations are before the storms get worse. India have lost seven of their last 15 games in this format, not the number a team with world-beating ambitions wants to carry. It is an ageing house. Four of its pillars will be 35 or beyond when the tournament begins.

Age hasn’t touched the form yet, but even a brief ailing spell between now and then would cause panic. Gaikwad, Yashasvi and Jurel are outsiders for now, but this series is a platform to find runs, stay in the selectors’ memory, and be ready if the call comes. Batting, though, is the smaller of India’s worries.

The real state of the house shows in the rear and the kitchen. The balance hinges on one pillar, Hardik Pandya, the brick that holds the walls to-

gether. His form is seldom in doubt; his fitness is. He was the missing link in the 2023 final, perhaps the reason India lost after an otherwise irresistible march. A new shin injury has ruled him out of the series against Australia, and he has not played an ODI since the Champions Trophy. Since then, India have fretted over balance, weighing an extra batsman against an extra bowler.

The old flaw persists: none of India’s batsmen bowl, and among the bowlers guaranteed a start, only Ravindra Jadeja bats. Nitish Kumar Reddy offers a balm, though it isn’t clear if he’s a long-term answer. His batting has flourished in Tests, his bowling in T20s. In ODIs, he hasn’t yet strung together the performance that would let the selectors relax. He will figure in the next few series regardless, with time to develop.

If his career takes off, he could be more than Hardik’s back-up: an ally, a second engine to power India toward the title it hasn’t won. If Hardik keeps breaking down and Nitish flatlines, India’s balance would be as asymmetric as a scalene triangle. India have to prepare for that scenario too, a composition without either of them, which would look very different and far less balanced.

Nothing will be left to chance, or to last-minute scrambling. What lies between

now and the World Cup will be experiments and adjustments, not wholesale change: pieces moved carefully into and out of place, with one eye on the destination and the other on not losing so often that the dressing room’s confidence cracks.

Search continues

The search for a multi-utility cricketer has also raised Harshit Rana’s stock, a seamer who can bat with some freedom. It is why the team management tolerates his injury history and occasionally scattergun bowling. His 52 against New Zealand and in Indore only strengthened that faith.

If he can consistently touch 140kph, the management’s confidence in him will grow further. He could be the third name in India’s pace attack, now that Mohammed Shami’s return looks unlikely.

India’s spin combination is just as unsettled. It’s unlikely that Jadeja, Axar Patel and Kuldeep Yadav all make the flight to South Africa together. The next few months should offer clearer answers: whether India can mount a serious title challenge, whether an old flaw resurfaces to check their progress, and whether this grand old house can hold up in a South African storm.

LIVE: INDIA VS WEST INDIES, 1ST ODI, 2PM ONWARDS, STAR SPORTS, JIHOTSTAR

Savitha comes up clutch in India’s draw

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, September 26

A +3.6 evaluation out of the blue, a pawn down on the board and a decision that would define the Indian women’s team’s campaign in Samarkand. Under nauseating circumstances in the penultimate round of the 2026 Chess Olympiad, Savitha Shri B spent hours grinding out a defence against China’s Mo Zhai, before the scales tipped in her favour.

Beside her, Vantika Agrawal remained locked in an equally tense and unpredictable skirmish against Miaoyi Lu. Chasing a win carried the fatal risk of an overextension that could knock India off the podium entirely, and Savitha, instinctively leaning toward safety, repeated moves twice, teetering on the brink of a bittersweet draw.

And then, intuition took over. A captured piece rolled between the fingers of her left hand while her right hovered above the board, darting forward and pulling back. Another scan across the tables later, she made an instinctive call: instead of taking an easy exit, she would back herself to squeeze out a result. She slammed the brakes on the threefold repetition, played rook to d1 (45. Rd1) that instantly nullified every advantage. Savitha’s decision was a gamble that looked borderline reckless at the time, but in hindsight, it was the



Savitha Shri B got the better of China’s Mo Zhai. FIDE/RAFAŁ OLEKSIEWICZ

work of a genius. Shortly after, Vantika slipped to concede her first loss of the event. The hand-shake, hence, would have proven to be catastrophic, had Savitha taken it. That she did not, kept India alive.

Chaos ensued. In an endgame that swung wildly, Savitha came clutch. She outmanoeuvred Mo, converting a sensational win to drag India to a 2-2 draw. Sharing the spoils against China may not be the ideal result to wrest back control of the gold medal race, but Savitha’s eighth win of the tournament (8.5/9) kept India’s title defence breathing by a thread and ensured their fate on the podium remains in their own hands.

Vantika, unbeaten heading into Round 10, was forced into a marathon grind chasing a win, an overextension that came back to haunt her. Both her and

Savitha carried a burden after Koneru Humpy and Divya Deshmukh settled for quick draws on the top two boards.

The draw leaves India tied for third alongside Poland and Vietnam on 16 match points. China lead the pack with 18, while Kazakhstan sit second on 17. For the defending champs to retain gold, they would need an overwhelming win in the final round paired with big defeats for both China and Kazakhstan. Realistically, however, silver is now the best India can hope for.

Uzbekistan 2 routed

In the Open section, India decimated Uzbekistan in Round 10, albeit their second-string side. Clinical wins from R Praggnanandhaa, Nihal Sarin, and D Gukesh powered the team to a commanding 3.5-0.5 rout over Uzbekistan 2, con-

solidating their hold on sole second place right behind Uzbekistan’s senior team.

Nihal was the first to put his name on the scoresheet, comfortably dispatching Mukhammadzokhid Suyarov. On Board 4, defending world champion Gukesh continued his imperious run. He outwitted Orlík Nigmatov to notch his seventh victory of the tournament, moving to a staggering 8.5/10.

On the top board, Pragg engaged in a protracted battle with Jakhongir Vakhidov, but the Uzbek Grandmaster could only delay the inevitable before crumbling. Had it not been for another squandered opportunity by Arjun Erigaisi against Abdimalik Abdusalimov, India would have completed a clean 4-0 sweep. Arjun has now logged six consecutive draws and has just a solitary win under his belt in Samarkand.

Just a solitary match point separates the gold medallists of the last two Olympiads, setting up what promises to be a tantalising shootout between India and Uzbekistan. The hosts cling to the top spot with 17 match points, while India sit on 16, just ahead of Ukraine, Germany, and Hungary knotted at 15. Much like the women’s section, defending the crown is no longer in their own hands. In the final round, Indian men will take on Hungary while the women will be up against tricky Georgia.



The Unlikely Superstar

Dubbed Flop Master General, he went on to become a star in Bengal. At his centenary celebrations, unpacking Uttam Kumar's appeal

Chef Anahita Dhondy's millet love



The Wind in her Hair

Women in India are riding further, faster and in greater numbers. What holds them together is the sense of community, not choosing just a destination but a direction

Reva Thakkar

IN A car, you watch the landscape through a window. On a bike, you feel the change in temperature, the wind, the surface of the road. You're in it," says actor-producer Gul Panag, who famously had a bikers-only doli for her wedding to Rishi Attari in 2011. Ask any biker what it means to have the rubber hit the road, it's not the two tons of steel, the foam padding, the safety glass or the full-face helmets that provide the safety. It's that inside feeling of being alive, that twist of the throttle that is both an art and a release, that comfort of fellow bikers that makes all the difference.

Drop a gear

Anjaly Rajan was seven when she rolled out her mother's Kinetic Honda. "I always loved bikes," she says. Today, alongside her jewellery business, she runs a female motorcycling club, Riderni, which started in Gujarat in 2012 and is now based in Kochi. "The first person I taught biking to was my mother. If she could do it, anyone could," says Anjaly. "Biking has always been a part of my life and no matter what happens, it will be there," she adds. She started with a 125cc Super Splendour and recently added a 937cc Ducati Monster to her collection. Her previous partner, who didn't love bikes, thought that because she was a woman, she would give up riding. The 38-year-old has decided to spend her life being single. "Some people feel that female bikers are outcasts, that they smoke, drink, and lead a certain lifestyle," she says. But no woman is apologising. "I call my bike the beast and I truly feel like the beast when I'm riding it," says Gurgaon-based Dr Neharika Yadav about her Ducati Panigale V4. "Our motorcycles are our family members, our life partners, our better halves," adds the dentist and a professional superbike racer. Gul says, "I also love how much riding asks of you. Your hands, eyes, balance and judgment have to work together. If my mind is wandering, the bike has a way of telling me to come back. That complete sense of being present is a large part of why I ride."

Country roads that don't take them home

Kalyani Potekar, India's fastest woman motorcycle racer, started riding in 2010, when seeing a woman on a motorcycle was still unusual. "Today, many more women are riding, touring, racing and participating in the motorcycling community. There is still a long way to go but women are increasingly claiming the handlebars," she says. She was nine when she first learned to ride,



watching her father race on dirt tracks in Indore. She went on to race professionally. She divides her riding life into two parts: "Racing is for my goals; touring is for my soul," she says.

The riding bug is spreading, with riders from Visakhapatnam, Pune, Bengaluru, Assam, Mumbai, Delhi and other cities, hitting the track.

Anita Krishnan, 43, who has spent almost 10 years leading tours and is national president of Women's International Motorcycling Association's Indian division, says biking also brings in adventure. "Exposure to adventure doesn't come naturally to Indian women because of societal conditioning and responsibilities," she says. It led her to co-found Moto Gypsy Adventure Tours, an independent motorcycle touring company that focuses on adventure tours for women, two years ago. Women from all backgrounds, professions, and ages have been a part of their adventures. In one of the tours to Ladakh, with mostly women over 40, upon reaching the top of Khardung La Pass, they were joyous, she says, "That sense of achievement is different."

Motorcycling isn't conventional and sometimes convincing your family to go itself is the first hurdle. Anita has met women from conservative families who prefer that they ride only in women groups and not with men.

Community matters

What happened to Shivani (Sia) Chauhan recently, in some form has happened to most women who ride a motorcycle in this country. She was chased by four men in a car for almost two kilometres, while on her way to a Gurugram cafe. The car rammed into her, making her fall off the bike, dragging the bike across the road. Much of this was captured because of Shivani's moto-vlogging.

Maral Yazarloo-Patrick, an Iranian biker based in India who has ridden across 70 countries, calls it the trigger for the male ego. "On a bike, people's behaviour can change when they realise I am a woman," she says. She founded a riders' tribe called the Lady Riders of India almost 10 years ago, with two requirements — a 650cc motorcycle and 10,000 kilometres ridden.

India has several women's biking clubs, with The Bikerni, started by Urvashi Patole and Firdaus Shaikh in 2011, being possibly the first. Today, it has over 2,500 members across 17 chapters in different states. It was also the inspiration for Taapsee Pannu's production, *Dhak Dhak* (2023).

"When I was younger, a lot of it was the excitement of discovering that I could ride this machine. Now I'm much more attentive to technique, the bike, the road, my own fatigue and the decisions I make along the way. I think I enjoy riding more because of that. I still feel free, but I have a much better sense of what it takes to keep riding," says Gul, who got curious about motorcycles in college in Patiala. She was riding a Kinetic



WITH THE OTHER HALF (Clockwise from top left) Anjaly Rajan; Shivani (Sia) Chauhan; Dr Neharika Yadav; Gul Panag (From far left) Maral Yazarloo-Patrick; Leena Reddy; Anita Krishnan

Honda when a cousin left his Bullet 350 in their garage and asked her to start it now and then, so the battery wouldn't die. Before long, she was riding it to college.

To her, such biker communities are important. "When a woman sees other women riding, she can picture herself doing it too. The community also gives riders a place to share knowledge and encourage one another. I look forward to the day when 'rider' is enough of a description for any of us. Until then, support matters," she says.

The Tvarra Research Centre's India Women Rider Safety & Mobility Report 2026 — a survey of 1,018 women across India, including 542 regular riders — found that 72.7 per cent of women riders report that larger vehicles disregard them, cutting in, crowding, and overtaking without room.

It is also why Maral does not want people

to immediately recognise that she is a woman rider. Being in full gear is non-negotiable for her, both for road safety and protection as a woman.

From the saddle to the handlebar

Then there is literally, the art of motorcycle maintenance that women bikers stay mindful of. For Hyderabad-based Leena Reddy, a banker, who bought a Royal Enfield Hunter 350, two years ago, after her second pregnancy, it was about navigating the 40km trip to work daily. She now teaches women to ride geared motorcycles and lift their own bikes, across Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, through her club, SheMoto. Her sons are proud of her. The elder one, 10, tells everyone at the gym that his mother is a biker and rides with other women. He wants to learn to ride, too, she says, but only after he turns 18.

"I had just learned to ride Rishi's BMW F650 Funduro. It felt taller and heavier, and I dropped it more than once. This was back in 1999. What stays with me is learning to pick it up myself. I couldn't just heave it upright. I had to stop, work out the technique, use my legs and take my time. The first time I managed it unaided, I felt ridiculously pleased with myself. Then I got back on and rode. I suppose that bike taught me that dropping a motorcycle doesn't have to be the end of the ride. You work out what happened, get it back on its wheels, and carry on," says Gul.

But what happens when a bike breaks down in the middle of the road? Most bikers know how to handle the basics, like punctures, battery problems or chain-related concerns. Some, like Kalyani, carry toolkits, besides keeping contacts of nearby service centres handy. "Some bikers and locals have even offered help or invited us to stay with them. For me, that is one of the most beautiful parts of our journey," she says.

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THE WORD
THIS WEEK

US National Book Awards 2026:
Five titles to read from this year's longest

THE UNITED STATES' National Book Foundation has announced its 2026 longest for fiction, non-fiction, poetry, translated literature and young people's literature. Winners will be honoured in New York on November 18, at a ceremony where *The Satanic Verses* author Salman Rushdie will receive the Medal for Distinguished Contribution to American Letters, one of American publishing's top lifetime honours. His memoir *Knife*, about the 2022 attack that blinded him in one eye, was also a finalist in 2024. It has since been adapted into a documentary. Here are our recommendations, one from each category.

WHAT I READ
THIS WEEK

Stranger
in a Strange
Land

Mirza Waheed's *Maryam & Son* looks at the precarious relationship between an immigrant and the state through the story of a grieving mother

Sukhmani Malik

MONTHS INTO her 20-year-old son's disappearance on a random Tuesday morning, Maryam implores one of the officers in charge of her son Dilawar's case, to shift his gaze. She has been pleading for assistance but has been met only with suspicion and surveillance by the London authorities who started investigating her son — and in some ways, Maryam — for connections to the Islamic State. She asks the officer, "Do you know what it means to have a missing son? Do you know what a knock on the door does to me?"

This frames the central tension in Mirza Waheed's *Maryam & Son*. A mother who doesn't know how to grieve her son, Maryam is surrounded by people who offer her shrugged indifference at best and accusation at worst; the world seems to be closing in on her, and there is little she can do about it. With that premise, in the painful in-between that Maryam's life has become, Waheed makes readers confront the price of innocence denied, trust stolen, and grief poisoned to the point of racial profiling, state surveillance and imperial policy.

While placed firmly inside the home, the book has everything to do with the politics of today. It tells the story of an impact: When otherness, stereotypes and impunity for the powerful converge, the fallout for the othered can be catastrophic. Contemporary European politics is obsessed with the Muslim immigrant and her assumed crimes, fuelling a machinery that discriminates at home, and invades outside. At a time when domestic politics in the

West is consumed by rhetoric and headlines announce the arrival of Western forces and funding in foreign countries, Maryam's story comes as a plea, a window into the homes such politics and policies seek to overtake and destroy.

Waheed says these characters "have every right to be normal". But do they? Even before Dilly goes missing, the reader can see the compromises he and his family make as immigrants and the vilified religious minority: What they allow themselves to say, think, expect,

and how they negotiate their space even as they hold onto the belief that they belong. Maryam, who was brought to the UK as a baby, wonders at one point if her fate would have been different had she been born in the country.

Also, at the centre of the novel is memory. Readers often experience the world Waheed has built through memories; they provide the context for loss and the fodder for doubt. Maryam starts soaking in nostalgia almost as a compulsive habit; she is caught between her past and present, struggling to spot how she missed this about her son. The book is an exercise in holding your breath, yearning and praying. In execution, though, the story slows too much at several points. Sometimes, the repetition of the mundane fails to serve its function.

But in this tale that reads as a mother's nightmare coming to life, there are also flashes of levity, helmed by affection, familiarity and community. The characters carry themselves in all the complexity they deserve; you can see in them and their relationships, tea-time conversations with your own parents, aunts, children, sisters. Because the mundane is felt so viscerally, so is the grief of their extraordinary circumstances.

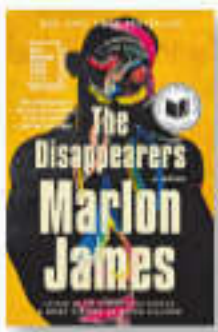
But Maryam does much more than grieve her son and her husband, whom she lost years ago. She finds herself. She rediscovers the pleasures of being more than the mother, and explores the freedom of being left behind by the men in her life.

Her relationship with Julian Chapman, the family liaison assigned to her son's case, has a constant tussle with trust even as it embodies comfort for both parties. In many ways, it reflects the relationship between a faithful immigrant and a suspicious state.

In the aftermath, dealing with tragedy and loss, facing endless possibilities, we leave Maryam in a place of hope: of a new life, of a new door, and of a new feeling when someone knocks on it. For readers condemned to live in and around the tragedies of the non-fiction world of today, that hope can be a saving grace.

The Disappears
Marlon James (Fiction)

THE BOOKER-winning author takes us to 1988, where eight men are rehearsing Jamaica's first gay play. Seeing this as a provocation, a homophobic mob kills one of them. Years later, a survivor sets out to find what became of the rest of them in the aftermath of the attack. James has said the novel "is based on a violent incident that was rumoured to have happened but was never proven." The novel also made the 2026 Booker Prize shortlist.



The Midnight Special: The Secret Prison History of American Music

Colin Asher
WHAT DO Lead Belly, Johnny Cash, Ike White and Tupac Shakur have in common? They are all musicians whose careers were shaped by the criminal justice system. In *The Midnight Special*, Colin Asher examines how incarceration affected their music, pointing out that while White artists were able to cash in on their notoriety, it wasn't the same for Black artists.



Tree of Knowledge

Victoria Chang

WHEN MIN-HUI'S husband vanishes pursuing a business deal in China, she moves to Beijing. As she waits for answers, she writes a novel about a young Qing emperor trapped in the Forbidden City, spellbound by a pirate merchant's tales of Taiwanese seas. Through Min-Hui's tales, Ping Lu explores the universal hunger for freedom. Jeremy Tiang, longlisted for the International Booker Prize, has translated it.



To the East of the East

Ping Lu

WHEN MIN-HUI'S husband vanishes pursuing a business deal in China, she moves to Beijing. As she waits for answers, she writes a novel about a young Qing emperor trapped in the Forbidden City, spellbound by a pirate merchant's tales of Taiwanese seas. Through Min-Hui's tales, Ping Lu explores the universal hunger for freedom. Jeremy Tiang, longlisted for the International Booker Prize, has translated it.



Life on the Moon

Matthew Swanson and Robbi Behr

Life on the Moon follows 12-year-old Leo, who gets the opportunity to join the first Moon colony. But after his family lands, his dad is sent on a mission and never returns. Authorities claim the mission never existed. Determined to find him, Leo explores the colony and discovers a landscape teeming with extraordinary creatures, baffling behaviours, and strange beliefs.

AISHWARYA KHOSLA



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For Select Palates Only

Featuring essays by economists, artists, entrepreneurs and travel writers,
Taste is a product of indulgence, even as it attempts to be a critic of it

Aishwarya Khosla

IN INDIA, Rs 15,000 can buy a decent phone, a weekend in Goa or a box-set of two volumes of cultural criticism that takes the reader down a rabbit hole, a literary Russian nesting doll. Inside *Taste*, edited by journalist Lakshmi Chaudhry, CEO of Splainer Media and co-founder of *Firstpost*, one finds essays on the politics of taste but also pages that unfold sideways or upwards into larger-than-life Bollywood posters, maps, postcards from a bygone world and a sleeve of coloured lenses.

Graphic designer Kriti Monga designed the first volume; designer Tania Singh Khosla and her studio, TSK Design, designed the second.

Dismissing *Taste* as a coffee-table book that happens to contain essays would be a mistake. It is a book about who gets to exercise cultural judgement and who is denied it.

The first volume opens with 'Immortal

Beloveds' by Srinath Perur — author of the travelogue, *If It's Monday It Must Be Madurai* — a joyful account of Boney M's Indian afterlife.

Nobel laureate economist Abhijit Banerjee hosts a roundtable on the homogenisation of Indian food and the loss of regional traditions with four chefs: Garima Arora of the Michelin-starred Gaa in Bangkok, Bengaluru restaurateur Manu Chandra, Prateek Sadhu of Masque and Naar and Thomas Zacharias, founder of The Locavore.

Novelist and essayist Aatish Taseer dissects the death of the Delhi drawing room and the rise of the "Antilia effect", a hotel-like luxury that severs the bond between a person and their home. Simran Lal, co-founder of the lifestyle brand Nicobar, writes an unexpectedly moving ode to the spittoon, an object "meant for bodily waste" that Indian artisans turned into a canvas for "creativity, innovation and aesthetic refinement."

Artist Subodh Gupta offers a visceral

A PLATEFUL
Abhijit Banerjee and chefs Garima Arora, Manu Chandra, Prateek Sadhu and Thomas Zacharias, reimagined at one table for the book's 'Plating India' conversation

meditation on cow dung. His mother asked him to fetch it for daily rituals, and it was "sacred: used to cleanse our home, cook our food, anchor our prayers."

Novelist Meenakshi Reddy Madhavan's "The Solo Traveller" is a wry account of a DDLJ-themed bus tour through Switzerland, where the Alps become a pilgrimage for Bollywood fans. Photographer Sujata Setia, whose project 'A Thousand Cuts' examines domestic abuse, asks why art made from the survivor's gaze is deemed unpalatable by the market.

MacArthur-winning artist Shahzia Sikander recounts the beheading of her sculpture 'Witness' at the University of Houston, calling it "tasteless moral theatre." Conceptual artist Mithu Sen takes her title from pao bhaji, and uses it to question highbrow taste itself.

Vivek Shanbhag, the Kannada writer behind *Ghachar Ghochar*, and *The New Yorker* critic Parul Sehgal discuss how translation works and how a new tongue alters who we are.

Where do we go
from here?

Parini Shroff on her new novel *Some People*, ditching saintly heroines and embracing mess in relationships

Paromita Chakrabarti

THERE IS a particular kind of dread that comes with being trapped somewhere with a person you would rather avoid. It is this premise — seven days, two reluctant companions, nowhere to go — that powers Parini Shroff's new novel, *Some People*, in which a mother-in-law and son-in-law who share little beyond their love for the same woman are forced into each other's company.

Shroff's 2023 debut, *The Bandit Queens* — a blackly comic tale of village wives in rural India turning the tables on their husbands — was long-listed for the Women's Prize for Fiction, drawing comparisons to Aravind Adiga's *The White Tiger* for the way it laid bare the darker undercurrents of contemporary Indian society beneath its comedy. *Some People* consolidates that promise and sets her up as a writer unafraid to let humour do serious work. "Nathan and Malti differ on so many fronts: age, gender, race, upbringing, language, culture. I

wanted to thrust two disparate people in a pressure cooker and make them actually talk to each other. I knew from the onset that they would hide behind their differences but also that these were misdirects to avoid the work of actually interfacing with someone who doesn't agree with you, and then realising that that disagreement does not automatically make them a villain," Shroff, 41, says.

Family, in the novel, is a slippery thing, a constant tussle between the ones we choose and the one we inherit. Can the two ever truly come together? Shroff's answer runs through Kavya, the daughter and wife who orbits between her mother Malti and her husband Nathan, smoothing over a friction neither of them will name. Shroff calls her the embodiment of the "eldest daughter maintaining the peace," and it is Kavya's removal from the equation that sets the

novel in motion. Without her to mediate, Shroff explains, "Nathan and Malti must reckon with each other. The only thing binding them are their ties to Kavya, and even those are fraying." What follows is less a reconciliation than a reckoning: two people realising "they never really knew each other — or bothered to." Kavya, Shroff says, is "a load-bearing corner I yanked out so the entire artifice above could wobble and fall" — leaving her mother and husband to have the "messy" conversations that never would have happened otherwise.

That interest in mess — in characters who are undignified, contradictory, still figuring themselves out — runs through Shroff's fiction more broadly, and she is candid about wanting to push back against tidier depictions of South Asian women in particular. "People are complicated, but for so long South Asians, women especially, are portrayed as long-suffering saints. I'm far more interested in flailing and failing humans and I hope readers are, too. We won't all see ourselves in saints, but we can certainly identify and empathise with a character who tries and just can't seem to get it

FAMILY WOMAN
Parini Shroff



SOME PEOPLE
PARINI SHROFF
HarperCollins
300 pages
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Sandip Roy

THE UTTAM Kumar centenary celebrations in Kolkata often felt more like an Uttam Kumar carnival. There were not just film screenings, panel discussions and exhibitions, the usual fare for such occasions but Nandan, the West Bengal government's film complex, also had a booth where you could bellow "I love Uttam Kumar" and see if the decibel-level of your love was worthy of an Uttam Kumar badge. There were *Mahanayak-Mahanayika* lookalike contests where couples were encouraged to come dressed as the great hero and his heroines. One of Kolkata's current leading actresses flaunted an Uttam Kumar print sari. A man in a thin *aaddi* cotton kurta and dhoti posed as a "living statue" of Uttam Kumar. He didn't really look like the *Mahanayak* but that did not deter selfie-seekers. "Anyway no one can look like Uttam Kumar," a friend reasoned. "That's why Uttam Kumar is Uttam Kumar."

Uttam Kumar is the greatest film star Bengal has ever produced but director Srijit Mukherji said at the Kolkata Literary Meet this year that he has long ceased to be a "matinee idol and romantic hero" and become instead a "cultural emblem of Bengaliness". "I think he has become a bit like the Howrah Bridge," quipped Mukherjee, "Or the rasagolla."

Mukherji himself made a film called *Oti Uttam* (2024), a fantasy tribute to the megastar where a researcher tries to resurrect Uttam Kumar via planchette.

But it still begs the question whether the euphoria about Uttam Kumar is just eternal Bengali nostalgia about lost Bengali exceptionalism. Or perhaps it's the newly elected BJP government in West Bengal trying to establish their Bengali bona fides through the charisma of a man whose death in 1980 brought Kolkata to a standstill. There is probably some truth to both but neither explains fully the allure of the man. Even my mother braved surging crowds to watch his funeral cortege go past.

Uttam Kumar was in some ways an unlikely superstar. His early films flopped so resoundingly he was dubbed Flop Master General. When the romantic pairing with Suchitra Sen clicked, he became a star but the adulation didn't necessarily mean respect. Satyajit Ray, India's most internationally renowned director, favoured Soumitra Chatterjee for his films. "Uttam was certainly a star in the true Hollywood sense of the term," Ray wrote in his obituary. "The question was: was he also an actor?" When he cast Uttam Kumar after his own film *Kapurush-o-Mahapurush* (1965) failed at the box office, he said fellow director Mrinal Sen scoffed "Now he has sunk to the level of using a matinee idol!"

Uttam Kumar's own forays outside Bengal were decidedly mixed. The bilingual *Amanush* (1975) was a hit but the much touted *Chhoti Si Mulaqat* (1967) produced by Uttam Kumar himself flopped. His role in Manmohan Desai's *Desh Premee* (1982) was hardly a star turn. He died during the making of the film and lore has it Amitabh Bachchan's hairdresser had to fill in for him. Diehard fans claimed Mumbai's big shots sabotaged his Hindi films but it also makes one wonder if, unlike the rasagolla, Uttam Kumar did not really translate across borders.

Film studies scholar Sanjoy Mukhopadhyay argued at the Kolkata Literary Meet that history helped create Uttam Kumar. In 1952 India had its first general election. That was also the year Uttam Kumar had his first hit with *Basu Paribar*. "For the first time in Bangla cinema we discovered a commoner, a Ram, a Shyam, a Jadu or Uttam,

a next-door neighbour who could solve anything," said Mukhopadhyay. He was the ultimate feel-good story, a man from humble beginnings with a Port Trust job (one can still see his cashier's office receipt at the Port Trust museum) who proved a commoner could succeed in both life and love. A generation holding out for a hero had finally found one.

It certainly helped that he had a billion-

For the first time in Bangla cinema, we discovered a commoner, a Ram, a Shyam, a Jadu, an Uttam, a next-door neighbour who could solve anything

SANJOY MUKHOPADHYAY

Film studies scholar

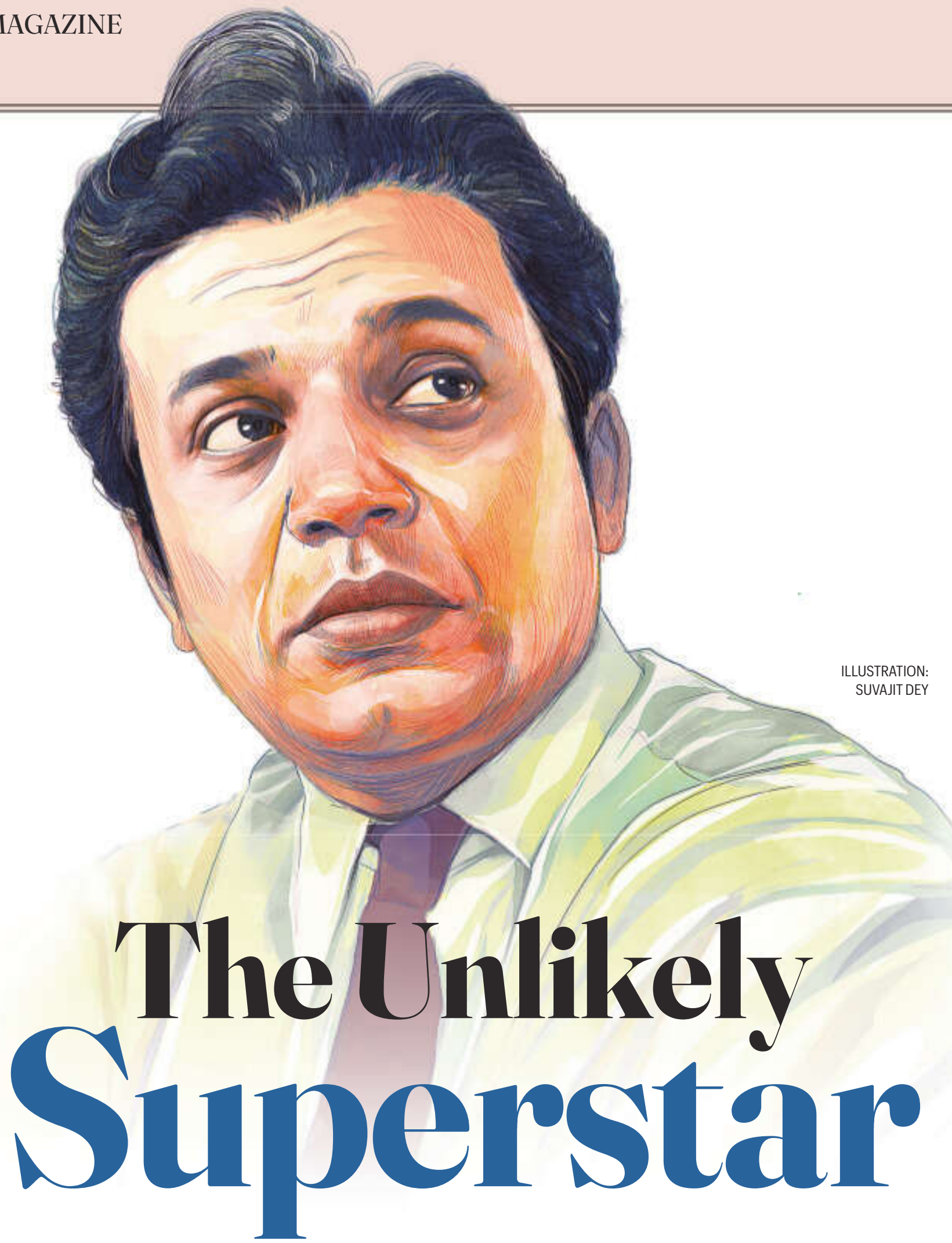


ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

The Unlikely Superstar

Once dubbed Flop Master General, he became a star in Bengal who made fans forget the world and its problems. In his centenary year, unpacking Uttam Kumar's appeal



EXPRESS ARCHIVE

WORKED LIKE A CHARM
(Clockwise from top) Uttam Kumar; with Satyajit Ray; with Suchitra Sen in *Harano Sur*; with Sharmila Tagore in *Anand Ashram*

watt smile that lit up his eyes. A smile that made you forget the world, his fans said. That world was in turmoil. Bengal was struggling with refugees, uprisings against food shortages and striking teachers demanding better pay. But Uttam Kumar and Suchitra Sen could reassure their audiences: "*Neer chhoto kshati nei akashta toh boro*" (The nest is small, but it doesn't matter, the sky is vast).

This is not to say he wasn't a consummate actor. Even Ray admitted he had the "rare virtues of grace, spontaneity and confidence", a combination not easy to come by. Famously while filming Ray's *Nayak* (1966), Uttam Kumar, playing a version of himself, prepared to sign an autograph. Then he realised the ink had dried in the pen. Ray was about to call 'cut' but Uttam casually shook the pen, dipped it in a glass of water, and continued signing, never breaking from his dialogue. That impressed Ray to no end.

When one watches an Uttam Kumar film now, one cannot but marvel at what he does even when he is not the one delivering the dialogue. As Suchitra Sen sings *Tumi je amaar in Harano Sur* (1957), he lies perfectly still, head on her lap, almost unblinking in his gaze. He cedes her the entire spotlight but his own stillness renders the song hypnotic. Soumitra Chatterjee, as quoted in Sanghamitra Chakraborty's biography *Soumitra Chatterjee and His World* (Penguin, 2025), said while their acting styles were different, he learned many "small elements of craft (from him), such as how to hold a pause." "Can you think of Bengali films without Uttam Kumar?" wondered Chatterjee.

Now almost 50 years after his death, we live in a world of Uttam Kumar what-ifs. Would an older Uttam Kumar have felt freer to deglamorise himself? Could his star power have stalled the decline of the Bengali film industry in the 1990s and 2000s? What if he had acted with Soumitra Chatterjee in a Bengali stage version of Laurence Olivier and Michael Caine's *Sleuth* (1972)? Or Satyajit Ray had been able to make *Ghare Baire* (1984) with the dream cast of Uttam Kumar, Soumitra Chatterjee and Suchitra Sen? If Uttam Kumar had accepted Raj Kapoor's offer to act in *Sangam* (1964), could he have become a pan-Indian *Mahanayak*? We will never know the answers. But my mother would console herself by repeating the story of how Rajesh Khanna apparently saw Uttam Kumar in *Nishipadma* (1970) umpteen times but admitted he couldn't match up to his performance when he took on that role of a Bengali babu in his Hindi version *Amar Prem* (1972).

Perhaps the enduring appeal of Uttam Kumar was that in a state that often felt it was out of step with the rest of the country, whose capital had been dismissed as a "dying city", he remained a reassuring talisman of good taste, a consummate *bhadralok* even when playing a murderer.

It's a quality he still possesses. Some of his films may have aged but he has not. At the centennial celebrations, today's stars tried to recreate his magical moments through song and dance. Devoid of his easy charm, they seemed more like cardboard cutouts than the actual cutouts of Uttam Kumar outside. Because when you looked at those, I swear, the man, hands akimbo, seemed to be looking at you and smiling. And for a moment you could still forget the world.

Sandip Roy is the author of *Chapal Rani*, the Last Queen of Bengal and *Don't Let Him Know*



PHOTOS: SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

'Producing is all about hustle'

At a masterclass for Screen Academy in Mumbai, Oscar-winning producer Guneet Monga spoke on the power of hustle and how producing isn't confined only to money

Devansh Sharma

PRODUCING IS all about hustle. Hustling is not a bad thing," said two-time Oscar-winning Indian producer Guneet Monga Kapoor, while asking film students at Whistling Woods International, Mumbai, to "own your hustle". She was speaking at a masterclass organised by Screen Academy, a non-profit initiative launched by The Indian Express Group to identify, support, and mentor the next generation of filmmakers as well as creative voices in India. Guneet won the Academy Awards for co-producing short documentary *Period. End of Sentence.* in 2019, and for backing documentary feature *The Elephant Whispers* (2023). She has more than 30 films to the credit of her production house, Sikhya Entertainment.

"Given in India we largely come from family-run businesses, there's an understanding that the one who puts in the money is the producer," said Guneet, before reminding the students that she doesn't come from money. As a child, she lived with her parents in the suburbs of Delhi in a rented apartment with Rs 5,000 as rent. Even after relocating to Mumbai after some progress in her production career, she shared an apartment with five other girls. "Money for survival was also tough, forget money for investment."

"I sit in front of you here after two decades with the resume I have and with a global footprint because I understand what

producing is," said Guneet. "A producer needs to find solutions. Your locations will always not be available. You'll always lose your sun. You'll never get that magic shot that you wanted to. Life will always be without lunch breaks. It won't be ideal. But a producer would be like, 'What best can we make of this', given all the odds are stacked against you!" she said.

After growing slowly within the production departments of international films shot in India, Guneet decided at 21 that it was time to be a producer. She asked a neighbour in Delhi to invest in making a film, and put that money in Subhash Kapoor's 2007 sports drama, *Say Salaam India*. An underdog story that revolved around cricket, it was released at what would conventionally be the most appropriate time — during the ICC World Cup tournament. However, as soon as India was eliminated from the race to the finish, theatre owners also wanted the cricket film out of the cinemas. But that didn't stop Guneet from giving up on her hustle. She resigned from her high-paying job of a line producer on *Ghajini* (2008), and relocated to Delhi in order to earn back the lost money. She convinced the principal of her school to send a batch of students for a special screening, earning Rs 40,000 from the attempt. Once the students took to the film, she began pitching to other schools. That unique self-distribution model eventually led to her earning back all the money through over 350 shows. Guneet, who won critical acclaim for *The Lunchbox* (2013)

says, "My childhood was all about how to survive. So, when 10 doors are shut in your face, then you figure out what next."

LIFE WITHOUT BREAKS

(Left) Guneet Monga; with Screen Fellows, students who have received scholarships from Screen Academy



A Second Shot

After being rejected, a nudge from her brother and a second attempt changed the course for 21-year-old Sneha Kumari who plays Phoolan Devi in Richie Mehta's recent film

Alaka Sahani

WHEN JHANSI-based Sneha Kumari first auditioned for the role of Phoolan Devi in *Phoolan*, directed and co-written by Richie Mehta, she was rejected. Nearly a month later, goaded by her brother, she performed the lines given to her again, taped the audition and sent it.

This time, Sneha was selected to attend a workshop in Mumbai, along with five others who were also being considered for the part. Though her family was not very open to the idea of their daughter pursuing acting, Sneha, accompanied by her sister-in-law and supported by her brother, attended the month-long workshop under the supervision of casting director Mukesh Chhabra. She, however, did not tell her parents about the role she was eyeing.

Soon after, she bagged the role. But getting ready to play Phoolan required intensive preparation, including combat training. Apart from the physical preparation, she watched interviews of Phoolan Devi and read the bandit-turned-parliamentarian's autobiography, *I, Phoolan Devi: The Autobiography of India's Bandit Queen* (1996), and worked on internalising the script.

"After I read the script and Phoolan Devi's autobiography, I got to know more about her. Since it was in her words, after you read each chapter, you wonder about her life. You also feel sad that she had to undergo all this at a very young age," says the 22-year-old actor.

Even after all the preparation, Sneha was nervous before the shooting began. "But Richie sir asked me not to overthink. He asked me to imagine how I would respond if I had to face what she encountered," says Sneha, who is a second-year student at Madhya Pradesh Natya Vidyalaya.

While Phoolan marks Sneha's big-screen debut, she has been acting in street plays and on stage under the guidance of her elder brother, Pushpendra Singh, for several years. She was selected for Bharatendu Natya Academy in Lucknow, where she further refined her craft. Her theatre



CLOSE TO THE GROUND

(Far left) Sneha Kumari as Phoolan Devi; stills from the film

work includes plays such as *Lanchhan*, *Prem Light*, *Kitni Nirbhaya*, *Dastak* and *Andha Yug*. She singles out Lanchhan, based on a story by Munshi Premchand, as one of her favourites.

Mehta says they selected Sneha because "she embodied the spirit" of what they were looking for. "She had the energy, the youthfulness... Sneha comes from the region. She has more knowledge of that part of the world than I ever will. So, I also had to rely on her. That was one of the reasons I wanted to collaborate with her," says Mehta.

Born in 1963 in a small village in Uttar Pradesh, Phoolan Devi rose to prominence in the early 1980s after spending several years as a bandit in the ravines of the Chambal valley. She surrendered in 1983 and spent 11 years in prison. Following her release in 1994, she entered public life and was elected twice as a Member of Parliament from Mirzapur, Uttar Pradesh. In 2001, she was killed outside her residence in New Delhi.

Phoolan, which is an Amazon MGM Studios film and produced by Namah Pictures, focuses on a 48-hour siege in which 17-year-

old Phoolan Devi and a member of her group must outsmart the Indian police. The sequences are physically and mentally demanding. However, Sneha found considerable support from her co-actors, including Anurag Thakur, Aakash Dahiya and Prateek Pachori, while filming these scenes.

Before Sneha began shooting for the film, which involved a long schedule, she finally told her family that she had been cast as Phoolan Devi. When her debut film premiered at the recent Toronto International Film Festival, her parents couldn't have been happier.

The Millets Mama

After reinventing Parsi food, chef Anahita Dhondy is now making millets cool



Heena Khandelwal

FOR THE longest time, chef Anahita Dhondy has been associated with Parsi food. Born into a Parsi family, she was the founding chef of SodaBottleOpenerWala (SBOW) when it opened in 2013 and left as chef-partner in 2021. Her first book, *The Parsi Kitchen: A Memoir of Food and Memory*, saw her sharing family anecdotes and recipes like fried boomla and ravo. So when we reach out and she says she wants to make ragi tacos with mushroom filling, we are surprised. But millets are not new for 36-year-old Dhondy. She was introduced to the grain a decade ago by Pallavi Upadhyaya, who runs the organisation Millets for Health. “She walked me through the basics: how to clean them, whether to use them as flour or whole grain, how long to soak and wash them and how to cook them. Once I had the fundamentals, I could bring my own creativity as a chef,” recalls Dhondy, who did an entire millet menu in SBOW in 2015. “A full sit-down, eight-course menu, which no one had done at that point. After that, I started working millets into different dishes at the res-

taurant — sneaking them in, for instance, in place of *rava* for a crust.”

Early September, when we meet Dhondy, she has her hands full. Pregnant with her second child, she tends to her 20-month-old son Avram, even as she runs the house and creates content for social media, that is, in between promotions for her second book, *The Grain Kitchen*. Yet, she is fully present the minute we start.

Cooking, she tells us, happened naturally. Her mother, Nilufer Dhondy, has been a home chef and baker for 36 years. Dhondy started cooking at 10. Her earliest food memory, at three or four, is licking the batter off the bowl when her mother baked a chocolate cake. Her mother had once wanted to attend culinary school but stayed home to raise Dhondy and her brother, so the kitchen became her world, recalls the chef.

By 14, Dhondy was sure of becoming a chef and when she told her parents, they were taken aback. Not because they disapproved of her choice but simply because they knew of only three or four women chefs. They supported her anyway.

After Institute of Hotel Management, Aurangabad, a working year at Taj Mansingh, Delhi, shaped her path: A senior chef moved her from the bakery to the hot kitchen, telling her that to run a kitchen she had to be thrown into the deep end. At Le Cordon Bleu in London, she chose the full cuisine and pastry course over bakery alone. But



IT'S NEVER A WRAP

(left) Chef Anahita Dhondy kneading the taco dough; a disassembled ragi taco; (below) ragi taco



ABHINAV SAHA

Ragi Taco

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup ragi flour
- 1 cup whole wheat flour, 1 tbsp ghee
- 1 tsp salt
- ½ cup hot water or as required
- 1 cup mixed mushrooms (diced/sliced)
- 1 tbsp chopped garlic
- 1 tbsp butter, a little oil, salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Mix the ragi flour, whole wheat flour and salt. Add the ghee and slowly add hot water to knead into a dough. Rest for 15 minutes. Divide into small portions, roll into rotis and cook on a hot tava. Finish directly over the flame
2. For the mushrooms, heat the butter and oil in a pan. Add the garlic and sauté. Add the mushrooms and cook. Season with salt and pepper.
3. Assemble the tacos with the mushrooms and toppings of your choice, such as garlic yoghurt dip and tomato salsa, or just some herbs. Serve hot.

London did not deliver the career she had hoped for: No one would sponsor a visa, and she returned to India in 2013.

Then, she met AD Singh, whom she had approached for a job at Olive, Delhi. Learning she was Parsi, he told her about a café concept, and within four days she had joined the founding team. SBOW opened a couple of months later. She was 23.

Dhondy called aunts for recipes and trained a team that had never cooked Parsi food. Being older than her, they assumed she was a front-of-house face. “Only once I started cooking alongside them, morning to night, did that change,” she says. She stayed for nearly a decade, leaving in 2021 when the company moved towards regional cuisine and away from Parsi food.

Millets, meanwhile, had become a slow-burning passion. That first millet menu caught the attention of the UN's SDG2 Advocacy Hub, which invited her into The Chefs' Manifesto — a global group of chefs promoting sustainable kitchens. She has since

cooked millet dishes at the UN in New York, in California and across Europe, and started #MilletMonday on Instagram, where she shares unique recipes.

Millets have an image problem, she says, adding, “I took it upon myself to make millets cool.”

Her ragi taco is a step in that direction. She turns a roti made out of ragi flour and *atta* into a fillable taco. Mushroom was among the first fillings, because the earthiness of *nachni* pairs well with mushrooms. Her advice for the hesitant: Start with millets at breakfast or lunch, so the body has the day to use the slow-releasing energy.

DHONDY IS THE FOUNDING CHEF OF SODABOTTLE OPENERWALA... SHE CALLED AUNTS FOR RECIPES AND TRAINED A TEAM THAT HAD NEVER COOKED PARSII FOOD

That thinking runs through *The Grain Kitchen*. She initially wanted a book only on millets but her publisher HarperCollins felt that was premature. So, she widened it to grains. Its opening line calls the millet the first victim of “cancel culture”. The book also has a berry pulao, because “there was no chance anyone would let me leave without a berry pulao recipe.”

Life after SBOW has been a portfolio of projects. There have been restaurant consultancies, the latest being White Tiger in Liverpool in the UK. There is the constant FMCG research on getting more grains into baby food, including a long association with Sturp Farm. There is also Figure 8 Catering in Delhi, where she is a consulting chef. Another cookbook is in early development.

What she isn't doing is opening a restaurant, purely for personal reasons: She doesn't want a commitment that is “bigger than having a child.” She plans to revisit the idea once her children are in school. For now, it's books, content and consultancies, plus a weekly roti wrap, with the filling swapped to suit whoever is at the table.



Neil Patil

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There is a scene in ‘The Secret Life of Walter Mitty’ that I came across on Instagram recently. Sean O’Connell, the photographer character played by Sean Penn, has spent months in the Himalayas chasing a single shot of an elusive snow leopard, a creature so rare and so shy that most photographers never see one in their lifetime. And then, finally, it appears. Right there in his viewfinder. The shot he has been waiting for his entire career. He does not take it.

Walter, watching beside him, is baffled. Why not? Why chase something for months and then let it go the moment it arrives? And O’Connell says something legendary in that moment. That when he finds something he loves, he does not like to get distracted by the camera. He just wants to stay in the moment. Let it linger. Right there. Right here.

I was in my twenties when I first watched that scene, and I remember thinking it was a nice piece of writing. A little too neat, maybe. The kind of line that sounds profound in a cinema and slightly performative once you leave. I did not understand it then, but I understand it now, a full 13 years later.

The Years of Trying to Capture Everything

For a long time, I photographed everything. I remember returning from a trip to Japan once, having clicked 12,000 photographs across eight days. Every sunset got a picture. Every meal got a picture, sometimes several, until I found the angle that did it justice. Every mountain, every coastline, every strange and beautiful thing I encountered, I reached for my phone or my camera before I had even finished processing what I was looking at.

I do not think this was vanity, exactly. I think it came from a fear of forgetting. Travel moves fast, and memory is unreliable, and a photograph felt like insurance against the version of yourself ten years from now who cannot quite recall the colour of the sky over Bordeaux or the

I Have Stopped Trying to Photograph

Those moments belong entirely to me, unmediated, unedited, unshared. They exist only in memory, which means they exist only as I experienced them...

exact shade of turquoise in a Tasmanian bay. If I did not capture it, I reasoned, I might lose it entirely.

And there is truth in that. I have thousands of photographs that have brought memories rushing back years later, moments I would genuinely have forgotten without the image to jog them loose. Photography, done well, is a gift to your future self.

But somewhere along the way, I noticed something else happening. Certain moments started to feel wrong to photograph. They felt wrong because reaching for the phone would have meant leaving the moment to go and capture it, and something in me understood, instinctively, that the leaving would cost more than the capturing was worth.

The Sunrise in Ladakh

I remember one clearly. We were in Ladakh, up before dawn, driving towards a point where we had been told the sunrise over the mountains was worth the early start. We got there in the dark, the cold biting through every layer we had on, and we waited.

And then the light started to change. Slowly, the way it does at altitude, where the sky seems to consider its options before committing to colour. The peaks went from black to grey to a deep blue-violet, and then the first orange line appeared along the ridge, and within minutes the entire range was lit gold. My younger self would have immediately reached for that phone in my pocket, but this time I did not take it out.

I do not fully know why, even now. Some part of me understood that the moment I looked at that sunrise through a four-inch screen instead of my own eyes, I would be watching a slightly worse, slightly smaller version of what was actually happening in front of me. And that once I started composing the shot, adjusting the exposure, deciding whether to include the foreground rocks or crop them out, I would no longer be a person watching a sunrise. I would be a person doing a small piece of work, with a sunrise as the raw material.

Years later, I do not have a single photograph of that sunrise. And it remains one of the most vivid memories I have of that entire trip. More vivid, if I am honest, than moments I photographed extensively and now barely remember beyond the images themselves.



The Conversation in Hoi An

The second one is different. And this one is about a person.

We were in Hoi An, and I had struck up a conversation with an elderly woman running a small noodle stall. With language as a barrier, this was the kind of conversation that happens entirely through gesture and goodwill. She had corrected my attempt at ordering in Vietnamese three times, laughing harder each time, and by the end she was sitting across from me, showing me photographs of her grandchildren on an old phone, and I was showing her photographs of my travels through the country.

There was a moment, near the end of that exchange, where I genuinely considered asking if I could take a photograph of her and her food stall. And I did not. Something about asking felt like it would turn a real, spontaneous human exchange into a piece of content. Into proof. Into something for later rather than something for now. I wanted, for once, to let an interaction with a stranger exist only in the space where it happened, without needing to survive as evidence.

I think about that conversation sometimes. I do not have a photograph. I have the memory of her stall, that conversation, and that feels, strangely, like more than a photograph would have given me.

What O’Connell Understood

I think what that scene in Walter Mitty is really about is not photography at all. It is about the difference between experiencing something and collecting it.

A camera, even a brilliant one, does something specific to your attention. It asks you to step slightly outside the moment in order to frame it. You become, for a few seconds, an observer of the thing rather than a participant in it. Most of the time, this trade-off is worth it. You get a photograph, and the cost to your presence is small. A quick photo of a meal, a landmark, a family group shot, none of that meaningfully pulls you out of the experience.

But some moments are too fragile for that trade. The sunrise that is changing every thirty seconds. The conversation that only works because both people are fully present. The silence in a monastery, the first sight of a mountain range, the specific quality of light at a specific second that will never happen in exactly that way again. For these, the act of reaching for a camera does not just interrupt the moment, it changes what the moment is. You stop being someone the sunrise is happening to. You become someone documenting a sunrise happening to someone else, and that someone else used to be you.

O’Connell had spent months waiting for the snow leopard. He understood something that took me years of travel to learn: sometimes the whole point of chasing something extraordinary is to be fully present for it when it arrives, not to walk away with a record of it. The photograph and the moment are not the same thing, and sometimes you genuinely have to choose.

What I Have Stopped Doing

These days, I still photograph plenty. My travels with Heta and our two kids.

The obligatory landmark photos, because they are fun and they are easy and there is no real cost to taking them.

But I have stopped photographing everything. I have learned to recognise the moments that ask to be left alone, the ones where I can feel, almost physically, that reaching for a phone would be a kind of betrayal of what is actually happening. A particular silence. A particular light. A conversation that only works if both people stay in it completely.

I do not have photographs of some of the best moments of my travelling life. I used to think that was a loss. I have come to think it is the opposite. Those moments belong entirely to me, unmediated, unedited, unshared. They exist only in memory, which means they exist only as I experienced them, not as I later chose to frame them.

Sean O’Connell let the snow leopard go and kept the moment. I think, more and more, that is the better trade.

Know the Unknown

Ever since we launched flight bookings on Veena World, I have been falling down rabbit holes about what is happening on the other side of that window seat. This week, thinking back to that sunrise in Ladakh, I found something that changes how I look at the sky whenever two planes cross in the same frame.

The next time you are looking out a window and another aircraft passes in the opposite direction, look closely. Chances are the two of you are not sharing an altitude, even though your eye cannot tell the difference from a distance.

There is a rule that governs almost

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every commercial flight in the sky, and most passengers go their entire lives without knowing it exists. Pilots have a mnemonic for it: East is Odd, West is Even. Any aircraft heading broadly east, anywhere from due north round through east to due south, cruises at an odd flight level, say 33,000 feet or 35,000 feet. Any aircraft heading broadly west, from due south round through west back to due north, cruises at an even flight level, say 32,000 feet or 34,000 feet. The two are kept at least a thousand feet apart, sometimes two thousand, depending on where in the world you are flying.

It sounds like a small technicality, but it is one of the reasons a corridor as busy as Mumbai to Delhi does not turn into chaos. Hundreds of aircraft crossing in opposite directions, every single day, sorted invisibly by the direction they happen to be pointed. No controller is nudging each aircraft into place in real time. The direction of travel decides the altitude, decided before the aircraft has even pushed back from the gate.

I find something oddly moving about this, in the same way I found something moving about that sunrise. There is an entire order sitting directly above us, silent and exact, doing its work without ever asking to be noticed. We fly through it constantly, we watch two aircraft pass each other from our window seats, and we assume it happened by luck. It happened because of a rule almost none of us will ever learn, holding two aircraft a thousand feet apart while we finish an in-flight meal without a second thought. See you next week...

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